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Business Standard

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THE MARKETS ON WEDNESDAY

			change †
Sensex	77,562.9	▲	2,946.3
Nifty	23,997.3	▲	873.7
Nifty Futures‡	24,057.8	▲	60.5
Dollar	₹92.6		₹93.0‡‡
Euro	₹108.1		₹107.5‡‡
Brent Crude ($/bbl)	93.2*		100.3‡‡
Gold (10gm)**	₹1,50,516.0	▲	₹3,322.0

† Over previous close; ‡ (December) Premium on Nifty Spot; ‡‡ Previous close; * At 9pm IST; ** Market rate exclusive of GST; Source: IBJA

Markets soar on shaky US-Iran ceasefire

RBI maintains status quo; pegs FY27 growth at 6.9% with downside risks

MNRE, FinMin in talks to launch PLI for polysilicon

नगर परिषद कार्यालय, उमरगा ता. उमरगा, जि. धाराशिव

जा.क्र. /938/2026 — ई-निविदा सूचना (5 व 6)/ 2026 — दिनांक: 07/04/2026

मुख्याधिकारी, नगरपरिषद उमरगा जि. धाराशिव यांनी लोकशाहीर अण्णाभाऊ साठे नागरी वस्ती सुधार योजना सन 2025-26 व वैशिष्ट्यपूर्ण योजना अंतर्गत उमरगा शहरात विविध ठिकाणी स्मारक विषयक व इतर कामे करणे या कामांसाठी ई-निविदा मागवित आहेत.

सदर कामाची ई-निविदा www.mahatenders.gov.in या संकेतस्थळावर प्रसिद्ध करण्यात आली आहे.

स्वा/- (रामकृष्ण जाधवर)
मुख्याधिकारी, उमरगा नगरपरिषद

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that the Certificate of **LINDE INDIA LIMITED** vide Folio Number **0200725**, Certificate Number **419842** and Distinctive Numbers 66321 to 66340; 4645148 to 4645161; 2680249 to 2680256; 3642377 to 3642381; 8253371 to 8253394; 3717058 to 3717066; 6187966 to 6187983 and 10993555 to 10993586 for **130** shares, of the Face Value of Rs.10/- each, standing in the Name (s) of **KHORSHED HORMASJEE NAOROJEE HANSON (deceased)** have been lost or mislaid and the undersigned has / have applied to the Company to issue duplicate Certificate(s) for the said shares. Any person who has any claim in respect of the said shares should write to our Registrar, **M/s. KFIN Technologies Limited, Karvy Selenium Tower B, Plot 31-32, Gachibowli, Financial District, Hyderabad – 500032** within one month from this date else the company will proceed to issue Duplicate Certificate(s).

Name of Legal Heir: CHRISTOPHER DARIUS HANSON
Date: 09.04.2026

THE TATA POWERS COMPANY LTD

Bombay House 24, Homi Mody Street, Fort, Mumbai, Maharashtra-400001

NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that the certificate[s] for the under mentioned securities having **Folio No. HSM0013282** of the Company has/have been lost/mislaid and the holder[s] of the said securities / applicant[s] has/have applied to the Company to issue duplicate certificate[s].

Any person who has a claim in respect of the said securities should lodge such claim with the Company at its Registered Office within 15 days from this date, else the Company will proceed to issue duplicate certificate[s] without further intimation.

Name of the Holder : (1) MEHUL THAKORBHAI DESAI (2) GITABEN JAYANTILAL DESAI

Certificate No.	Start Dist. No.	End Dist. No.	No. of Securities
14879	30675091	30677590	2500
40214	2374107768	2374108117	350
Total : 2850			

Place : Mumbai — Name of Applicant
Date : 09/04/2026 — DESAI MEHUL THAKORBHAI

MAHAGENCO — TENDER NOTICE : CPA – 08 – 2026

Digitally signed tenders under Two Bid System are invited for the following:

RFx No:	Description of Tender	Tender Sale Period Up to
3000067342	Procurement of Water Quality Analyzers for Condensate Polishing Unit system for Chandrapur TPS of Mahagenco.	Up to 15.00 Hrs of 19/04/2026

Contact Details: Office of Chief Engineer (CPA), Tel No.: 022 – 6985 3617 / 3618

For further details, please visit website: ***https://eprocurement.mahagenco.in/***

Chief Engineer (CPA)

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the public at large that EASY HOME FINANCE LIMITED, a Housing Finance Company duly registered with National Housing Bank under Section 29A of the National Housing Bank Act, 1987, having its registered office at 302, 3rd Floor, Savoy Chambers, Dattatray Road & V.P. Road (Extn), Santacruz (West), Mumbai – 400054, had dispatched original documents pertaining to certain borrowers/customers from Santacruz registered office of Easy Home Finance Ltd to the godown of Crown Worldwide Pvt Ltd in Haryana through Shree Maruti Courier Services ("**Courier Company**"). During the transit, the said original documents were lost/misplaced by the Courier Company.

The Courier Company has not only acknowledged that the original documents were lost/misplaced by them during transit but also has lodged a Lost Property Report bearing no.132570292600086 with Jhajjar Police Station.

The lost documents include original title deeds, facility agreements with stamp duty, mortgage deed and other related documents submitted by certain borrowers/customers of EASY HOME FINANCE LIMITED in connection with loan transactions. The customer-wise and the document-wise particulars are set out in Schedule 1 below.

If any person finds, holds, receives, or is approached in relation to any of the said documents mentioned in Schedule 1 below, such person must immediately inform EASY HOME FINANCE LIMITED Mr. Rajendra Kamble (Regional Admin Manager) at 9321979669.

The public at large, including all lenders, banks, financial institutions, authorities, sub-registrars, developers, co-operative societies, and all other persons, are hereby cautioned not to rely upon, or accept, or deal with, or create any encumbrance or third-party rights, or otherwise act upon the said documents in any manner whatsoever.

Any person dealing with, or acting upon the said documents, or entering into any agreement or understanding pursuant to the said documents shall do so entirely at such person's sole risk as to cost and consequences, and any such dealing shall be deemed to be misuse or unauthorized use of the said documents shall attract civil and/or criminal liability. Furthermore, EASY HOME FINANCE LIMITED shall not be held liable for any misuse or fraudulent use of the said documents, or any third-party claim of whatsoever nature arising out of the misuse, or fraudulent use said documents.

Schedule 1
(Customer-wise / Document-wise Particulars of Misplaced/Lost Original Documents)

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/Customer	Description of Original Documents misplaced/ lost in transit by the Courier.
1	Santosh Laxman Disale	Original Registered Agreement, Original Demand Letter, Original NOC, Possession Letter, Sanction Letter, Guarantee Deed By Individual, Facility Agreement (Lenders Copy), Mitc(Lenders Copy), Declaration, Demand Promissory Note, Letter of Continuity, Cheque Submission Form (CSF), Disbursal Request Form (DRF), Declaration-cum-Undertaking (Deposit of PDD), Acknowledgement Slip/Declaration, Application Summary Letter, NDC Check-List, Aadhar Declaration Form, Deed of Deposit of Title Deeds Form, Undertaking OTC Compliance, Magma Health Insurance Form, HDFC Life Medical Insurance Form, Go Digit Consent Form.
2	Kumar Haribhau Chavan	
3	Santosh Vijay Vichare	

Date: 09-04-2026 — For Easy Home Finance Limited
Place: Maharashtra — Authorized Signatory

Government of Jharkhand
Jharkhand Flying Institute

A Society Regd. Under Department of Cabinet Secretariat & Vigilance (Civil Aviation Division)
State Hangar, Birsa Munda Airport Road, Hinoo Ranchi-834002
E-mail-jfi.govtfly@gmail.com, Website-www.jharkhandaviation.in

Ref. No: - A/c-GT/JFI/69/2025/194/Ranchi, Date:- 07/ 04/ 2026
Corrigendum-01
e-Global Tender published through Reference No. - A/c-GT/JFI/69/ 2025-182/Ranchi,dated-02.04.2026 (PR No-376513)

Some changes are made to the RFP Document and the revised content to be read as mentioned below:

Due to an unintentional clerical error, the content regarding the payment provisions put forth at point 16 of CHAPTER-II and point 8 of CHAPTER-III were observed to be contradictory.Hence, the existing content in the point 8 of CHAPTER-III may be ignored and to be read in line with the point 16 of CHAPTER-II as the provision contained in both the points is the same.

Other Terms & Condition of NIT & RFP will remain the same.
This Corrigendum is also available on the website www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in

Sd/-Capt. S.P. Sinha
Managing Director cum Director Ops
Jharkhand Flying Institute

PR 376952 (Civil Aviation)26-27*D

झारखण्ड सरकार
कृषि, पशुपालन एवं सहकारिता विभाग
(सहकारिता प्रभाग)

झारखण्ड राज्य लघुवनोपज सहकारी विकास एवं विपणन संघ लि.
(झाम्फकोफेड लि०, राँची)एचतुर्थ तल, पशुपालन भवन, हेसाग, राँची–834003, झारखण्ड
E.mail I.D.:- mdjhamfcofed@gmail.com
Ph No :0651-3510563 Web Site: - www.jhamfcofed.in

झाम्फकोफेड से सम्बद्ध सहकारी समितियाँ/लैम्पस/पैक्स/वन धन विकास केन्द्र/स्वयं सहायता समूह/FPO आदि के चयन हेतु अल्पकालीन इच्छा की अभिव्यक्ति का आमंत्रण

केंद्रसरकार के आत्मनिर्भर संरचना विकास हेतु अनुदान योजना अन्तर्गत कृषि, पशुपालन एवं सहकारिता विभाग (सहकारिता प्रभाग), झारखण्ड सरकार द्वारा झारखण्ड राज्य लघुवनोपज सहकारी विकास एवं विपणन संघ लि. (झाम्फकोफेड), को प्राप्त निम्न योजनाओं के क्रियान्वयन हेतु सम्बद्ध संस्थाओं से इच्छा की अभिव्यक्ति आमंत्रित की जाती है। Solar Agro- MFP Processing unit, Sustainable Harvesting of MFP By Modern Tools and Technique. झाम्फकोफेड से सम्बद्ध सहकारी समितियाँ/लैम्पस/पैक्स/वन धन विकास केन्द्र/स्वयं सहायता समूह /किसान उत्पादक संगठन (FPO) आदि को योजना अन्तर्गत अनुदान पर प्रसंस्करण ईकाई/ Sustainable Harvesting Tool Kit उपलब्ध कराई जाएगी। सम्बद्ध संस्थाओं से निर्धारित नियम एवं शर्तों के अधीन विहित प्रपत्र में दिनांक 20.04.2026 (सोमवार) के अप० 05:00 बजे तक इच्छा की अभिव्यक्ति का आवेदन आमंत्रित की जाती है। आवेदन झाम्फकोफेड कार्यालय में निर्धारित तिथि तक हाथो–हाथ अथवा डाक के माध्यम से जमा किया जा सकता है।

विहित प्रपत्र, नियम एवं शर्तें झाम्फकोफेड के सूचना पट एवं झाम्फकोफेड के वेबसाईट:– www.jhamf cofed.in पर भी उपलब्ध है। अधिक जानकारी के लिए झाम्फकोफेड कार्यालय 0651-3510563 अथवा श्री चन्द्रशेखर तिवारी (विपणन प्रमुख), मोबाईल नं०– 8825331461 से सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है।

ह०/–
प्रबंध निदेशक
झाम्फकोफेड लि०, राँची

PR 376937 Co-opretive(26-27).D

POONAWALLA FINCORP LIMITED

POONAWALLA FINCORP

Corporate Office : Unit No. 2401, 24th Floor, Altimus, Dr. G M Bhosale Marg, Worli, Mumbai – 400 018 (Maharashtra)
Registered Office : 201 and 202, 2nd Floor, AP81, Koregaon Park Annex, Mundhwa, Pune – 411 036 (Maharashtra)

DEMAND NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002

You the below mentioned Borrowers/Co-borrowers have availed Home loans/Loans against Property facility (ies) by mortgaging your Immovable property/ies from Magma Fincorp Ltd "MFL" now renamed as Poonawalla Fincorp Ltd "PFL". You defaulted in repayment and therefore, your loan/s was classified as Non-Performing Assets. A Demand Notice under Section 13(2) of Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Asset and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 for the recovery of the outstanding dues sent on last known addresses however the same have returned un-served. Hence the contents of which are being published herewith as per Section 13(2) of the Act read with Rule 3(1) of The Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 as and by way of Alternate Service upon you.

Details of the Borrowers, Co-borrowers, Guarantors, Securities, Outstanding Dues, Demand Notice sent under Section 13(2) and Amount claimed there under are given as under:

SL. No.	Name of the Borrowers, Co-Borrowers, Loan Amount and LAN No.	Details of the Secured Asset	Demand Notice Date	Amount Due in Rs.
01.	**Borrowers, Co-Borrowers:** RADHAMOHAN MARKETING PRIVATE LIMITED, NIDHI ABNISH GUPTA, ABNISH KUMAR GUPTA. **Loan Amount:** Rs. 4,45,00,000/- (Rupees Four Crores Forty Five Lacs only) **Loan No.:** LAP00271000000019176130	**SCHEDULE OF PROPERTY:** ALL THE PIECE AND PARCEL OF FLAT NO. 601, ADMEASURING 710 SQ. FT. CARPET AREA, ON 6TH FLOOR, WING-A, ALONGWITH CAR PARKING NO. 13 GROUND FLOOR, IN BUILDING NO. 15 KNOWN AS "JULIAN ALPS", IN THE SOCIETY KNOWN AS "IVORY TOWERS CO-OPERATIVE HOUSING SOCIETY LIMITED", CONSTRUCTED ON LAND BEARING CTS NO. 1A5, 1B, LYING AND BEING SITUATED AT VILLAGE ANIK, TAL.-KURLA, DIST.-MUMBAI SUBURBAN, WADALA (EAST), MUMBAI–400037. & ALL THE PIECE AND PARCEL OF FLAT NO. 602, ADMEASURING 710 SQ. FT. CARPET AREA, ON 6TH FLOOR, WING-A, ALONGWITH CAR PARKING NO. 14 GROUND FLOOR, IN BUILDING NO. 15 KNOWN AS "JULIAN ALPS", IN THE SOCIETY KNOWN AS "IVORY TOWERS CO-OPERATIVE HOUSING SOCIETY LIMITED", CONSTRUCTED ON LAND BEARING CTS NO. 1A5, 1B, LYING AND BEING SITUATED AT VILLAGE ANIK, TAL.-KURLA, DIST.-MUMBAI SUBURBAN, WADALA (EAST), MUMBAI – 400037.	18.03.2026	Rs. 4,81,42,824/- (Rupees Four Crores Eighty One Lacs Forty Two Thousand Eight Hundred Twenty Four only) and interest till 18.03.2026 is due and payable by you along with future interest @9.85% per annum.

You the Borrower/s and Co-Borrower/s are therefore called upon to make payment of the above mentioned demanded amount with further interest as mentioned hereinabove in full within 60 Days of this Notice failing which the undersigned shall be constrained to take action under the act to enforce the above-mentioned security/ies. Please Note that as per Section 13(13) of The Said Act, You are in the meanwhile, restrained from transferring the above-referred securities by way of sale, lease or otherwise without our consent.

Place : Mumbai — Authorised Officer
Date : 09.04.2026 — *For Poonawalla Fincorp Limited*

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public at large is hereby given notice that our client **(1) Mr. Parmanand Chunnilal Gokalgandhi and (2) Mrs. Meeta Parmanand Gokalgandhi intends to purchase the undermentioned property** and in that connection wishes to investigate the title of **(1) Mr. Nitin Manikant Kothari and (2) Mrs. Sonali Nitin Kothari** to the undermentioned Property.

Any person having any share, right, title, interest, claim or demand into, upon or against the said property or any part thereof by way of sale, exchange, mortgage, gift, inheritance, possession, lease, license, lien, charge, trust, settlement, maintenance, easement or otherwise howsoever is hereby required to make known the same in writing together with certified true copies of the documents if any supporting such claim to us at our **Office at 202, Elite Square, Perin Nariman Street, Fort, Mumbai- 400 001, within 07 (Seven) days** from the date hereof, failing which our client shall proceed without regard to such claim/demand, and the same will be treated as waived/abandoned.

Description of the Property

All those piece or parcel of land together with the structures sending thereon and known as **Flat No. 702, 7th Floor, Wing A, Bhakti Co-operative Housing Society Limited**, Village Kanheri, Jamli Galli, S.V. Road, Borivali West, Mumbai 400 092, admeasuring **720 sq. ft. of carpet** area **along with furniture and Fixtures (Inclusive of Balconies etc)** and one parking space known as **"BHAKTI CO-OPERATIVE HOUSING SOCIETY LIMITED"** situated at CTS No. 99, 99/1 to 10 of village Kanheri, at Jambli Gully, Borivali West Mumbai-400092 in the Registration District and Sub-District of Mumbai City and Mumbai Suburban and in the District of Mumbai Suburban.

Sd/-
LawFort Advocates
Dhaval Ved (Partner)
ddved87@gmail.com

Place: Mumbai
Date: 09/04/2026

IN THE PUBLIC TRUSTS REGISTRATION OFFICE
GREATER MUMBAI REGION, MUMBAI.
Dharmadaya Ayukta Bhavan, 1st floor,
Sasmira Building Sasmira Marg, Worli, Mumbai 400 030.

30001/4/2627

ODISHA MINING CORPORATION LIMITED

OMC House, Bhubaneswar-751001, Odisha
CIN: U13100OR1956SGC000313, www.omcltd.in

OMC — ODISHA MINING CORPORATION LTD. — Mining Happiness

E-PROCUREMENT NOTICE

Sl. No.	NIT No.	Job Description	Availability of Tender documents	Bid due date
1.	OMC/E-PROC/ C&P/003/2026-27, Dtd. 07/04/2026	Supply of Fire Clay Mortar and Fire Clay Bricks at Ferrochrome Plant	08-04-2026	04-05-2026
2.	OMC/E-PROC/ C&P/004/2026-27, Dtd. 07/04/2026	Supply of Quartzite at Ferrochrome Plant	08-04-2026	04-05-2026
3.	OMC/E-PROC/ C&P/005/2026-27, Dtd. 07/04/2026	Supply of Magnesite at Ferrochrome Plant	09-04-2026	05-05-2026
4.	OMC/E-PROC/ C&P/006/ 2026-27, Dtd. 07/04/2026	Supply of C.I. Moulds and C.I. Slag Pots with Spout as per drawing at Ferrochrome Plant	09-04-2026	05-05-2026
5.	OMC/E-PROC/ C&P/007/ 2026-27, Dtd. 07/04/2026	Supply, installation, testing and commissioning of various Medical Equipment for Hospitals and Dispensaries of OMC Limited	10-04-2026	07-05-2026

All other details can be seen from the Tender Document available on the e-procurement portal of the Government of Odisha (**www.tendersodisha.gov.in**) and on the website of OMC (**www.omcltd.in**). OMC reserves the right to reject any/all the bids or to annul the bidding process without assigning any reason thereof.

Sd/-
Head (C&P)

I&PR No-30001/30005/1/26-27/0004

Bank of Maharashtra

A GOVT. OF INDIA UNDERTAKING

Thane Zonal Office:-B-37, Wagle Industrial Estate, Thane (W) – 400 604.
Head Office : Lokmangal,1501, Shivajinagar Pune-5
TEL : 022 25829406, 25823040 **e-mail :**dzmthane@mahabank.co.in

POSSESSION NOTICE [Appendix IV [Under Rule 8(1)]]

Whereas the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of **Bank of Maharashtra** under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Sub Section (12) section 13 read with rule 3 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notices dated as mentioned below calling upon the following Borrowers to repay the amounts mentioned in the demand notices within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

The Borrower/s having failed to repay the amount, Notice is hereby given to the Borrower/s and the Public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the properties described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under Sub Section (4) of Section 13 of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002 on the dates mentioned below.

The Borrowers in particular and the Public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of Bank of Maharashtra for the amounts mentioned herein below The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets. This notice is also being published in vernacular. The English version shall be final if any question of interpretation arises.

Sr No	Name & Branches of the Borrowers	Outstanding Amount in Rs.	Date of Demand Notice / Date of Possession
1	**Branch : Wada Branch Borrower:-Mr. Alauddin Janullah Shaikh & Mr. Jamila Alauddin Shaikh**	**Rs.17,21,203/-Plus interest @ 7.90 % p.a at monthly rest w.e.f. 23.01.2026**	**06.11.2025** / **08.04.2026**
	Description of Property : All that pieces and parcel of the property consisting of Plot No. / S. No. / CTS No. / Gat No. / Milkat No. 115 116 118, Flat / House No. 204, Building / Wing - BL No 7 Type B4 Wing D Sector V, Floor-2, Sumitra Landmark Tower, Betegaon Boisar Palghar, in the Area /Village-Betegaon, Taluka / Tehsil / Sub Dist.-Palghar, City-Palghar, District-Thane, State-Maharashtra, 401501 **CERSAI ID: 200079905551**		
2	**Branch : Palghar Branch Borrower:- Mrs. Jayashri Ankush Naik & Mrs.Namrata Ankush Naik**	**Rs.19,32,301/-Plus interest @ 8.20 % p.a at monthly rest w.e.f. 17.12.2025**	**17.12.2025** / **08.04.2026**
	Description of Property : Flat No 404, 4th Floor, Ambrosia-7, Type B-1, 1 Unit, S.no403/1,403/1p And 403/1b (403/1p), Village Mahim, Taluka Palghar, Dist Palghar **CERSAI ID 200077042360**		
3	**Branch : Wada Branch Borrower:- Mr. Rishi Pandey & Mrs Pritee**	**Rs.22,32,568/-Plus interest @ 7.90 % p.a at monthly rest w.e.f. 28.01.2026**	**06.11.2025** / **08.04.2026**
	Description of Property : All that pieces & parcel of the property consisting of Plot No./ S.No./ CTS No./ Gat No./ Milkat No. 210, Flat / House No. 402, Building / Wing -BLD NO 4, Floor-4 , Renuka Apartment Parasnath Nagari, At Umroli Palghar, Umroli Railway Station in the Area / Village -Palghar,Taluka /Tehsil / Sub Dist.-Palghar, City-Palghar,District-Palghar, State-Maharashtra., 401404 CERSAI ID: 200086500410		
4	**Branch : Wada Branch Borrower, Mr. Vishal Ravindra Khot & Mr. Aniket Ashok Pamale**	**Rs.17,22,122/-Plus interest @ 7.90 % p.a at monthly rest w.e.f. 23.01.2026**	**06.11.2025** / **08.04.2026**
	Description of Property : All that pieces and parcel of the property consisting of Plot No. / S. No. / CTS No. / Gat No. / Milkat No. 131/6A 128/1 77/1, Flat / House No. 1, Building / Wing – MAYURESHWAR TYPE C, Floor – 0, Type C Mayur Eshwar Attanayake Homes, Village Tembhode, in the Area /Village – Palghar, Taluka / Tehsil / Sub Dist. – Palghar, City - Palghar, Maharashtra, 401404 CERSAI ID: 200078577421		

Date : 09.04.2026 — **BANK OF MAHARASHTRA**
Place : Thane — **Chief Manager & Authorized Officer, Thane Zone**

Bank of India

Relationship beyond banking

RECOVERY DEPARTMENT, KOLHAPUR
KOLHAPUR ZONE: 1519,C, JAYDHAVAL BUILDING, 3rd FLOOR, LAXMIPURI, PO Box 5, KOLHAPUR-416002.

E-AUCTION FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES
E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT 2002 CUM NOTICE TO BORROWER / GUARANTOR

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the following Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to Bank of India (Secured Creditor), the constructive / physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officers of **Bank of India**, will be held on **"as is Where is" "as is what is"** and **"what ever there is"**, for recovery of respective dues as detailed here under against the secured assets mortgaged / charged to **Bank of India** from respective borrowers and guarantors. The reserve price and earnest money deposit is shown there against each secured asset. The sale will be done by the undersigned through E-Auction platform provided hereunder.

(Rs. in Crore)

Sr. No.	Names of the Branch / Borrower / Guarantor	Description of the properties	Reserve Price / EMD Amount / Bid Increment Amount	Last Date (for sub of EMD)	O/s Dues (Excluding Int., Penal interest & Expenses)	E Auction Date & Time
1.	Branch : **ARB Kolhapur** Name of Account: **M/s. SHRI KARVIR NIVASINI MAHALAXMI ISPAT PVT. LTD.** Director Name- 1. **Mr Jitendra Pukhraj Gandhi**	Plot No. A-06 admeasuring 19783 Sq. Mtrs. Situated at MIDC, Gokul Shirgaon, Kolhapur - 416234. (**Type of Possession : Symbolic**)	**Rs. 18.18 / Rs. 1.81 / Rs. 0.10**	**28th April, 2026**	**Rs. 21.32** plus Uncharged interest and other charges Costs from	**28th April, 2026 10.00 AM** to **5.00 PM** with unlimited Extension of
2.		Plot no A-7/2 admeasuring 6712 Sq.Mtrs, situated at MIDC, Gokul Shirgaon, Kolhapur - 416234. (**Type of Possession : Symbolic**)	**Rs. 5.61 / Rs. 0.56 /**	**28th April, 2026**		

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Business Standard

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THE MARKETS ON WEDNESDAY

		change†
Sensex	77,562.9	▲ 2,946.3
Nifty	23,997.3	▲ 873.7
Nifty Futures‡	24,057.8	▲ 60.5
Dollar	₹92.6	₹93.0‡‡
Euro	₹108.1	₹107.5‡‡
Brent Crude ($/bbl)	93.2*	100.3‡‡
Gold (10gm)**	₹1,50,516.0	▲ ₹3,322.0

† Over previous close; ‡ (December) Premium on Nifty Spot; ‡‡ Previous close; * At 9pm IST; ** Market rate exclusive of GST; Source: IBJA

COMPANIES 2 ›

Tesla lags new foreign entrants in India's electric car race

ECONOMY & PUBLIC AFFAIRS 4 ›

₹ likely to stabilise at 92-93 level, says EAC-PM chairman

TAKE TWO 15 ›

A debate unscrolled: Should social media for teens be regulated?

Sensex surges nearly 4% in its best session in over five years as a two-week US-Iran ceasefire eases oil supply fears, even as Israel pummels Lebanon to target Hezbollah and Hormuz remains largely blocked

Markets soar on shaky Iran-US ceasefire

₹ vs $ (spot)	Brent crude	India 10-year Gsec yield	Nifty Midcap 100	Nifty Smallcap 100	India mcap*	India vix
92.58	89.50/bbl	6.90%	56,799.5	16,538.05	₹445.5 trn	19.70
▲ 0.44%	▼ 10.75% until 5 pm IST	▼ 15 bps	▲ 4.03%	▲ 4.39%	▲ ₹16.5 trn	▼ 20.24%

*mcap of BSE-listed companies

Source: Bloomberg

1-day change

❝THE US WILL WORK CLOSELY WITH IRAN... THERE WILL BE NO ENRICHMENT OF URANIUM❞

Donald Trump, US President

❝WE'RE NOT PUTTING ANY TRUST IN THE OTHER SIDE. OUR MILITARY FORCES ARE KEEPING THEIR PREPAREDNESS❞

Ali Bahreini
Iranian ambassador to UN

SUNDAR SETHURAMAN
Mumbai, 8 April

Domestic equity markets rallied sharply on Wednesday, buoyed by a wave of optimism across global markets after the United States (US), and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire and Tehran pledged to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, in a last-ditch deal that saw American President Donald Trump back off from threats to escalate the war. A sharp decline in global crude oil prices, growth-focused commentary from the Reserve Bank of India and short-covering by traders further supported the surge.

Tensions, however, remain elevated, with Iranian media claiming that oil tankers passing through Hormuz had been stopped after Israel's "ceasefire breach". Despite truce announcement, Israel launched its biggest attacks yet on Lebanon, and Iran struck Gulf neighbours' oil facilities.

The Sensex rose 2,946 points, or 3.95 per cent, to close at 77,563 — its biggest single-day gain since February 1, 2021.

The Nifty 50 climbed 874 points, or 3.8 per cent, to 23,997, marking its strongest advance since May 12, 2025.

The total market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies increased by ₹16.3 trillion to ₹445.5 trillion, compared with ₹464 trillion before the conflict began.

The rupee appreciated 0.44 per cent to 92.58 a dollar, while forward premiums declined. The benchmark 10-year government bond yield fell 14.8 basis points to 6.90 per cent as Brent crude dropped below $90 a barrel, down nearly 11 per cent. The crude oil benchmark, however, is still trading well above the pre-conflict level of about $73.

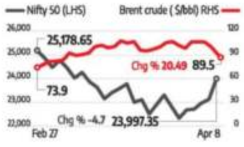
The rally followed Iran's agreement to conditions linked to reopening the Strait of Hormuz, a critical chokepoint that carries nearly a fifth of global oil supplies. The earlier blockade had unsettled oil markets and

The war shock

Indian equities slid into a sharp riskoff phase after the West Asia war began, with benchmarks falling up to 11 per cent amid a 45 per cent surge in crude oil prices, rupee weakness and foreign investor outflows. Wednesday's rally signals a sentiment rebound, though risks persist.

SUNDAR SETHURAMAN

Equities slip on oil

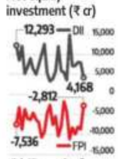


Losing value

₹ vs $ (inverted scale)

FPIs exit

Net equity investment (₹ cr)



Note: Provisional data as reported on exchange
Source: Exchange

Bonds weaken

— India 10-yr gsec yield (%)

Members of the US Air Force walk towards a B-52 Stratofortress bomber after it returned still loaded with munitions to the RAF Fairford airbase in the UK, following the announcement of a two-week ceasefire in the Iran war PHOTO: REUTERS

US, Iran agree to talk in Islamabad even as Strait of Hormuz stays blocked for now

KATE SULLIVAN, PATRICK SYKES & DAN STRUMPF
8 April

The United States (US) and Iran said they are prepared to hold talks to end the war in West Asia during a proposed two-week pause in hostilities, even as Israeli strikes on Lebanon threatened to derail the fragile truce.

Further adding to uncertainty, sporadic fighting con-

draw from the deal if Israel kept up attacks in Lebanon, according to the semi-official Tasnim news agency. Passage of oil tankers through the strait was halted after Israel's attacks, the semi-official Fars news agency reported.

Trump on Wednesday said that Lebanon was not included in the ceasefire deal "because of Hezbollah".

"They were not included in the deal. That'll get taken care

PAGE 4

Indian refiners begin talks on cargo via Strait of Hormuz

As the US and Iran agreed to a ceasefire, Indian refiners have initiated talks with suppliers from West Asia. Shipping firms, however, showed some hesitation in resuming cargo transport through the passage, sources said.

New Delhi welcomes ceasefire, calls for dialogue, diplomacy

India on Wednesday welcomed the ceasefire between the US and Iran, and hoped that the development "will also encourage peace efforts in Ukraine". External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar will visit the UAE on April 11 and 12.

PAGE 10

Lebanon not part of ceasefire, says Israel, carries out strikes

Israel carried out its heaviest strikes on Lebanon since the conflict with Hezbollah broke out last month, even as the Iran-aligned group paused attacks on northern Israel and Israeli troops in Lebanon under a two-week raised concerns over a global energy shock.

Foreign portfolio investors (FPI) were net sellers to the tune of ₹2,812 crore, while domestic institutional investors (DII) provided support with net inflows of ₹4,168 crore.

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74,616.6 Apr 7

▪ Markets believe the worst is over: Samir Arora P12 ▶

Source: Bloomberg
Compiled by BS Research Bureau

tinued throughout the region and the Strait of Hormuz remained largely blocked.

US President Donald Trump has said that reopening the Strait was a condition for halting the fighting.

Trump announced the ceasefire on Tuesday night was a retreat from threats to unleash massive devastation on Iran, easing fears of a protracted global energy crisis. Mediator Pakistan has floated negotiations later this week in Islamabad, and Trump said they could start very soon, according to the New York Post.

Yet there were already signs that the agreement was buckling. Iran said it would with-


People celebrate ceasefire in Tehran PHOTO: REUTERS

of, too. It's all right," he said in a brief telephone interview with *PBS News Hour*.

When asked about Israel continuing its strikes in Lebanon, he said, "It's part of the deal — everyone knows that. That's a separate skirmish."

Turn to Page 8 ▶

US-Iran ceasefire.

EDIT:
WAIT AND WATCH 11 ▶

▪ Oil flows from Gulf may take months to recover 10 ▶

IN BRIEF

Puducherry, Assam, Kerala set to vote today

Assembly elections in Assam (126 seats), Kerala (140 seats), and Puducherry (30 seats) will be held in a single phase on Thursday. In Assam, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is eyeing a third term in a high-stakes battle with the Congress. Meanwhile in Kerala, a triangular contest is emerging between the Left Democratic Front (LDF), the United Democratic Fund (UDF), of which the Congress is a part, and the BJP-led NDA. PTI

Centre hikes non-urea subsidy by 10-21%

With fertiliser prices rising sharply due to the West Asia crisis, the Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved a 10–21 per cent increase in per-kilogram subsidy rates for non-urea fertilisers for kharif 2026 under the Nutrient-Based Subsidy regime, compared with kharif 2025. The move will cost the exchequer around ₹41,534 crore — about 12 per cent more than the previous season. 8 ▶

▪ Hydropower projects worth ₹40,000 cr in Arunachal get nod

RBI maintains status quo, sees FY27 growth at 6.9% with downside risks

MANOJIT SAHA
Mumbai, 8 April

Hours after the declaration of a two-week ceasefire in the West Asia conflict, the six-member monetary policy committee of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) announced that the key policy rate remains unchanged at 5.25 per cent, and maintained a neutral stance, in line with what the street was expecting.

"The ceasefire, to some extent has been taken into account," RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said in a media conference after unveiling the MPC's policy decisions. "The whole implication... we will come to know. But the ceasefire has been taken into account in the monetary policy decision."

After cutting the repo rate by 125 basis points (bps) between February and December 2025, the MPC has now kept the policy rate unchanged in the two bi-monthly reviews since then.

Observing that geopolitical uncertainties have heightened significantly since the February MPC meet, Malhotra noted that upside risks to the inflation outlook, driven by increased energy price pressures, among other factors, have increased even though core inflation remains muted. At the same time, supply chain dislocations and the risk of

"... IT'S QUITE POSSIBLE THAT EVEN IN THE SHORT TO MEDIUM TERM, WE WILL CONTINUE TO HAVE LOW RATES"

Sanjay Malhotra
Governor, Reserve Bank of India

second-round effects render the future inflation trajectory uncertain, he remarked.

For the first time ever, the MPC shared projections for core inflation,

PAGE 4
World Bank ups India's FY27 growth forecast to 6.6%

The World Bank on Wednesday upgraded its forecast for India's GDP growth in FY27 by 30 bps to 6.6 per cent compared to its October 2025 forecast of 6.3 per cent, even as it expects inflation to inch up due to high energy prices.

PAGE 7
India's banking system resilient, safe and strong: RBI Governor

India's banking system is resilient, safe, and strong, said RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday. He added that central-bank regulations, along with its supervisory framework, helped keep the banking system robust.

PAGE 6 ▶ ▪ Forex curbs temporary: RBI guv ▪ RBI proposes scrapping IFR

which excludes prices of volatile energy and food items, in the April monetary policy statement. While headline inflation is projected at 4.6 per cent through 2026-27 (FY27), relative to 2.1 per cent estimated for FY26, core inflation rate has been estimated at 4.4 per cent this year.

The central bank assessed that elevated energy and other commodity prices due to the West Asia conflict and other supply disruptions are likely to impact growth in 2026-27, and it projected a real GDP growth of 6.9 per cent in FY27, down from the 7.6 per cent uptick expected in FY26.

"Further escalation and wider spread of the conflict, heightened volatility in global financial markets and weather-related events, however, weigh on the domestic growth outlook. Risks to the baseline projections are tilted to the downside, with uncertainty remaining elevated due to the ongoing West Asia conflict," Malhotra said, noting that the FY27 GDP growth projection was way lower than the FY26 estimate.

When asked about the thinking on interest rates staying lower for longer as indicated during the February policy, Malhotra said it is quite possible that rates remain low in the near to medium term, but it will depend on how conditions evolve.

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MNRE, FinMin in talks to launch PLI for polysilicon

SUDHEER PAL SINGH & NANDINI KESHARI
New Delhi, 8 April

THE SCHEME IS BEING PROPOSED IN A BID TO BOOST SOLAR SUPPLY CHAIN AND CUT DEPENDENCE ON CHINESE IMPORTS

The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) is in discussions with the Ministry of Finance to launch a production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme aimed at boosting domestic manufacturing of polysilicon, a critical component in the upstream solar power value chain.

Polysilicon, a highly purified form of silicon, is used as the primary raw material for more than 95 per cent of solar panels globally. It is produced by refining silicon into multi-crystalline structures, which are then melted to produce wafers, solar cells, and finally photovoltaic (PV) modules.

As part of its push for self-reliance and to reduce dependence on cheap Chinese imports, India has expanded its solar manufacturing capacity in the past few years, mostly based on the Advanced List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) schemes.

Currently, India has a solar module manufacturing capacity of 172 gigawatts (Gw) and around 65 Gw of cell capacity. "We have created adequate capacity in these areas, but we still depend on imports for upstream components. "For that, we are discussing a scheme with the finance ministry to support polysilicon manufacturing," MNRE Secretary Santosh Kumar Sarangi said in an interaction with *Business Standard*.

He added that the ministry has not introduced ALMM for polysilicon because, while the ingots-to-modules value chain is dominated by solar manufacturers globally, the same players may not enter into polysilicon manufacturing, which is a different ball game.

Turn to Page 8 ▶


weight in Pink!”


Jay SPEAKS


The Fact of the Matter


Jay SPEAKS
The Art of War, boardroom edition.
Business Standard


Jay SPEAKS
Liked. Shared. Commented. Respected.

STOCKS IN THE NEWS

HFCL

Subsidiary receives ₹1,366 crore order for optical fibre cable supply

₹75.2 CLOSE ▲ 3.5% UP*

Shriram Finance

Board approves allocation of 471.1 million shares to MUFG for ₹39,618 crore

₹1,023.6 CLOSE ▲ 10.0% UP*

TVS Motor Co

Launches three-wheeler Armado 200 in Indonesia

₹3,697.9 CLOSE ▲ 6.6% UP*

Cyient

Acquires majority stake in Kinetic Technologies for $85 million

₹859.2 CLOSE ▲ 3.2% UP*

Torrent Power

CCI approves acquisition of 100% equity stake in Nabha Power

₹1,448.2 CLOSE ▲ 3.4% UP*

*OVER PREVIOUS CLOSE

IN BRIEF

Adani wins US court hearing in push to dismiss SEC fraud suit

A US judge granted a request from billionaire Gautam Adani to schedule a hearing in his effort to dismiss a US Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) fraud case, which he says lacks necessary jurisdiction and fails on multiple reasons. This followed lawyers of Adani and his nephew, Sagar, filing a plea seeking dismissal of the case. "The court has received Defendants' letter requesting a pre-motion conference on their anticipated motion to dismiss the Complaint. The court GRANTS that request and DIRECTS the parties" to schedule the pre-motion conference, the Eastern District court of New York said in its order. In the filing, the Adanis' lawyers said there was no credible evidence supporting the alleged bribery scheme. The SEC, they said, lacked necessary jurisdiction over the two men and that the alleged misstatements underpinning the case weren't actionable. The Adani group has denied all allegations, saying none of its entities or executives have been charged under US Foreign Corrupt Practices Act. PTI

Anthropic appoints Amlan Mohanty to lead India policy

San Francisco-based Artificial Intelligence (AI) major Anthropic has appointed Amlan Mohanty to lead its policy initiatives in India. In a post on LinkedIn, Mohanty said: "I'm thrilled to be joining Anthropic to lead policy in India!... India is key to the future of AI — the scale, diversity and potential for impact are unmatched, and what works well here can be replicated in other parts of the world. I'm excited to shape Anthropic's early presence in India and build trusted partnerships with government, industry and civil society." Prior to joining Anthropic, Mohanty served as an Associate Fellow at the Centre for Responsible AI. He has also led Google's public policy and government affairs in India across privacy, platforms, and AI policy. Anthropic describes India as its second-largest market for Claude.ai and home to a developer community doing "some of the most technically intense AI work". PTI

Equinix opens 4th data centre in Mumbai to support AI demand

Digital infrastructure company Equinix on Wednesday announced the launch of MB3, its fourth International Business Exchange data centre in Mumbai. With an initial investment of over $95 million, MB3 provides more than 1,370 cabinets of capacity, with the facility designed to scale to more than 5,475 cabinets when fully built. MB3 is designed to support high-performance workloads and hybrid multicloud deployments with liquid cooling capability for enterprises across India. The launch comes at a time when AI adoption, cloud migration, data localisation requirements, and the rapid expansion of digital services are significantly increasing demand for secure and globally interconnected infrastructure in India. With a cumulative investment of over $365 million across India, Equinix has made one of its largest sustained commitments to digital infrastructure in India, reflecting long-term confidence in the country's digital growth trajectory. BS REPORTER

Max Healthcare acquires 59% stake in Kalinga Hospital for ₹300 crore

Tesla trails new foreign entrants in India's EV race

VinFast, BYD outpace US EV giant with sharper pricing, wider networks

SOHINI DAS
Mumbai, 8 April

India's electric passenger vehicle (PV) market surged to 199,923 units in FY26, accounting for 4.2 per cent of the overall PV market, up 83.6 per cent year-on-year (Y-o-Y).

Within this growing market, new foreign entrants such as Vietnamese automaker VinFast and China's BYD have significantly outperformed Tesla. This is despite all of them facing similar completely built unit (CBU) import constraints and geopolitical headwinds.

Tesla entered India in July 2025 and began deliveries in September, managing to sell 342 units in FY26, translating into just 0.17 per cent share of the EV market. VinFast also started sales around the same time.

VinFast, entering as a new brand just 12 months ago, delivered 2,390 units — about seven times Tesla's volume — capturing a 1.2 per cent EV market share.

The company gained traction by pricing its VF e34 and VF7 models in the ₹25-35 lakh range, undercutting Tesla's ₹60-67 lakh Model Y by around 50 per cent. VinFast simultaneously announced a Tamil Nadu plant with 120,000 unit annual capacity by 2027 to accelerate localisation.

BYD, meanwhile, clocked 5,361 units in FY26, up 54 per cent Y-o-Y, or around 15 times Tesla's tally, despite importing most vehicles as CBUs subject to 100-110 per cent duties. Its expansion has also been constrained by geopolitical tensions, including the blocking of its proposed $1 billion joint venture in India.

Even so, BYD leveraged a broader portfolio — such as the Atto 3 and eMax 7 — priced in the ₹25-35 lakh band, alongside rapid service network expansion and plans to explore semi-knocked down (SKD) assembly.

The company operates a small Chennai facility with 10,000-15,000 unit annual capacity, even as full manufacturing plans remain on hold.

Tesla's relatively muted performance is also being linked to its limited retail footprint. The company currently operates just two showrooms in Delhi and Mumbai, compared to around 35–39 outlets for BYD and 34–35 for VinFast across more than 30 cities.

Anurag Singh of Primus Partners told *Business Standard* that Tesla's approach in India appears tentative, noting that its cars are "imported and expensive." And, the company still lacks a full customer ecosystem, including "dealership, service and charging" infrastructure.

In his view, Tesla is "experimenting rather than committing."

Singh added that over the long term, traditional internal combustion engine (ICE) automakers may have an edge over EV startups, given the complexity of the automobile business.

"It takes an Elon Musk to do Tesla," he said, pointing out that most EV startups globally have struggled to sustain themselves, with China being "a different story" due to strong government backing. He added that it is "easier for ICE players to get into EVs" than for startups to build an automobile business from scratch.

Tesla's global market entry performance has varied significantly across regions, shaped largely by import duties, local manufacturing timelines, and model availability.

In the United States, Tesla launched the Model S in June 2012 — its first full production vehicle — and sold 2,650 units in that debut year. The company faced zero import duty, as production was localised at its Fremont factory in California, which it had acquired in 2010 ahead of the launch.

Tesla entered Europe in mid-2013, beginning Model S deliveries in August–September across Norway, the Netherlands, Germany, France and Switzerland. It sold around 5,000 units in its first year, despite a 10 per cent European Union (EU) tariff on imports.

Local manufacturing only came nearly a decade later, with Giga Berlin commencing production in March 2022 with an initial capacity of 250,000 units, ramping up to 500,000 units annually by 2025.

In China, Tesla began Model S shipments in April 2014, selling 2,499 units in its first year, while facing 95–100 per cent import duties. The high cost led to an inventory overhang of more than 2,300 unsold vehicles.

Tesla addressed this by setting up Giga Shanghai, which started production in September 2019 — just five years after entry — and scaled from 150,000 units annually to over 1 million units by 2025. This made China its largest market, with 657,000 units sold in 2024, a 263-fold increase from its first year.

In contrast, India marks Tesla's weakest first-year performance globally.

Changing gear

PV OEM	FY26	Y-o-Y %	FY26 market share (%)
Tata Motors PV	78,811	35.90	39.42
JSW MG Motor India	53,089	73.67	26.55
Mahindra & Mahindra	42,721	407.01	21.37
BYD India	5,361	54.01	2.68
VinFast Auto India	2,390	NA	1.20
Tesla India Motors and Energy	342	NA	0.17

Source: Fada

'Higher fuel prices, ethanol push may accelerate EV shift'

DEEPAK PATEL
New Delhi, 8 April

Rising fuel prices and the push for higher ethanol blending amid the West Asia conflict, along with improving electric vehicle (EV) ranges, are expected to accelerate the shift towards EVs, BMW group India President and Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Hardeep Singh Brar said on Wednesday.

Israel and the United States carried out military strikes on Iran on February 28, triggering the conflict, after which Iran largely shut the Strait of Hormuz, pushing up global crude oil prices. Both the sides agreed to a two-week ceasefire starting Wednesday.

In parallel, India has begun discussions with automakers on moving from mandatory E20 petrol, which contains 20 per cent ethanol blended with petrol, to E25, a higher ethanol mix. Ethanol has lower calorific value than petrol, meaning it releases less energy per litre, which can reduce vehicle mileage. This has raised concerns for both buyers and automakers.

Brar said the immediate impact of the conflict is being felt more through currency movements than input costs. Forex is more crucial for BMW India as the firm imports components and completely knocked down (CKD) kits. "It's too early to predict what will happen to raw material prices. For me, the bigger worry is how the forex will play out," he said, adding that BMW raised prices by 1-2 per cent from April 1 due to exchange rate fluctuations.

On fuel prices, he noted that domestic retail rates have not been changed despite the significant rise in global crude prices, but any increase at a later date could influence buying decisions. "Whenever these prices go up, it will trigger a thought in the consumer's mind —what if it goes up further —and that could push them towards EVs," he said at a media roundtable in New Delhi. He added that policy moves such as higher ethanol blending could further support this shift. "We have not seen any concerns about ethanol blending so far. But any of these moves will definitely bring more customers towards EVs," he said.

"IT'S TOO EARLY TO PREDICT HOW THE WEST ASIA WAR WILL IMPACT RAW MATERIAL PRICES. FOR ME, THE BIGGER WORRY IS HOW FOREX WILL PLAY OUT"

Hardeep Singh Brar
BMW group India president and chief executive officer

Brar also pointed to improving EV technology, particularly driving range — the distance a vehicle can travel on a single charge — as a key factor. "Today, we are talking about ranges of over 500 km and even approaching 800 km in luxury EVs. Customers will naturally gravitate towards them," he said.

BMW group India reported that EVs accounted for 26 per cent of its total car sales in the first quarter of 2026, up from 21 per cent a year earlier, with 1,185 EVs sold during the period. Overall, the company sold 4,567 cars in the quarter, up 17 per cent year-on-year.

On policy support for EVs, Brar said state governments must continue incentives such as registration fee waivers to sustain adoption. He explained that battery electric vehicles, which run entirely on electricity without an internal combustion engine, currently have a price gap of about 15 per cent compared to petrol or diesel vehicles. "If this gap widens to 30 per cent, adoption could fall sharply," he said. "This is the time to keep the foot on the accelerator. States should continue their support so EV penetration goes up rather than going down," he added.

Magicpin raises ₹15 cr debt from Stride Ventures to deepen AI play

UDISHA SRIVASTAV
New Delhi, 8 April

Hyperlocal ecommerce platform Magicpin has raised ₹15 crore in debt funding from Stride Ventures as it looks to double down on artificial intelligence (AI)-led offerings for small retailers, people aware of the matter told *Business Standard*.

The venture debt route allows the company to raise capital without significant equity dilution, while continuing to invest in long-term technology capabilities.

The company has already put in about $1 million (between ₹8.5 crore and 9.2 crore) raised venture debt three times, including the latest round. It has already repaid its earlier borrowings, and also pre-paid its second debt tranche ahead of schedule, a source added.

While venture debt refers to a loan given to startups that must be repaid with interest, usually without giving up equity, venture capital is equity investment where investors take ownership stakes in exchange for funding and share the company's risk and upside.

Magicpin has raised $100 million in total funding to date. This is inclusive of debt.

In a recent conversation with *Business*

Flipkart accelerates AI push, shifts focus from strategy to execution

PEERZADA ABRAR
Bengaluru, 8 April

Flipkart is accelerating its push to embed artificial intelligence (AI) across its operations, moving from strategy to execution as it scales deployment across the business.

Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Kalyan Krishnamurthy said the Walmart-owned ecommerce company was entering a phase where AI was no longer experimental, but central to how it built products, served customers, and

CEO Kalyan Krishnamurthy said that AI was no longer experimental,

broad strategic direction to measurable deployment. Krishnamurthy positioned the transition as foundational to Flipkart's next phase of growth.

"What being AI-first means for us at Flipkart is that intelligent systems should sit at the core of what we build," he said, adding that the approach would enable "a more intuitive customer experience, seller tools that drive growth more efficiently, and internal productivity where AI handles routine tasks so teams can focus on innovation."

The emphasis on productivity gains

With an eye to expand in East India, Max Healthcare on Wednesday said it had acquired a controlling stake in Bhubaneswar-based Kalinga Hospital (KHL) for an enterprise value of ₹300 crore. Under a share purchase agreement (SPA), Max will acquire a 58.4 per cent stake in KHL from the Hospital Corporation of Orissa. The financing for the acquisition will be done through external commercial borrowings from Standard Chartered Bank. BS REPORTER

to develop its AI-powered assistant, 'Vera AI'. The tool is designed to assist small retailers across the country to streamline their operations, enhance digital presence, and drive customer engagement.

"The company has already deployed a part of the amount to invest in Vera AI. It is likely to use the remaining amount to do further innovations in Vera while also experimenting with other AI-specific innovations," a source said.

Since its launch in 2015, Magicpin has

Standard, Anshoo Sharma, chief executive officer and cofounder of Magicpin, said the AI-led merchant enablement will unlock a new revenue stream for the company, contributing meaningfully to its SaaS (software-as-a-service) and advertising business over the next two-three years.

The platform estimates this to be a multi-billion dollar opportunity over the next 5-7 years, as local retailers shift from manual marketing and agencies to automated, performance-led platforms.

improved internal efficiency.

"As I have been emphasising, the landscape of our industry is evolving rapidly. To lead in the next decade, we need to build on AI," he wrote in an internal note to employees, reviewed by *Business Standard*.

The company has appointed Hemant Badri to lead what it calls a critical "AI Transformation Charter", expanding his remit beyond his existing responsibilities across supply chain,

but central to how it built products and served customers

quick-commerce unit Minutes, customer experience, and recommerce.

The move signals Flipkart's intent to turn AI strategy into operational outcomes by putting a senior, execution-focused leader in charge of implementation. Badri will be responsible for identifying and scaling high-impact use cases, marking a shift from

and automation reflects a broader industry trend, as firms increasingly deploy AI not just in customer-facing applications, but also to streamline back-end operations and cut costs.

The initiative will require coordination across teams, marking what the CEO described as "a broader organisational shift". The mandate underscores the growing importance of cross-functional alignment in AI adoption, particularly in large organisations like Flipkart.

Reliance Retail 7th among top 100 VC-backed private firms globally: Study

ILLUSTRATION: BINAY SINHA

The pecking order

Top global private companies in the list of 100

Rank	Company	Post-money valuation ($ bn)
1	OpenAI*	852
2	SpaceX	400
3	Anthropic	350
4	ByteDance	300
5	Databricks	134
6	xAI	113
7	Reliance Retail	100
8	Stripe	92
9	Ant group	79
27	NSE India	24
28	Epic Games	23
93	Tata EV Mobility	9

*OpenAI recently raised fresh funds which takes its valuation to $852 billion; Source: Stanford Graduate School of Business's Venture Capital Initiative, Ilya Strebulaev, professor at Stanford

SURAJEET DAS GUPTA
New Delhi, 8 April

Reliance Retail has been ranked seventh among the top 100 most valuable privately held, venture capital (VC)-backed companies in the world with a post-money valuation of over $100 billion, according to research by Venture Capital Initiative of the Stanford Graduate School of Business.

The research is based on data up to January 2026.

Apart from Reliance Retail, two more companies from India are on the list of top 100 — NSE India, which is 27th in the pecking order, with a post-money valuation of $24 billion, and Tata EV Mobility, 93rd on the list, with a valuation of $9 billion.

The Mukesh Ambani-owned company, which is one of the seven hectacrons (valuation over $100 billion) on the list, is backed by numerous big global private equity players, including Qatar Investment Authority, Abu Dhabi Investment Authority, KKR, Silverlake, GIC, TPG, and Mubadala.

Though Reliance Retail is the only company in the retail space which is in the top seven, its valuation is far behind AI giants like OpenAI (post-money valuation of $852 billion), Elon Musk's SpaceX ($400 billion), Anthropic ($350 billion), Bytedance ($300 billion), Databricks ($134 billion), and xAI ($113 billion).

The Venture Capital Initiative study has looked through data of over 1,700 privately held unicorns across the world with a combined post-money valuation of $7.3 trillion. The 100 most valuable companies alone are worth $3.7 trillion, more than half of all unicorn value.

The top three players — ChatGPT, SpaceX, and Anthropic — account for a third of that amount. And, two out of the three most-valuable companies are AI players.

While the US is a clear leader with as many as 65 of the top 100 companies, it is followed by China (21), India (3), the UK (3), and Germany (2).

What is interesting is that the collective post-money valuation of the three Indian companies is pegged at $133 billion, which is nearly a fifth of the collective valuation of 21 Chinese companies, at $634 billion.

NSE India, the Indian stock exchange company, is also a key player to watch. It has a valuation higher than US-based video game and software developer Epic Games ($23 billion), and also more than AI company Perplexity in the US ($20 billion). Perplexity has an Indian-origin cofounder, Aravind Srinivas.

On the other hand, Tata EV Mobility, which manufactures electric vehicles (EVs), has similar or near-similar valuation as that of US-based neurotech company Neuralink ($10 billion), which was founded by Elon Musk with eight other scientists and engineers. Further, its valuation is same as that of HKC Corporation ($9 billion), a Chinese innovator in semiconductor displays.

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Adani group to invest ₹33K cr in 3 Odisha projects

Digital infrastructure, power and cement in focus

HEMANT KUMAR ROUT
Bhubaneswar, 8 April

Karan Adani, MD, Adani Ports and SEZ Ltd, interacts with Odisha CM Mohan Charan Majhi on Wednesday

The Adani group on Wednesday said the company was investing ₹33,081 crore in three projects in Odisha across digital infrastructure, power generation and cement manufacturing, aligning its expansion with the state government's ambitious road map to become a $1.5 trillion economy by 2047.

Speaking at the groundbreaking ceremony of these projects held at Bhuinpur in Khurda district, Karan Adani, managing director of Adani Ports and SEZ Ltd said the group's latest projects are part of a long-term commitment to Odisha's development trajectory.

The conglomerate will invest ₹30,181 crore in a thermal power plant near Cuttack, ₹2,100 crore in a cement manufacturing unit in the same region and ₹800 crore to set up a data centre at Info Valley in Bhubaneswar. Together, the projects are expected to generate close to 10,000 direct and indirect employment opportunities.

"The upcoming data centre would anchor Odisha's role in the digital economy, serving as critical infrastructure for artificial intelligence, cloud computing and e-governance. It will not be a building full of servers but Odisha's claim on the digital economy. The project is expected to create around 200 high-skilled jobs," Adani said.

The thermal power project, the largest among the three, is aimed at strengthening energy security in the region, he said. The plant will bring stability to the grid and energy security for the industries, he said, emphasising that reliable and affordable power was central to sustaining industrial growth. The power plant would support both large industries and micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) while generating around 7,000 jobs, Adani added.

The cement manufacturing unit will support the state's infrastructure push by ensuring local availability of the key construction material. The facility is expected to employ around 2,500 people and contribute to sectors such as housing, healthcare and transport.

Framing Odisha's growth within a broader historical continuum, Adani invoked the state's legacy — from the transformative impact of the Kalinga war on Emperor Ashoka to its maritime trade links with Southeast Asia and architectural sophistication, while underlining its enduring capacity for global influence and innovation.

The Adani Ports MD highlighted Odisha's structural advantages, including its 570-km coastline, abundant reserves of coal, iron ore, bauxite and chromite and a young workforce as key enablers of long-term growth. He also credited the state government for adopting a facilitative approach towards industry, describing it as a "partner, not a gatekeeper."

The Adani Group already has a significant presence in Odisha across ports, logistics and mining. The latest investments, Adani said, mark a shift from being a participant to a long-term builder in the state's development journey. "Taken together, these projects are a statement of belief," he said.

State rolls out ₹41K cr projects

The Odisha government on Wednesday rolled out 36 industrial projects with a cumulative investment of ₹40,811 crore, signalling a decisive shift from investment intent to on-ground execution. Speaking at the groundbreaking and inauguration ceremony at Bhuinpur in Khurda district, Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi said that the projects were expected to generate over 59,000 jobs.
HEMANT KUMAR ROUT

Pharma mkt growth touched 5-qtr high in Q4

SOHINI DAS
Mumbai, 8 April

India's domestic pharmaceutical market closed the March quarter of FY26 on a stronger footing, with growth acceleration and early indications of a volume recovery, according to data from market research firm Pharmarack.

The Indian pharmaceutical market (IPM) recorded value growth of about 10.5 per cent in Q4FY26, the highest seen in the last five quarters.

While pricing remained the primary driver, volume growth showed a notable improvement, rising to around 1.7 per cent compared with near-flat trends in earlier quarters.

Price growth was steady at roughly 5.4-5.5 per cent. Taken together, the data points to a broad-based recovery, albeit still skewed toward value growth (led by price increases) rather than pure consumption growth.

Figures in percentage; Source: Pharmarack

Monthly trends through the quarter indicate consistency rather than volatility. January began with a healthy 10.2 per cent growth, followed by a peak of around 11 per cent in February, before moderating slightly to about 10.1 per cent in March. The steady monthly trajectory suggests that demand was resilient across therapy areas, without any sharp spikes or one-off drivers.

An analysis of therapy performance shows that chronic and specialty segments continued to anchor growth during the quarter. In January, therapies such as cardiac (14 per cent), anti-diabetic (15.2 per cent) and urology (15.4 per cent) led the market, while respiratory (9.7 per cent) also posted strong gains.

February saw a similar trend, with cardiac (14.8 per cent) and anti-diabetic (15.5 per cent) therapies maintaining momentum, alongside a sharp uptick in vaccines (30.1 per cent) and steady growth in neurology (11.5 per cent) and dermatology (10.9 percent). By March, the pattern held, with cardiac (14.7 per cent) and anti-diabetic (15.4 per cent) therapies again delivering robust double-digit growth, supported by respiratory (10.7 per cent), neurology (11.6 per cent) and vaccines (22.7 per cent). The growth across months underscores the increasing dominance of chronic therapies in driving market expansion.

"Changing dynamics of the IPM indicate a strong shift from stable, seasonal demand-driven acute therapies to lifestyle-driven non-communicable diseases that are more chronic and sub-chronic in nature," said Sheetal Sapale, vice president, commercial, Pharmarack.

More on business-standard.com

Hilton signs franchise deal for 125 Hampton-branded hotels

AKSHARA SRIVASTAVA
New Delhi, 8 April

Global hospitality major Hilton signed a strategic agreement with Regenta Hotels Private Limited, owned by BSE-listed Royal Orchid Hotels Limited, on Wednesday to franchise and open 125 Hampton by Hilton hotels across the country.

"The partnership accelerates Hilton's upper mid-scale expansion in India, where rising domestic travel and growing demand from the country's expanding middle class are driving strong opportunities in the mid-market segment," the company stated in a release.

The franchised hotels will primarily be developed across western and southern markets, including Goa, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana and are expected to be opened by 2035.

"India's economic growth, expanding middle class and rapid infrastructure development are reshaping the country's travel landscape, creating significant opportunities for our brands," said Alan Watts, president, Asia Pacific at Hilton.

For Royal Orchid Hotels, the focus remains on strengthening both the Regenta portfolio and its association with Hampton by Hilton.

"We anticipate a healthy mix of greenfield developments and conversions as we scale this partnership, with approximately 60 per cent of the portfolio expected to be greenfield and 40 per cent through conversions. This balanced approach allows us to expand efficiently while tapping into existing assets across key markets," Keshav Baljee, executive director at Royal Orchid Group told *Business Standard*.

"Our new strategic partnership with the Royal Orchid Hotels demonstrates our commitment to working with established local operators, enabling us to scale our franchise footprint rapidly while maintaining the strength and consistency of Hilton's brands," added Watts.

This comes after Hilton's announcement last year, signing a strategic licensing agreement (SLA) with hotel management firm Nile Hospitality to bring 75 Hamilton brand hotels to India. The move points to a growing trend of expansion in the mid-scale segment. Several international and home-based mid-scale hotels like Ginger by Indian Hotels are charting expansion strategies on the back of sustained momentum in the Indian travel and tourism sector.

Permira to invest $100 mn in SILA to back expansion

PRACHI PISAL
Mumbai, 8 April

Funds advised by Permira will invest $100 million in the integrated business services platform SILA, aimed at accelerating the company's technology-led expansion and strengthening its presence across India's built-environment services ecosystem.

SILA operates in over 125 cities and manages around 450 million square feet of real estate assets, with a workforce of more than 60,000 employees. The investment by Permira values SILA at $250 million.

The investment will support SILA's plans to deepen its technology capabilities, expand adjacent service lines and pursue new growth opportunities. "India is creating a new generation of globally relevant, tech-enabled services companies, and SILA is among the most compelling we've seen," said Dipan Patel, co-managing partner and co-chief executive officer at Permira.

Permira is a global investment firm that partners with businesses to support their expansion ambitions. Founded in 1985, the firm advises funds with a total committed capital of about euro 89 billion.

Siddharth Narayan, head of Asia at Permira, said SILA has built a strong market position backed by deep client relationships, disciplined execution and a sustained focus on technology-led delivery.

Existing investor Norwest will continue its association with the company and retain a minority stake following the transaction. It has invested a total of $54 million between 2019 and 2025. "It's been a pleasure working with SILA since 2019," said Shiv Chaudhary, managing director, Norwest India.

Founded by brothers Rushabh and Sahil, SILA provides integrated services, material handling equipment leasing, and real estate advisory to corporates, developers and institutional investors.

Additionally, apart from Norwest, MS Dhoni's family office, and Piramal Group, are some of the existing investors in SILA.

Indian refiners begin talks for cargo via Hormuz, await shipping cos' nod

SHUBHANGI MATHUR
New Delhi, 8 April

As the US and Iran agree to a two-week ceasefire assuring the re-opening of the Strait of Hormuz, Indian refiners have initiated talks with suppliers from West Asia. Shipping companies, however, showed some hesitation in resuming cargo transport through the conflict-stricken passage, said people aware of the discussions.

Just hours before US President Donald Trump's deadline threatening to wipe out the Iranian civilisation, Tehran agreed to allow for the safe passage of ships through the Hormuz strait provided that Washington ceased its attacks on Iran. Indian refiners, highly reliant on energy supplies from West Asia, had immediately contacted suppliers including Saudi Arabia's Aramco, UAE's Adnoc and Kuwaiti companies to resume supplies via the strait of Hormuz.

Queries sent to major Indian refiners including Indian Oil Corp Ltd (IOCL), Bharat Petroleum Corp Ltd (BPCL), Hindustan Petroleum Corp Ltd (HPCL) and Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL) remain unanswered at the time of publishing.

"We have reached out to shipping companies and await their feedback. They are assessing the ground-level situation following comments from Trump and Iran," a refinery executive said on condition of anonymity.

WEST ASIA CONFLICT

India remains highly dependent on West Asia for energy supplies as the country receives around 40 per cent of crude oil, 50 per cent of liquefied natural gas (LNG) and 90 per cent of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) imports through routes linked to the Strait of Hormuz. Amid acute cooking gas shortage, India's oil companies are expected to prioritise LPG supplies from the region.

"We are prioritising critical (energy) supplies like LPG. The buyer and seller are ready but the resumption of supplies now depends on vessel owners," said another refinery executive.

Experts believe flows through the Strait of Hormuz would take months to normalise given the uncertainty in the region.

"Presuming traffic begins to flow through Hormuz, trade flow normalisation will take months, not weeks. Demand destruction — already underway — will likely continue despite the ceasefire. The bigger concern is what happens after reopening. It is likely that Hormuz will face persistent threats for the foreseeable future," said Zhuwei Wang, director of research & analysis at S&P Global Energy.

Indian oil companies are likely to face reduced pressure on marketing margins as energy prices ease in the coming days with the reopening of the critical waterway.

"While crude and product flows may take months to normalise, some supplies would start for crude oil and petroleum products like naphtha, LPG, thereby alleviating the immediate shortage. Additionally, with the prospect of supplies recommencing from the Strait of Hormuz, crude oil and LPG prices have eased thereby reducing the pressure on marketing margins and LPG under recoveries of oil marketing companies," said Prashant Vasisht, senior vice president and co-group head of corporate ratings at Icra Ltd.

India set to get 1st Iranian oil cargo in 7 yrs

India is set to receive its first oil from Iran in seven years after the US temporarily removed sanctions on Iranian oil and refined products to ease supply shortages, ship tracking data from LSEG and Kpler showed on Wednesday.

State-run Indian Oil Corp purchased the cargo, currently on the Curacao-flagged very large crude carrier Jaya, which is heading to India's east coast and is set to arrive later this week, the data showed.

Indian Oil, the country's top refiner, did not immediately respond to a *Reuters* email seeking comment. The Jaya initially went to Southeast Asian waters for discharge in China before heading to India, LSEG ship tracking shows. LSEG data shows another carrier Jordan is signalling India as its discharge location.

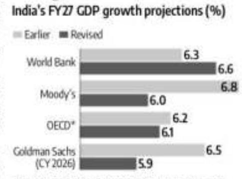
India, the world's third-biggest oil importer and consumer, has not received a cargo from Tehran since May 2019, following US pressure not to buy Iranian crude, but supply disruptions from the US-Israel war have hit the South Asian nation hard. REUTERS

World Bank ups India FY27 growth forecast to 6.6%

RUCHIKA CHITRAVANSHI
New Delhi, 8 April

On right track

India's FY27 GDP growth projections (%)



*Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development
Source: Agencies

The World Bank on Wednesday upgraded its forecast for India's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth in 2026-27 (FY27) by 30 basis points to 6.6 per cent compared to its October 2025 forecast of 6.3 per cent, citing robust domestic activity even as it expects inflation to inch up due to high energy prices.

The updated growth projection would mark a deceleration from the 7.6 per cent uptick expected in FY26, reflecting headwinds from the conflict in West Asia, with many forecasters revising their growth projections for this financial year to a range between 5.9 and 6.7 per cent. The World Bank's FY27 growth estimate is lower than the Reserve Bank of India's projection of 6.9 per cent, updated Wednesday.

The World Bank, in its South Asia Economic Update Spring 2026 edition, said that strong demand, normalising food prices, and higher energy prices are expected to push inflation up in FY27. Even though the reduction in GST rates is expected to support consumer demand in the first half of FY27, elevated global energy prices could put upward pressure on prices and constrain households' disposable income, the report noted.

The World Bank noted that while India's fiscal deficit had been declining in recent years, this trend is expected to stall or reverse as a result of increased subsidy outlays resulting from efforts to limit inflation passthrough to consumers.

The government had recently announced a reduction in additional excise duty on petrol and diesel by ₹10 per litre and a full customs duty exemption on critical petrochemical products in response to the continuing conflict in West Asia.

"Government consumption growth is expected to soften to offset higher subsidy outlays for cooking fuel and fertilisers. Investment growth is likely to moderate

costs," the update statedw.

While noting India's free trade agreements with the European Union, United Kingdom, the Bank also said that India's exports will be undermined by slower growth in major trading partners. However, India's new FTAs are doubling the scope for international market access for domestic firms from currently one-sixth to one-third of global GDP, exceeding the global market access of emerging markets such as Brazil, China, and Türkiye, the Bank noted.

India, it argued, could achieve the goal of becoming a developed country by 2047 if it could execute structural reforms. "If countries in the region were to complete structural reforms that added the equivalent of South Asia's recent forecast errors (+0.8 percentage points) on top of recent growth performance, it would significantly bring forward the date they would be expected to reach high-income status," the

India welcomes truce, calls for dialogue and diplomacy

ARCHIS MOHAN
New Delhi, 8 April

India on Wednesday welcomed a two-week ceasefire between the United States (US) and Iran, and hoped that the development in West Asia "will also encourage peace efforts in Ukraine".

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) also announced that External Affairs Minister S Jai-

LPG quota hiked to 70% for pharma, food, agriculture

The allocation would be capped at 200 tonnes per day for each sector

SHUBHANGI MATHUR
New Delhi, 8 April

The government on Wednesday increased the allocation of liquefied petroleum gas

tries mentioned above use LPG as an integral input in the manufacturing process or for specialised purposes that cannot be substituted by natural gas, the requirement shankar will visit the United Arab Emirates (UAE) on April 11 and 12. He will also travel to Mauritius on April 9 and 10 to participate in the 9th Indian Ocean Conference, as scheduled. The UAE leg was added in the context of the US-Iran ceasefire, people familiar with the development said.

In its statement welcoming the ceasefire, New Delhi reiterated its call for "de-escalation, dialogue, and diplomacy". It also stressed the need for unimpeded freedom of navigation and the smooth global flow of commerce through the Strait of Hormuz. The MEA said the conflict has already caused immense human suffering and disrupted global energy supplies and trade networks. The conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine, to which the MEA's statement referred to, have caused uncertainty for India's trade and energy supplies.

New Delhi's challenge now is to keep its relations with Iran, the Gulf countries, Israel, and the US at an even keel. India, however, rejected reports that it was paying tolls to Tehran for ships transiting through the Strait of Hormuz, pointing out that the strait is international waters. Officials said they were hopeful that India-flagged vessels will resume smooth passage through the channel in the coming days.

Jaishankar's visit to the UAE will provide an opportunity to understand the Emirati leadership's perspective on the West Asian situation, discuss energy supplies, restart India's exports to the Gulf country, and thank the leadership for ensuring the welfare of the 3.5 million Indians living and working there, sources said.

People in Srinagar raise slogans after ceasefire agreement between Iran, US and Israel PHOTO: PTI

During the visit, Jaishankar is scheduled to meet his UAE counterpart, Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan, and other senior leaders. India and the UAE share a strategic partnership that has strengthened over the past decade. UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan visited India in January.

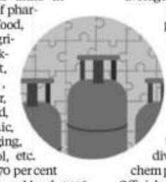
India is also watching the bitterness in UAE-Pakistan relations, with Abu Dhabi reportedly demanding that Islamabad repays the $3.5 billion that it owes the Gulf country in loans.

Regarding Pakistan's role in mediating the ceasefire, New Delhi is also of the view that it was not in a position to mediate between Iran and the US as Islamabad, given that Iran and Pakistan share a border, has done.

There is some acknowledgement that the current leadership of Pakistan, especially its Field Marshal Asim Munir, has cultivated significant access in the White House, which is partly attributable to their mutual business dealings. In February, the Donald Trump administration signed an agreement with Pakistan's government to "jointly redevelop" the Pakistan-owned Roosevelt House on Madison Avenue, reportedly worth $1 billion. The property belongs to the Pakistan government, and the redevelopment is part of its privatisation push.

During his visit to Mauritius, Jaishankar will meet the country's leadership and interact with foreign and deputy foreign ministers, including those from Egypt, Oman, and Saudi Arabia, who are attending the Indian Ocean Conference. Alongside Jaishankar's UAE visit, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri has begun a three-day visit to the US to meet senior officials, review bilateral trade and defence relations, and discuss the West Asian crisis.

(LPG) to 70 per cent for industrial units in the pharmaceutical, food, polymer, agriculture, and several other sectors. The allocation will be capped at 200 tonnes per day for each sector, according to a communication from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG).



"Industrial units in the sectors of pharmaceutical, food, polymer, agriculture, packaging, paint, uranium, heavy water, steel, seed, metal, ceramic, foundry, forging, glass, aerosol, etc. shall receive 70 per cent of the units' pre-March 2026 bulk non-domestic LPG consumption level, subject to an overall sectoral limit of 200 tonnes per day," Neeraj Mittal, secretary, MoPNG, said in a letter to states.

Units will be required to register with state-run oil-marketing companies to be eligible for the additional allocation. Commercial users will also need to apply for piped natural gas (PNG) with the city gas distribution company and take steps to adopt PNG.

"However, if the indus- relating to application for PNG shall stand waived," the letter added.

In a media briefing on the West Asia crisis, the government also said it has increased overall natural gas allocation by 5 per cent for fertiliser plants to about 95 per cent of the units' six-month average consumption.

In a relief to the petrochemical (petchem) sector, the government allowed 800 million tonnes (mt) per day of propane and butane to be diverted for petchem production.

Officials said that to ensure coal affordability, Coal India (CIL) has reduced the reserve price of coal by 20 per cent under e-auctions and increased supply through both e-auctions and the state-nominated agency mechanism.

CIL also increased the frequency of e-auctions in March 2026, offering 32.53 mt of coal, of which 13.32 mt was booked. For April 2026, 30 e-auctions have been planned, offering 25.8 mt, with 3.2 mt offered so far and 1.24 mt booked, the government said.

amid elevated uncertainty and rising input report said.

Rupee likely to stabilise at 92-93: EAC-PM Chairman

ISHITA AYAN DUTT
Kolkata, 8 April

The rupee is stabilising and could settle around the 92-93 level against the US dollar, S Mahendra Dev, chairman of the Economic Advisory Council (EAC) to the Prime Minister, said on Wednesday. He expressed confidence that foreign investment flows would return.

The US-Israel-Iran conflict in West Asia weighed on the rupee and foreign institutional investor (FII) as well as foreign direct investment (FDI) flows contributed to the pressure, Dev said. He added that the domestic currency will stabilise around 92-93. He added, "One should not worry."

The chairman, EAC-PM, was speaking on the sidelines of a session on India's Macroeconomy: Challenges and Opportunities organised by the Bharat Chamber of Commerce in Kolkata. His remarks came on a day when the United States and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire.

The rupee, which breached 95 per dollar in March, closed at ₹92.58 on Wednesday.

Dev said the Indian economy is resilient because its macroeconomic fundamentals are strong. "We also have fiscal space, which allows us to withstand shocks that many other countries cannot."

Dev added that many countries cannot spend as much on capital expenditure or on targeted sections. India is in a better position because its fiscal management is quite strong, he said. The debt-to-gross domestic product (GDP) ratio and fiscal deficit are relatively low, while reforms could help boost private capex, Dev said.

After the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday projected India's GDP growth for the current financial year at 6.9 per cent.

Calling it "reasonable", Dev said a 7 per cent growth was also achievable. He added, "I am more positive. A 6.9 per cent growth is good, but if things are better, 7 per cent growth is possible. We have inherent strength."

MUFG Bank completes stake buy in Shriram Fin for ₹39,618 crore

SUBRATA KUMAR PANDA
Mumbai, 8 April

Japan's MUFG Bank has completed its investment in Shriram Finance, subscribing to 471.1 million equity shares through a preferential allotment, marking one of the largest cross-border deals in India's financial services sector, Shriram Finance said in a press release. The investment, made at ₹840.93 per share, aggregates to about ₹39,618 crore and gives MUFG a 20 per cent stake in the non-banking financial company on a fully diluted basis, the companies said on Tuesday.

Shares of Shriram Finance closed 9.9 percent higher at ₹1023.55 per share from its previous close. The transaction follows all necessary regulatory approvals, including from the Competition Commission of India. The deal is expected to boost Shriram Finance's capital base and support its growth across key segments, particularly MSME and retail lending. The partnership will also enable the company to tap MUFG's global expertise in funding, risk management, and governance.

81% of SEZ domestic supplies will not receive benefits from one-time Customs duty relief

SHREYA NANDI
New Delhi, 8 April

As much as 81 per cent of the supplies from special economic zones (SEZs) to the rest of the country or domestic tariff area (DTA) will receive no concession under the one-time Customs duty relief implemented by the finance ministry last week.

According to an analysis done by the Export Promotion Council for export-oriented units (EOUs) and SEZs (EPCES), only about 13 per cent of supplies from SEZs to DTA will see a marginal 1 per cent duty cut.

That apart, the export promotion council is also worried that the basis of such classification and calculation of the concession is not clear. As a result, there are hardly any takers for this relief measure.

Last week, the finance ministry announced a one-time relief measure for units operating in SEZs, allowing them to sell goods domestically at a lower Customs duty for one year amid the geopolitical uncertainties.

Fine print

- Supplies worth $24.95 bn, out of $30.64 bn of goods sold domestically will not receive concession
- Goods worth $4.18 bn will receive 1% concession
- Lower duty is restricted to units that started production on or before March 31, 2025

The concession is expected to help exporters deal with the uncertainties, and enable units in SEZs to utilise idle capacity amid an unpredictable export market. The measure is effective from April 1, 2026, to March 31, 2027.

The calculations were made on the basis of the sum of DTA sales from SEZs during FY24 for key products.

According to calculations, supplies worth $24.95 billion, out of the $30.64 billion of goods sold domestically, will not receive Customs duty concession.

Similarly, goods worth $4.18 billion will receive 1 per cent concession.

The lower duty is restricted to units that started production on or before March 31, 2025.

At least 20 per cent value addition needs to be ensured and there will be a need to limit domestic sales to 30 per cent of the units' highest export value in the past three years.

The industry is also seeking a longer relief period of around three years, instead of one year that has been given by the finance ministry.

Besides, the industry, for a long time, has been seeking fair access to sell goods in the domestic market at a comparable rate with regard to free trade agreement (FTA) partner nations.

However, with the current structure of relief measures, imports under FTA will not be substituted by SEZ units.

These issues were also discussed during a meeting with the Department of Commerce on Tuesday.

ALL IN A DAY

Irdai issues revised information & cyber security guidelines

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) on Wednesday issued revised information and cyber security guidelines for regulated entities to strengthen its framework, mandating tighter governance, enhanced board accountability and frequent risk reviews. Under the new norms, the Information Security Risk Management Committee will be required to meet at least once every quarter, as against the earlier requirement of two meetings annually. BS REPORTER

NTPC, EDF sign pact for nuclear power

Power generator NTPC Ltd has signed a non-binding Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Électricité de France (EDF) to explore cooperation in developing new nuclear power projects in India. The MoU establishes a framework to jointly assess collaboration, including understanding EDF's EPR technology and its suitability for Indian requirements and exploring opportunities to maximise localisation for large-scale deployment. BS REPORTER

India's finished steel consumption grew 7% in 2025-26

India's finished steel consumption grew 7 percent to 164 million tonne (mt) last financial year, driven by increased activity in infrastructure, construction, railways, and manufacturing sectors, the steel ministry said in a statement on Wednesday. "The government's continued push on large-scale infrastructure projects and urbanisation played a pivotal role in boosting steel consumption during the period," the ministry said. BS REPORTER

Inclusion gaps in infra, tech weigh on labour force

AUHONA MUKHERJEE
New Delhi, 8 April

Barriers in access to transport, workplaces and digital systems are constraining labour force participation in India with an estimated 34 per cent of the population facing mobility-related limitations affecting jobs and skilling, said a report by audit firm KPMG and Svayam, a non-profit focused on accessibility, released on Wednesday.

The white paper noted that while only 2.2 per cent of Indians are officially classified as persons with disabilities, a much larger segment — around 486 million people — experience reduced mobility due to ageing, illness, injury, or caregiving responsibilities. This broader cohort remains largely outside the ambit of policy design, despite facing similar barriers in accessing education, training and employment.

Workforce participation among persons with disabilities remains significantly lower than the broader population, at about 36 per cent compared to roughly 60 per cent for others. This disparity is more pronounced along gender lines, with around 47 per cent of men with disabilities employed versus just 23 per cent of women. "These disparities stem from structural barriers such as attitudinal biases, inaccessible infrastructure, educational inequities, and weak inclusive hiring practices," said the report.

The report also flagged gaps in implementation of existing mandates. Less than 1.15 per cent of posts in Central ministries are held by persons with disabilities, against a statutory reservation of 4 per cent, indicating limited absorption even in government employment.

In addition to direct exclusion, accessibility gaps are seen to affect labour supply indirectly. Women spend an average of 137 minutes per day on caregiving activities, compared to 75 minutes for men, often due to lack of accessible infrastructure that increases dependency and limits workforce participation, the report said.

Mobility constraints in transport systems also impose productivity losses. The report estimated that individuals with severe mobility challenges face annual economic losses of over ₹52,000 per person due to restricted travel, missed work opportunities and higher costs.

deceased Late Mrs. Poonam Balram Israni to the names of the Mr. Deepak Israni, the Son and Mrs. Kavita Srivastav, the daughter as the joint owners and the exclusive owners/members.

Mumbai, Dated this **9th April 2026**

Sd/-
Mr. Ruben A. Fernandes
Advocate

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to public at large

This is to inform that Castor Lucknow 1 Logistics Park Private Ltd. is the absolute owner of Flat bearing No A-4404 admeasuring around 133.20 square meters RERA carpet area equivalent to 1433.78 Square Feet RERA carpet area along with the exclusive sanctioned deck area of 44.18 square meters of carpet area equivalent to 475.55 Square Feet of carpet area aggregately admeasuring 177.38 Square Meters of carpet area equivalent to 1909.32 Square Feet of carpet area, situated on the 44th Floor of the building known as 'Tower A' (also known as Tower 1) of the project known as 'Omkar 1973 Worli' in the society known as "Omkar 1973 Tower "A" Co-Operative Housing Society Ltd" ("Subject Property") constructed on all that piece and parcel of standing on land admeasuring approximately 14,501.93 Square Meters bearing CS Nos 2/914, 4/914, 914, 3/914, 1/914, 915, 1A/913(P), 913(P) and 286(P) of Lower Parel Division, Worli within the registration Sub-District and District of Mumbai city, Worli, Mumbai – 400018.

The said Subject Property was purchased by Castor Lucknow 1 Logistics Park Private Ltd. vide Registered Deed of Transfer dated 29th July 2025 duly stamped & registered at sub-registrar office of Mumbai-31, bearing Registration No. MBI-31-19153 of 2025 and is subject to the charge of Vistra ITCL (India) Limited.

All persons, having any right, title, interest, benefit, claim, or demand, if any or of any nature in or to the Subject Property, or any part/s thereof, by way of sale, exchange, gift, lease, tenancy, license, mortgage, charge, lien, trust, inheritance, bequest, easement, possession, cultivation, occupation, maintenance, memorandum of understanding, development rights, agreement to sell or otherwise howsoever, are required to make the same known in writing, together with documentary proof in support thereof, to the undersigned, at P.O. No. V. PATKE & CO. ADVOCATES, F-1, 1st floor, Shah Arcade, Rani Sati Marg, Near Western Express Highway, Malad (E), Mumbai – 400 097, within 14 (Fourteen) days of the date hereof, otherwise it shall be deemed that all such persons have surrendered and abandoned all their claims, rights, interest and title of any and all nature in the Subject Property and are left with no claim, right, title or interest of any nature in the Subject Properties.

Dated this 9th day of April, 2026

V. Patke & Co. - Advocates
F-1, 1st Floor, Shah Arcade, Rani Sati Marg, Near Western Express Highway, Malad (E), Mumbai – 400 097.

right, title and interest over the said property. By and under Deed of Release dated 10/06/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai21 – 11538 – 2025, dated 10/06/2025 for Flat No. 204. By and under Deed of Release dated 10/06/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai21 – 11541 – 2025, dated 10/06/2025 for Flat No. 304. By and under Deed of Release dated 10/06/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai21 – 11541 – 2025, dated 10/06/2025 for Flat No. 404, in Leela Residency and By and under Deed of Release dated 10/06/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai21 – 11554 – 2025, dated 10/06/2025 for Flat No. 403 and By and under Deed of Release dated 10/06/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai21 – 11549 – 2025, dated 10/06/2025 for Flat No. 503 in Aditya Breeze all the legal heirs of late Mr. Surendra Pragji Solanki had released all their undivided right, title and interest over the said property in favour of Smt. Jashanbala Surendra Solanki. Further by and under Gift Deed dated 22/12/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai16 – 19803-2025, dated 22/12/2025 for Flat No. 204. By and under Gift Deed dated 22/12/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai16 –19806 - 2025, dated 22/12/2025 for Flat No. 304. By and under Gift Deed dated 22/12/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai16 – 19801 – 2025, dated 22/12/2025 for Flat No. 404 in Leelas Residency and By and under Gift Deed dated 22/12/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai16 – 19807 – 2025, dated 22/12/2025 for Flat No. 403 and By and under Gift Deed dated 22/12/2025, duly registered with the Office of Sub-Registrar of Assurance under Serial No. Mumbai16 – 19802 – 2025, dated 22/12/2025 for Flat No. 503 in Aditya Breeze, Smt. Jashanbala Surendra Solanki had gifted, transferred and assigned all her right, title and interest over the said property in favour of his son Mr. Divyesh Surendra Solanki.

All person/s having any claim/interest in the said property or any part thereof on account of the transfer of right, title and interest of late Mr. Surendra Pragji Solanki, by way of inheritance, easement, reservation, maintenance or otherwise howsoever is/are hereby requested to inform and make the same known to the undersigned in writing, together with supporting documents in evidence thereof within 14 (Fourteen) days from the date of publication of this notice hereof at his office address, failing which the claims or demands, if any, of such person or persons will be deemed to have been abandoned, surrendered, relinquished, released, waived and given up, ignoring any such claims or demands and no subsequent claims or demands will be entertained and/or for which my Client shall not be responsible.

Advocate Jyoti A. Gaud
D/46, Kalpataru CHS, Jagjivan Nagar, Bandra Link Road, Sion, Mumbai – 400017.

Form No. 3
[See Regulation-13 (1)(a)]

DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL MUMBAI (DRT 1)

2nd floor, Colaba, Telephone Bhavan, Colaba Market, Mumbai-400005
(5th Floor, Scindia House, Ballard, Mumbai-400001)

Case No.: OA/274/2025

Summons under sub-section (4) of section 19 of the Act, read with sub-rule (2A) of rule 5 of the Debt Recovery Tribunal (Procedure) Rules, 1993.

Exh. No.: 8

EDELWEISS ASSET RECONSTRUCTION COMPANY LIMITED
VS
RADIUS SUMER DEVELOPERS PRIVATE LIMITED

To,

(1) Rahul Shah (Defendant No.3) 1201, 1202, Sumer Height, K M Munshi Marg, Chowpatty, Mumbai 400001, Maharashtra.

(2) Catalyst Trusteeship Ltd (Defendant No.4) Plot No 85, Bhusari Colony Paud Road, Pune 411038, Maharashtra.

Also At. 8th Floor, B Wing, Mittal Tower, Nariman Point, Mumbai 400 021 Maharashtra.

SUMMONS

WHEREAS, OA/274/2025 was listed before Hon'ble Presiding Officer/Registrar on **09/03/2026.**

WHEREAS this Hon'ble Tribunal is pleased to issue summons/ notice on the said Application under section 19(4) of the Act, (OA) filed against you for recovery of debts of **Rs. 4730856293/-** (application along with copies of documents etc. annexed).

In accordance with sub-section (4) of section 19 of the Act, you the defendants are directed as under:-

(i) to show cause within thirty days of the service of summons as to why relief prayed for should not be granted;

(ii) to disclose particulars of properties or assets other than properties and assets specified by the applicant under serial number 3A of the original application;

(iii) you are restrained from dealing with or disposing of secured assets or such other assets and properties disclosed under serial number 3A of the original application, pending hearing and disposal of the application for attachment of properties;

(iv) you shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise, except in the ordinary course of his business any of the assets over which security interest is created and/ or other assets and properties specified or disclosed under serial number 3A of the original application without the prior approval of the Tribunal;

(v) you shall be liable to account for the sale proceeds realised by sale of secured assets or other assets and properties in the ordinary course of business and deposit such sale proceeds in the account maintained with the bank or financial institutions holding security interest over such assets.

You are also directed to file the written statement with a copy thereof furnished to the applicant and to appear before Registrar on **11/06/2026 at 12:15 P.M.** failing which the application shall be heard and decided in your absence.

Given under my hand and the seal of this Tribunal on this date: 06/04/2026.

Signature of the Officer Authorised to issue summons.

9	Bid Submission Address	JUIDCO Bhawan, Kutchery Chowk, Ranchi, Jharkhand- 834001
10	Helpline Number of e-procurement Cell	0651-2225878

Further details can be seen on website http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in

Sd/-
PR 377005 Urban Development(26-27).D — **Project Director (Technical) JUIDCO Ltd, Ranchi**

TJSB SAHAKARI BANK LTD.

TJSB House, Plot No. B5, Road No. 2, Wagle Industrial Estate, Thane (W) – 400 604. Tel: 022-6936 8500 • Web: www.tjsb.bank.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
Permanent Closure of Banda Branch

This is to inform to all esteemed members and customers, that TJSB Sahakari Bank Ltd shall be closing its Banda Branch effective from 12.06.2026 after office hours and merging with Sawantwadi Branch w.e.f. 15.06.2026.

1	Name & Address of Branch	Banda Branch Ward No. 05, Banda, Grampanchayat No. 1699, Ground Floor, Bajarpeth, Tal-Sawantwadi, Dist.-Sindhudurg, - 416511 Email id - tjsb.194@tjsb.co.in IFSC Code: TJSB0000194
2	Name & address of Branch	Sawantwadi Branch Sawantwadi Municipality No. G-143, Ubhabazar, First Floor, Sawantwadi,Dist. Sindhudurg - 416510 Email id - tjsb.192@tjsb.co.in IFSC Code: TJSB0000192

All banking operations, including deposits, withdrawals, loans servicing and other services, will cease at Banda branch from the effective date.

Customers are requested to take a note of the above and may continue to avail uninterrupted banking services from Sawantwadi Branch or any other branch of the bank as per your convenience.

A list of all branches along with addresses is available at the Banda Branch and on the Bank's official website (**www.tjsb.bank.in**)

It is clarified that due care is being taken by the Bank to ensure that no inconvenience whatsoever is caused to the Bank's customers during the process of merger and post-merger of above branches.

For further assistance, please contact: 9136068939

Email id - **tjsb.194@tjsb.co.in**

This notice is issued in accordance with regulatory guidelines for the information of the public.

Place: Thane
Date: 09.04.2026

Managing Director & CEO
Head Office

NATIONAL PLASTIC INDUSTRIES LIMITED

Regd. Office: Vilco Centre, 114 E, 4th Floor, Subhash Road, Opp. Garware, Vile Parle East, Mumbai- 400057.
Tel.: 91-22-67669999 | **Fax:** 022-67669998
E-Mail: info@nationalplastic.com | **Website:** www.nationalplastic.com
CIN: L25200MH1987PLC044707

NOTICE for the attention of the Equity Shareholders of the Company 100 Days Campaign - Saksham Niveshak for KYC and other related Updations and shareholder's engagement to prevent transfer of unpaid/unclaimed dividends to Investor Education and Protection Fund ('IEPF')

Notice is hereby given to Shareholders of the Company pursuant to the provisions of Section 124(2), 124(5), and 124(6) of the Companies Act, 2013 ("the Act"), read with the Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (Accounting, Auditing, Transfer and Refund) Rules, 2016 as amended, ("the Rules"), and in addition to above, SEBI's clarifications regarding processing investor requests and updating KYC details through its various circulars including SEBI Master Circular No. SEBI/HO/MIRSD/POD-1/P/CIR/2024/37 dated 07/05/2024, as amended, and in line with the objectives of the Niveshak Shivir and IEPF Authority's broader drive for investor education and facilitation, IEPF Authority has launch a 100 Days Campaign - "Saksham Niveshak", targeting shareholders whose dividends have remained unpaid/unclaimed.

In view of the above, list of all shareholders whose dividend warrants/ demand drafts/claim vide dividend intimations, on the equity shares have remained unpaid/unclaimed in respect of dividend declared commencing from the dividend declared for the financial year 2018-19 is uploaded on the Company's website www.nationalplastic.com (Path - Investor KYC | National Plastic Industries Ltd)

The Company, on 17th October, 2025, communicated individually to the latest available e-mail (wherever e-mail id is available)/postal address of the shareholders, whose dividends are lying unclaimed, requesting them to update the KYC details with the Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent ('RTA') (where shares held in physical mode) and with your depositories (where shares held in demat mode), and advising them to claim the dividends expeditiously. Further, the Company has also published the newspaper notice dated 17-10-2025 informing about IEPF Authority's 100 days Campaign - "Saksham Niveshak" and to take necessary actions by the shareholders whose dividends have remained unpaid/unclaimed.

To claim unclaimed dividend or in case need any information/ clarification, please write to our RTA, M/s. MUFG Intime India Private Limited, (Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited) at C-101, 247 Park, LBS Marg, Vikhroli (West), Mumbai - 400 083, Tel. No.: 08108116767, Toll Free No. 1800 1020 878, E-mail: investor.helpdesk@in.mpms.mufg.com (Please provide 1. Name of the Company, 2. Folio No. or DP and Client ID, 3. Name of the shareholder the details in all your communications).

Kindly note that if the dividends remained unpaid/unclaimed for 7 consecutive years, the equity shares held by shareholders in the Company will be transferred to IEPF in accordance with the IEPF Rules and shareholder can claim the said equity shares from IEPF Authority, by filing e-form IEPF-5 as prescribed under said Rule, which is available on IEPF's website at www.iepf.gov.in

For National Plastic Industries Limited
Sd/-

Place : Mumbai — **Dhawal Vora**
Date : 07th April, 2026 — **Company Secretary**

Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, issued a demand notices as mentioned below calling upon the Borrowers to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of the said notice.

The borrower, having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower, in particular and the public, in general, that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under section 13(4) of the said Act read with rule 8 of the said Rules.

The borrower, in particular, and the public in general, are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Hero Housing Finance Limited, for an amount referred to below along with interest thereon and penal interest, charges, costs etc. from date mentioned below.

The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub- section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets

Loan Account No.	Name of Obligor(s) /Legal Heir(s)/ Legal Representative(s)	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount as per Demand Notice	Date of Possession (Constructive /Physical)
HHFMUMHOU19000005219, HHFMUMIPL19000005271	Indrapal Paras Chavan, Anjani Devi @ Anjani Indrapal Chauhan	19-Nov-2025 Rs. 14,09,046/- Due as on 17-Nov-2025	06.04.2026 (Physical)

Description of Secured Assets/Immovable Properties:- All That Premises Bearing Flat No. 102, Admeasuring 433.73 Sq. Ft. Built Up Area, I.e 40.31 Sq.mtr, On 1st Floor, A Wing, BLDG No.3 'Radha Residency' Of Type C1a, All The Sanctioned Fsi Admeasuring 1743.11 Sq. Mtrs. F.S.I. (Built-U.P. Area) In Building No. 03 Consisting Of A Wing, Type C1a, Area Admeasuring About 558.59 Sq. Mtrs. And Consisting Of B Wing, Type A-1, Area Admeasuring About 606.39 Sq. Mtrs. And Consisting Of C Wing, Type C1b, Area Admeasuring About 578.13 Sq. Mtrs. On The Portion Of Land Bearing Gut/survey. No. 20/1 And 20/3, Of Revenue **Village - Nagzari, Tal & Distt.- Palghar, Within The Limits Of Grampanchayat Nagzari And Sub-registrar Palgharsurvey No. 20/1, 20/3, Situated At Village Nagzari- Taluka And Dist Palghar-401404.**

DATE :- 09-04-2026,
PLACE:- PALGHAR

Sd/- Authorised Officer
FOR HERO HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

asREC (India) Limited

Bldg No. 2, Unit No. 201-202A & 200-202B, Gr. Floor, Solitaire Corporate Park, Andheri Ghatkopar Link Road, Chakala, Andheri (East), Mumbai-400 093.

APPENDIX-IV-A
Sale Notice for sale of immovable Assets Under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Security Interest Act Read with Rule 8(6) & Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002

E-AUCTION SALE notice for Sale of Immovable Properties under Rule 8(6) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule, 2002 will also serve as 15 days' notice to the borrowers, Joint/Co. borrowers, guarantors of **M/S Shriniwas Mangal Karyalaya Prop-Mr.Umesh Hari Pawar (hereinafter referred to as "the Borrower"), Mr Kailash Janardhan Dhumal and Mr Gaurav Vijay Khamkar** for sale of secured properties under SARFAESI Act and Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules. By virtue of Assignment Agreement dt. 30.03.2022 executed with **Chembur Nagrik Sahakari Bank Ltd** acting in its capacity as Trustee of ASREC-PS 08/2021-22 Trust has acquired the secured debt with securities from the original lender, notice is hereby given to the public in general and Borrower(s) and guarantor(s) in particular that the Authorised Officer hereby intends to sell the below mentioned secured property for recovery of dues, as per aforesaid demand notice issued u/s 13 (2) after giving due credit to the payment received subsequent to the said notice if any, under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and hence the tenders/bids are invited through online auction for the purchase of the secured property. The property shall be sold strictly on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" and "NO RECOURSE" basis under 8 & 9 of security interest (enforcement) Rules for recovery of dues. Recovery of **Rs. 5,91,83,031/- (Rupees Five Crore Ninety-One Lakh Eighty-Three Thousand and Thirty-One only) plus further interest as on 01.01.2026**

Lot No	Description of the Secured Assets	Reserve Price (Rs. in Lakh)	E.M.D. (Rs. in Lakh)	Bid Increment (In Rs. Lakh)	Possession
1.	All that piece or parcel of leasehold land known as "Shriniwas Mangal Karyalay" Situated at Plot No. P-7, Having Land & Building in M.I.D.C. Territory in Wai, Taluka- Wai, Dist - Satara - 412803. Total Plot Area- 5595 Sq.Mtr & Total Build Up Area of Building-2676.391 Sq.Mtr. Owned By Mr. Umesh Hari Pawar, Prop. Of Shriniwas Mangal Karyalaya	621.00	62.10	1.00	Physical

E-Auction date 24.04.2026, last date for Submission of Bid Form is 23.04.2026 upto 4.00 PM. The bid form or EMD received late for any reason whatsoever will not be entertained. Bid without EMD shall be rejected summarily. **For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to our website: http://asrecindia.co.in and http://sarfaesi.auctiontiger.net or may Contact Mr. Navinchandra Anchan - Cell No. 9820250145, 022 – 61387051, Mr. Dipesh Wadia – Cell no. 9821509508, 022-61387030** may be contacted for any query.

Date: 08.04.2026
Place: Mumbai

Sd/-
Authorised Officer & DVP(BH)
Mr. Navinchandra Anchan,
ASREC (India) Ltd.

TJSB SAHAKARI BANK LTD.

TJSB House, Plot No. B5, Road No. 2, Wagle Industrial Estate, Thane (W) – 400 604. Tel: 022-6936 8500 • Web: www.tjsb.bank.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
Permanent Closure of Shiroda Branch

This is to inform to all esteemed members and customers, that TJSB Sahakari Bank Ltd shall be closing its Shiroda Branch effective from 12.06.2026 after office hours and merging with Vengurla Branch w.e.f. 15.06.2026.

1	Name & Address of Branch	Shiroda Branch Shiroda Grampanchayat No. 461, Ground Floor, Main Road Shiroda, Tal-Vengurla, Dist.-Sindhudurg - 416 518 Email id - tjsb.198@tjsb.co.in IFSC Code : TJSB0000198
2	Name & address of Branch	Vengurla Branch Plot no.303 A, Khardekar Road, Vengurla, Sindhudurg – 416 516 Email id - tjsb.199@tjsb.co.in IFSC Code: TJSB0000199

All banking operations, including deposits, withdrawals, loans servicing and other services, will cease at Shiroda branch from the effective date.

Customers are requested to take a note of the above and may continue to avail uninterrupted banking services from Vengurla Branch or any other branch of the bank as per your convenience.

A list of all branches along with addresses is available at the Shiroda Branch and on the Bank's official website (**www.tjsb.bank.in**)

It is clarified that due care is being taken by the Bank to ensure that no inconvenience whatsoever is caused to the Bank's customers during the process of merger and post-merger of above branches.

For further assistance, please contact: 9404267764

Email id - **tjsb.198@tjsb.co.in**

This notice is issued in accordance with regulatory guidelines for the information of the public.

Place: Thane
Date: 09.04.2026

Managing Director & CEO
Head Office

4. The members who have cast their votes by remote e-voting prior to the EOGM may also attend the EOGM through VC / OAVM but shall not be entitled to cast their votes again.

5. Any person, who acquires shares and becomes a member of the Company after the Notice has been sent electronically by the Company, and holds shares as on the cut-off date, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request to investor@bigshareonline.com.

Members in case of holding shares in dematerialized form are requested to submit PAN, Contact details, Bank account details and specimen signature (as applicable) to their Depository Participant (DP) or to our RTA viz: Bigshare through Form ISR-1 and Form ISR-2 in case holdings in physical form.

Shareholder holding securities in Demat mode may contact the respective helpdesk for any technical issue related to login through depositories i.e. NSDL & CDSL at evoting@nsdl.co.in or call at: 022-48867000 and helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or contact at toll free no. 1800225533 respectively and Shareholders holding securities in physical mode facing any technical issue in login may contact Bigshare's Ivote helpdesk by sending a request at investor@bigshareonline.com.

For KJMC Financial Services Limited
SD/-
Omkar Bamne
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer
ACS: 77772

Place: Mumbai
Date: April 09, 2026

Huhtamaki India Ltd.

(CIN No. L21011MH1950FLC145537)
Regd. Office: 7th Floor, Bellona, The Walk, Hiranandani Estate, Ghodbunder Road, Thane, Maharashtra - 400607 **Tel No.:** + 91 (22) 6174 0100
Website: www.flexibles.huhtamaki.in
Email address: investor.communication@huhtamaki.com

ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO CONFERENCING (VC) / OTHER AUDIO-VISUAL MEANS (OAVM) AND RECORD DATE

Members of the Company may note that in compliance with General Circular Nos. 20/2020 dated May 05, 2020, read with General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 and other circulars issued in this respect ("MCA Circulars") read with all applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) and SEBI LODR Regulations, the 76th Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the Company will be held through **VIDEO CONFERENCING (VC) / OTHER AUDIO VISUAL MEANS (OAVM)** on **Friday, May 08, 2026 at 2.30 p.m. (IST),** to transact the business as set out in the Notice of the Meeting.

Members may kindly note that:

- Electronic copies of the Notice of the AGM and Annual Report 2025 will be sent to all the shareholders whose email addresses are registered with the Company/Depository Participant(s) and **the Company will not send physical copies of AGM Notice and Annual Report to the Shareholders.**
- Shareholders holding shares in dematerialized mode and whose email ids are not registered are requested to register their email addresses and mobile numbers with their relevant depositories through their depositary participants.
- As per SEBI circular dated November 18, 2025, if complete bank details are not registered against the folio/ demat account, all future dividend declared by the Company shall be kept in abeyance.
- Shareholders holding shares in physical mode are requested to either dematerialize their holdings or are requested to ensure their account is KYC complaint. Dividend will remitted to the Members only in electronic form provided they are KYC Complaint.
- Shareholders are requested to make their folio KYC compliant by furnishing relevant Investor Service Request Forms (ISR-1 and ISR-2) along with relevant ID and address documents, for registering their email addresses and mobile numbers and to update their bank details for receiving dividend, with the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, **MUFG Intime India Private Limited** (formerly Known as 'Link Intime India Private Limited'). The above forms are available on the Company's RTA's website at https://in.mpms.mufg.com/
- Shareholders holding shares in dematerialized mode are requested to update their bank / ECS details, where applicable, for receiving dividend through their depository participants.
- All shareholders are requested to update their KYC details at the earliest, if not done already.

Shareholders will have an opportunity to cast their vote remotely prior to the AGM or during the AGM on the business as set forth in the Notice of the AGM, through electronic voting system. The manner of voting remotely prior to the AGM or during the AGM for shareholders holding shares in dematerialized mode, physical mode and for shareholders who have not registered their email addresses will be provided in the Notice to the shareholders.

The notice convening the 76th AGM and Annual Report 2025 will also be made available on the Company's website, at www.flexibles.huhtamaki.in, the websites of Stock Exchanges at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and on the NSDL's website at www.evoting.nsdl.com.

In terms of provisions of Section 91 of Companies Act, 2013 and applicable rules framed thereunder, the Company has fixed **Thursday, April 23, 2026,** as the **Record Date** for the purpose of payment of dividend for the financial year ended December 31, 2025, as recommended by the Board. Once approved at the AGM, the dividend will be paid within 30 days of the AGM, to those members who are KYC compliant and whose names appear in the Register of Members of the Company as on **Thursday, April 23, 2026.**

Pursuant to the provisions of the new Income Tax Act, 2025 ("the IT Act"), dividend income is taxable in the hands of members and the Company is required to deduct tax at source (TDS) from dividend paid to the members at applicable rates. The shareholders are requested to update their valid PAN linked with Aadhaar with the R&T Agents/Depository Participant. No TDS would be deducted if the dividend income to a resident Individual shareholder during FY 2026-27 does not exceed ₹ 10,000/-. An email in this regard has already been sent to the relevant shareholders.

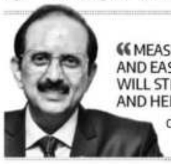
SEBI, vide its circular dated November 3, 2021 (subsequently amended by circulars dated December 14, 2021, March 16,2023 and November 17, 2023) has mandated that the security holders (holding securities in physical form), whose folio(s) do not have PAN or Choice of Nomination or Contact Details or Mobile Number or Bank Account Details or Specimen Signature updated, shall be eligible for any payment including dividend, interest or redemption in respect of such folios, only through electronic mode with effect from April 1, 2024, upon their furnishing all the aforesaid details in entirety.

The above information is being issued for information and benefit of the members of the Company and in compliance with the MCA Circulars.

By Order of the Board
For Huhtamaki India Limited

April 8, 2026
Thane

Abhijaat Sinha
Company Secretary & Legal Counsel



“MEASURES LIKE REMOVAL OF IFR REQUIREMENT AND EASING OF CRAR COMPUTATION NORMS WILL STRENGTHEN BANKS' CAPITAL POSITIONS AND HELP SUPPORT CREDIT GROWTH”

C S Setty, Chairman, SBI

“THOUGH A CEASEFIRE HAS BEEN REACHED, THE WEST ASIA CRISIS AND POTENTIAL RISKS TO GLOBAL ECONOMY, INCLUDING INDIA'S, HAVE LED TO RBI MAINTAINING THE STATUS QUO ON POLICY RATES”

P D Singh, CEO, India & South Asia, Standard Chartered Bank

“PRESERVING POLICY FLEXIBILITY ALLOWS RBI TO ASSESS EVOLVING RISKS WHILE CONSOLIDATING THE GAINS FROM EARLIER EASING MEASURES”

K Balasubramanian, India CEO & Banking Head and Indian Subcontinent Subcluster Head, Citi

A calculated pause

Against the backdrop of global headwinds, the RBI seems to have chosen an approach to steady the economy. It has rolled out measures like doing away with the IFR requirement, coming up with a new NBFC framework, and a simpler onboarding process for MSMEs on TReDS

NOT A STRUCTURAL SHIFT

Forex curbs temporary, aligned with market conditions: RBI guv

ANJALI KUMARI
Mumbai, 8 April

The recent regulatory measures to address volatility in the foreign exchange (forex) market, such as capping banks' net open positions in the onshore deliverables market, are temporary and aligned with current market conditions, and do not signal any structural shift, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra said at the post-monetary policy media briefing.

"Intervention in the forex market is aimed at smoothing excessive and disruptive volatility without targeting any specific level or band for the exchange rate. The RBI stands committed to this policy and will judiciously contain excessive or disruptive volatility to ensure that self-fulfilling expectations do not exacerbate currency movements beyond what is warranted by fundamentals."

He said the $100 million limit on open positions is not intended to be permanent. "These are reactions to specific market movements. In no sense do they signal any structural change. We remain committed in the long term to the development, broadening, and deepening of these markets through the internationalisation of the rupee. These are not measures that will remain in place forever," the governor said. The rupee, which declined over 4 per cent in March following the West Asia conflict, has gained 2.4 per cent since these directions came into force.

On March 27, the central bank directed banks to restrict their daily net open forex positions to $100 million, superseding earlier frameworks that linked limits to capital levels. Compliance is required by April 10.

RBI Deputy Governor T Rabi Sankar said at the post-policy press conference that the recent measures have not restricted foreign investors from hedging in domestic markets, and all participants continue to have full access to hedging avenues.

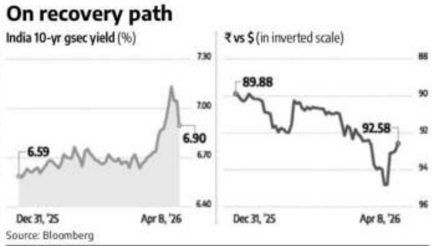
He added that the central bank will closely monitor how markets respond. Initially, the RBI had only asked for positions to be wound down by imposing limits. However, after assessing market behaviour, it observed that while market makers and authorised dealers typically act responsibly and contribute to market depth, some positions were being shifted around instead of being reduced.

"As an initial step, we expected the signal to calm markets, but that did not happen. Positions were being reassigned, so we had to take further measures to contain them," he said, explaining the decision to bar banks from offering non-deliverable forward contracts to clients. The rupee has been on an appreciation streak for the past five trading sessions. On Wednesday, the rupee appreciated 0.4 per cent against the dollar, supported by a two-week ceasefire between the US and Iran, dealers said.

The local currency settled at 92.58 per dollar, compared with the previous close of 92.99 per dollar.

The yield on the benchmark 10-year government bond witnessed its sharpest single-day decline since May 10, 2022, driven by a fall in crude oil prices, dealers said. The benchmark yield settled at 6.9 per cent, compared with the previous close of 7.05 per cent.

On recovery path



Source: Bloomberg

CAPITAL NORMS EASED

RBI proposes scrapping IFR, allows quarterly profit inclusion in CRAR

SUBRATA PANDA
Mumbai, 8 April

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday eased key rules that are expected to have a positive impact on banks' capital ratios. The central bank proposed to do away with the investment fluctuation reserve (IFR) requirement for commercial banks, and also allowed banks to include quarterly profits in capital to risk-weighted assets ratio (CRAR) calculations irrespective of fluctuations in provisioning levels.

Under current guidelines, commercial banks can include quarterly net profits in CRAR only if provisioning for non-performing assets (NPAs) does not deviate by more than 25 per cent from the four-quarter average — a condition the RBI has now proposed to remove. The central bank has also proposed to dispense with the Investment Fluctuation Reserve (IFR), as most commercial banks already maintain capital for market risk and follow updated norms for investment classification and valuation.

"The NPA-related change will mainly help in smoothing (out) CRAR over the year. Earlier, banks were not allowed to include quarterly profits in CRAR; this could only be done at the end of the financial year. Now, with the change, profits earned in each quarter can be included in CRAR as they accrue. That said, in overall terms, the end result remains the same, so there is no material difference on a full-year basis", said a senior banker at a state-owned lender, adding that the IFR change, however, is more significant.

"Most banks maintain around 2 per cent or so in IFR, which will now no longer be required. It remains unclear how this will be treated — whether it will be transferred to profits or handled in some other manner — and further clarity is awaited," he said. Through the reversal, banks could free up an IFR corpus of around

₹35,000-40,000, according to an SBI Research report. Banks can use this corpus optimally and judiciously between Common Equity Tier 1 (CET-1) capital and profit & loss account, even when yields have moved up substantially during the previous quarter, the report added.

According to Suresh Ganapathy, head of Financial Services Research, Macquarie Capital, the IFR requirement being done away with, in case banks fully reverse it, will be around 20-30 bps for most banks.

"However, we believe banks are unlikely to reverse and may stop making incremental IFR every year. Banks anyway today have excess capital," he said, adding that the other measure is merely a reporting change for quarterly CAR (capital adequacy ratio) reporting with respect to accounting for NPA provisions and doesn't change the full year CAR number for banks. IFR is a buffer that banks maintain to protect against potential losses arising from fluctuations in the value of their investment portfolios, particularly due to mark-to-market (MTM) movements when interest rates change.

Banks set aside a portion of their profits into this reserve, which can be used to absorb losses when bond prices fall, thereby ironing out the impact on earnings.

Investment fluctuation reserve status

	FY25-IFR (₹ cr)	IFR as % of RWA
Kotak Mahindra Bank	4,000	0.8
State Bank of India	11,500	0.3
Bank of Baroda	2,400	0.3
Axis Bank	2,900	0.3
ICICI Bank	3,400	0.2
HDFC Bank	5,600	0.2
IndusInd Bank	600	0.1

IFR: Investment fluctuation reserve; RWA: Risk-Weighted Assets
Source: Macquarie Research

WEST ASIA CONFLICT IMPACT

Slowdown in remittances not likely: DG Gupta

ANUPREKSHA JAIN
Mumbai, 8 April

Remittances to India from West Asia are unlikely to decline despite the conflict as demand for migrant workers from the region is expected to rise, which could further support inflows, said Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta at the post-monetary policy press conference.

Remittances originate from a diverse range of regions, with the share from Gulf countries declining over time, she said adding that this diversity also extends to the skill composition of migrants, encompassing low, medium, and high-skilled workers across countries, all of whom contribute to remittance flows. "We are not anticipating a decline, especially, if the crisis is going to be resolved very soon. We anticipate the demand for migrant workers will in fact increase from this region, which will help remittances further," said Gupta.

Meanwhile, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, in his monetary policy statement, said that weaker global growth prospects might dampen external demand and reduce remittance flows.

Gaura Sen Gupta, chief economist, IDFC First Bank, said: "Two things can happen, people would send back their money as a precautionary move or they might migrate to home because of the crisis. We feel that the impact could be more in the longer term." "Post-Covid, we had seen more migration to the US, Europe, Singapore. As a result, the remittances from these areas have picked up. The US is now the largest supplier of remittances. As per RBI Remittance Survey, US accounts for 27.7 per cent share, GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council) share reduced to 33.8 per cent and share of UK increased to 10.8 per cent and Singapore to 6.6 per cent," Sen Gupta said. Economists said that over a period, share of GCC may come down in total remittances but it will not affect the overall remittances.

'Quite possible that rates will remain low in the near to medium term'

RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra (*2nd from left*) with Deputy Governors Swaminathan J (*left*), T Rabi Sankar, and Poonam Gupta before the press conference on monetary policy statement, in Mumbai on Wednesday Photo: KAMLESH PEDNEKAR

Q&A Reserve Bank of India Governor **Sanjay Malhotra**, along with Deputy Governors **Swaminathan J, T Rabi Sankar**, and **Poonam Gupta**, addressed a range of issues during a post-monetary policy press conference. Edited excerpts.

One structural change in this policy seems to be that you have started providing the figure for the core inflation rate. While the full-year inflation average rate is 4.4 per cent, that for the second half moves closer to 5 per cent. Should the markets be prepared for a rate increase, especially as liquidity tightens?

■ **Malhotra:** This has been a long-standing request from market participants, and we felt this was the right time to introduce it, especially after completing the five-year review. That said, I would not call it a shift in monetary policy. Core inflation has always been tracked internally and we are now sharing the projections.

The monetary policy is not on a pre-set path. Our target remains headline inflation, and we must ensure it stays within the band. At the same time, we do analyse all components of inflation and their drivers before taking a decision.

On the second question, again, there is no predetermined course. The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) will assess how various factors evolve. The situation is rapidly changing, and we will take a call based on the incoming data.

One year ahead the inflation rate is projected at 4.7 per cent, implying a real interest rate of around 50 basis points as against an estimated neutral rate of about 1.5 per cent. Does that mean the policy is below neutral? Also, on recent RBI measures to curb rupee volatility, such as the cap on the net open position and restrictions on contracts, are you satisfied with their impact, and could these be withdrawn now that the conditions have changed?

■ **Malhotra:** On the forex measures first, there was heightened volatility in late March, with positions building up and creating arbitrage between offshore and onshore markets. While such linkages are useful in normal times, excessive positioning can distort price discovery. These measures were taken to address that specific situation and are not structural. We remain committed to deepening and internationalising the rupee market. So these steps are not permanent. On the neutral rate, we do not have a precise estimate. The real rate at present is still around 2 per cent, so it is not low. Given the high uncertainties, particularly from supply-side factors, the MPC decided to pause and wait for more clarity before acting.

In February, the guidance was that the rate, barring shocks, would remain low for 9-12 months. A shock has occurred, but there is now some clarity. Would you reiterate that comfort if conditions stabilise?

■ **Malhotra:** Our stance is "neutral". So outcomes in either direction are possible. That said, India's macroeconomic fundamentals remain strong and resilient. Even with the recent shocks, the growth rate has been projected at 6.9 per cent. It is quite possible that the rates will remain low in the near to medium term, but that will depend on how conditions evolve.

In your projections how long is the West Asia crisis presumed to last?

■ **Malhotra:** It is difficult to give a timeline. What matters more for us is the impact on commodity prices, especially energy, and the extent and duration of supply disruption. If supply shocks persist, they can eventually translate into demand-side effects over several months.

Are you seeing any sign of stress building up in banking because of supply disruption, high energy prices, and weak external demand? Is the transmission of the earlier rate cuts into the lending rates and deposit rates complete?

■ **Malhotra:** On banks, we do not see any systemic concern regarding their profitability or health. Yes, some pockets or sectors will be hit. Again, it will depend on the extent. The government has done a wonderful job as of now in trying to secure these inputs and reduce supply-chain disruption. It will depend on how long this continues. Against 125 basis points, about 90 basis points is the transmission that we have seen on the lending side. Similarly, on deposits, it is more than 100. So, there has been satisfactory transmission.

Isn't this growth assumption of 6.9 per cent too optimistic, given the fact that supply-chain normalisation, especially that of gas, takes quite a long time?

■ **Malhotra:** No, we do not think that it is too optimistic. However, we have mentioned that there are more risks to the downside rather than to the upside and that would happen primarily for the reasons that you are stating. If there is a prolonged disruption in supplies, which we hope should normalise sooner rather than later, that can put pressure on the assessment of growth at 6.9 per cent. This is a reduction in comparison to last year of about 70 basis points. So, it is not small.

More on businessstandard.com

OPINION

MPC avoids knee-jerk reaction, preserves policy flexibility


SIDDHARTHA SANYAL

The status quo on the key policy rates and the neutral stance maintained in the current meeting by the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC), the six-member rate-setting body of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), was no surprise. The RBI commentary, while retaining policy flexibility amid exceptionally high uncertainty, was justifiably cautious and vigilant.

The RBI's articulation of supply-side shocks weighing on both price and demand — and its conscious choice to avoid pre-emptive rate action — lent the current policy added significance as a meaningful reset of expectations.

Accordingly, the one-year overnight index swap (OIS) curve softened sharply by around 29 basis points (bps) during the day (and over 45 bps during April), as the possibility of an imminent rate hike faded significantly after today's policy.

Going ahead, the growth-inflation outlook is heavily contingent on the duration of the West Asia conflict and the extent of damage to energy infrastructure and cross-border economic activities. The recent two-week US-Iran ceasefire and the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz are clearly positive developments, but a sustained easing of global uncertainty will hinge on concrete progress in diplomatic negotiations. Even though external conditions pose a significant risk, the RBI pointed out that the pause was also cushioned by resilient momentum in domestic activity across manufacturing and services. It projected 2025-26 economic growth at 7.6 per cent, while sequentially moderating 2026-27 growth estimate to 6.9 per cent, reflecting the possible spillovers from external headwinds.

While headline consumer price index (CPI) -based inflation remains contained — supported by comfortable agricultural buffer stocks, strong kharif output and excise duty cuts — the RBI highlighted rising upside risks as higher energy and commodity prices impacted input costs, alongside emerging weather-related risks from a potential El Niño.

The central bank, accordingly, raised its 2026-27 inflation projection to 4.6 per cent, with a visible pickup expected in the middle of the year.

The RBI reiterated its commitment to ensuring sufficient liquidity after infusing durable liquidity of around ₹3.5 trillion through open-market operation (OMO) purchases and $20 billion in forex swaps in 2026 so far. The recent administrative measures augur well for credit flow to productive sectors like industries — weighted contribution of industrial credit to overall bank credit has started inching higher in recent months from a markedly low print about six months ago and has scope for further expansion.

In sum, the RBI commentary clearly acknowledged the deterioration in global growth-inflation dynamics, while consciously avoiding overreaction, given the domestic economy's comparatively resilient fundamentals. Through a demonstrably balanced policy outlook, the RBI effectively alleviated market concerns of a knee-jerk response, a reassurance evident in the softening of the OIS curve. The current policy configuration thus reinforces a "wait and watch" stance, with the balance of risks tilted toward supporting growth rather than prematurely constraining it.

Importantly, even in the absence of a policy rate action, the RBI retained a broad and flexible toolkit — encompassing calibrated liquidity operations, targeted prudential measures and discretionary foreign-exchange interventions — allowing it to aid credit transmission, manage the rupee's volatility and preserve orderly market conditions..

The author is chief economist & head of research at Bandhan Bank. The author thanks Sudarshan Bhattacharjee and Gaurav Mukherjee for assistance. Views are personal

QUELLING CONCERNS

Banking system safe, strong: Guv

SUBRATA PANDA
Mumbai, 8 April

India's banking system is resilient, safe, and strong, said Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday, adding, central-bank regulations related to conduct, governance, and prudence, along with its supervisory framework, helped keep it robust.

Malhotra's comments came after fixed deposit-related frauds involving a few private-sector banks were found.

His remarks also gain significance in the context of the HDFC Bank episode, in which Atanu Chakraborty, as part-time chairman, resigned abruptly, citing certain developments that were incongruent with his values and ethics.

This has triggered commentary on governance at the bank although the RBI has denied any such concerns, stating that there were "no material concerns" on record regarding HDFC Bank's conduct or governance.

The episodes that have come to light are bank-specific and are more in the nature of criminal incidents, Malhotra said at the post-monetary policy press meet. "While we have to be vigilant, the law-enforcement authorities will take care of these (incidents)," Malhotra said.

Deputy Governor Swaminathan J said, "These are entity-specific developments, and they do not pose any systemic risk at this point in time. As they play out, we deal with them on a bilateral basis. The banking system remains resilient, and we continue to focus on conduct- and governance-related matters. Banks are by and large run on professional lines. Any material supervisory concerns, as and when they arise, are dealt with on an event-specific basis."

If any regulatory tweak was required at a system level, "we are not averse to taking such measures but at this point in time there is no event which warrants a macro prudential measure or a regulatory tweak", he added.

Word of assurance

- Several instances of fixed deposit-related frauds at private banks have come to light recently
- RBI Governor says these episodes are bank-specific and do not pose any systemic risk at this point
- Deputy Governor Swaminathan says RBI is not averse to making any regulatory tweak at system level if needed
- RBI denies any immediate stress but supply-chain disruptions could lead to stress in some pockets

In late February, IDFC First Bank stated that it had detected, in a branch in Chandigarh, a ₹590 crore fraud pertaining to accounts related to the Haryana government.

The issue came to light after a government department sought to close its account with the bank and transfer the funds to another lender. However, the amount mentioned by the department did not match the balance in the account. The bank has paid nearly ₹650 crore to the relevant departments of the Haryana government, and is working with the state authorities and law-enforcement agencies to pursue action against the perpetrators of the fraud and recover the dues.

AU Small Finance Bank also faced a similar situation pertaining to fixed deposits with the Haryana government.

In March, Kotak Mahindra Bank said it had filed a formal complaint with the Panchkula Police after an alleged fraud involving fixed deposits belonging to the Panchkula Municipal Corporation came to light, with the lender stating that it was undertaking a reconciliation of the deposits and linked accounts. The bank, however, has not quantified the amount.

Separately, the RBI said while there was no immediate stress, there could be pockets where it could emerge due to supply-chain disruption.

"... insofar as the banks, we are not seeing any systemic concerns with regard to their profitability and their health. Yes, there will be pockets or sectors that will be hit because of the present crisis (West Asia). The government has done a wonderful job in trying to secure these inputs and reduce supply-chain disruption. It will all depend on how long this continues," Malhotra said.

"We have not seen any stress so far, but many companies are operating at a significantly reduced level, and some are even sharing capacity. This situation cannot continue for long. If it persists, they will eventually face problems, and asset quality will be impacted with a lag."

BANKER'S TRUST

RBI goes for extended pause before rate hike

TAMAL BANDYOPADHYAY

There was no surprise in the first monetary policy of 2026-27 (FY27), as the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC), the six-member rate-setting body of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), left the policy rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent. The decision was unanimous. The MPC also decided to continue with a "neutral" stance.

One wouldn't call the tone of the policy hawkish, but RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra seems to be preparing the market for an extended pause before future rate hikes. At the moment, the overnight index swap (OIS) market, which reflects the future interest rate trajectory, is pricing in three rate hikes for the current year. That might be unlikely, but there could be rate hikes in future. When? Not too soon. The two-week ceasefire in the US-Israel-Iran war has changed the pitch, albeit for the time being.

The 10-year bond yield dropped to 6.90 per cent, 14 basis points lower than Tuesday's close. The rupee closed at 92.58 a dollar, 42 paise stronger. And equities roared. Though the policy was a non-event, the ceasefire announced on Wednesday cheered the markets.

The MPC has recognised that the intensity and the duration of the West Asia conflict and its impact on the energy and other infrastructure are adding risks to both inflation and growth outlooks. At this juncture, the decision is to wait and watch the changing circumstances and the evolving growth-inflation outlook. The RBI will remain vigilant, closely monitoring incoming information and assessing the balance of risks.

The signal is clear: If the uncertainties continue and the supply-side shock intensifies, there will be a rate increase.

In his post-policy interaction with the media, Malhotra was non-committal on the rate front. "...it is quite possible that low rates will continue for a long time, as I mentioned — structurally, Indian economy is very strong, very resilient, very robust.... Structurally, long-term macroeconomic fundamentals — because of the various measures taken by the government, the RBI and various institutions — remain very strong and continue to drive growth, while at the same time keeping price pressures contained. So, it is possible that even in the short to medium term, we will continue to have low rates."

The governor flagged five critical concerns in his statement. While elevated crude oil prices could increase imported inflation and widen the current account deficit, disruptions in energy markets, fertilisers and other commodities could adversely impact industry, agriculture and services, reducing domestic output.

It doesn't end there. Heightened uncertainty, increased risk aversion and safe-haven demand could impact domestic liquidity conditions, economic activity, consumption and investment, even as weaker global growth prospects might dampen external demand and reduce remittance flows.

Finally, adverse spillovers from global financial markets could tighten domestic financial conditions and raise the cost of borrowing.

The RBI, of course, reiterated its commitment to remain proactive and pre-emptive in liquidity management and ensure sufficient liquidity in the banking system to meet the productive requirements of the economy.

Higher energy and other commodity prices, coupled with supply shocks, would affect growth. Assuming the adverse impact of the West Asia conflict would not last long, the RBI projected real gross domestic product (GDP) growth for FY27 at 6.9 per cent — 6.8 per cent in the first quarter, 6.7 per cent in the second, 7 per cent in the third, and 7.2 per cent in the fourth. There is a rider, though: There may be downside risks to the domestic growth outlook if the war continues.

For the same reasons, the consumer price index (CPI)-based inflation for FY27 is projected at 4.6 per cent — 4 per cent in the first quarter, 4.4 per cent in the second, 5.2 per cent in the third, and 4.7 per cent in the fourth.

Possibly for the first time, the RBI has given an estimate of non-food, non-energy inflation (core inflation) at 4.4 per cent. Excluding precious metals, it's even lower, indicating that underlying inflation pressures are expected to remain contained. Still, there is a caveat here too — the risks are on the upside.

Incidentally, the 4.6 per cent inflation estimate is based on the assumption of crude price at $85 a barrel. The Monetary Policy Report – April 2026, released simultaneously along with the policy statement, projects average inflation higher at 5 per cent in FY27 and 5.1 per cent next year, assuming crude price at $90 a barrel.

Postscript

Going beyond theories and assumptions, a close reading of the policy tells us all about the uncertain times:

- The word "uncertainty" has been used in the governor's statement seven times — four times referring to geopolitics, and twice following the adjective "heightened".
- "Deficit" has been used five times — thrice in reference to "current account" and twice to "trade".
- "Geopolitics" has appeared four times.
- The word "risk" has been used 13 times (once, in a different context, though — referring to banks' capital to risk-weighted assets ratio). Thrice it is preceded by the adjective "upside" and twice "downside".
- "Disruption" appears six times — thrice referring to "supply chain".
- The word "pressure" has been used five times and "volatility" thrice, preceded by adjectives such as "heightened" and "disruptive".
- "Heightened" appears five times in the statement, "disruption" six times and "disruptive" twice.

Of course, the statement has balanced these by using the word "resilience" thrice, and "strong" eight times — referring to momentum of economic activities, macroeconomic fundamentals, credit growth and FDI pipeline, among others. The language of the policy clearly communicates what the RBI is seeing and how it is preparing itself for uncertain times.

The writer is an author and senior advisor to Jana Small Finance Bank Ltd. His latest book: Roller Coaster: An Affair with Banking. To read his previous columns, log on to www.bankerstrust.in. X: @TamalBandyo

HIGHLIGHTS

Average unclaimed deposit payouts rise to ₹760 crore a month

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday said that post campaign and incentives, the monthly payout to customers from unclaimed deposits increased to ₹760 crore from October onwards, compared with an average monthly payout of ₹180 crore from April 2025 to September 2025. In its post-policy press meet, Lakshmi Kanth Rao, executive director, RBI, said: "There were two events. One is the campaign for three months from October to December by DFS, Government of India, and also RBI. So, that led to a lot of unclaimed deposits being returned to the claimants. Also, we have come out with incentive scheme to the banks, which also helped. It is around the same time. So, both these initiatives actually led to a lot of amounts being returned." BS REPORTER

CBDC transaction volume tops 150 mn, value exceeds ₹34K cr

The volume of central bank digital currency (CBDC) transactions has topped 150 million, with the total value of transactions exceeding ₹34,000 crore so far, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Deputy Governor T Rabi Sankar said at the post-monetary policy press meet. RBI is working on developing programmability for CBDC, which is the distinguishing feature of this form of digital currency. "CBDC is an innovation whose time has come. It is the future of payments. But there is a right time to launch it. The right time depends not only on our readiness but also on other countries, because its advantage is in the cross-border sector. We are gradually moving, getting the technology and use cases right. We are developing programmability. It is all in the works," Sankar said. BS REPORTER

Term money mkt open to NBFCs, corporates to boost liquidity

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) will allow participation of non-bank entities, including AIFIs, NBFCs, housing finance companies, and corporates in the term money market, the central bank said on Wednesday in the Statement on Developmental and Regulatory Policies. The RBI said that the step was taken to deepen liquidity and strengthen monetary policy transmission. The State Bank of India said in its report that since banks are net lenders in the term money market, the move is positive as it broadens demand for funds and enables better deployment of intraday surplus liquidity. It is also expected to have a moderating impact on yields going forward. The central bank has also decided to enhance borrowing limits for standalone primary dealers to support market activity. The central bank has also decided to enhance borrowing limits for standalone primary dealers to support market activity. BS REPORTER

Simpler onboarding process of MSMEs in Treds for easing biz

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday proposed to dispense with the requirement for MSMEs' due diligence when onboarding the trade receivables discounting system (Treds) platform, to promote ease of

EASING BURDEN

RBI may rationalise board norms, shift focus to strategy, policy

SUBRATA PANDA
Mumbai, 8 April

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is planning to revise and rationalise directions for bank boards to enable them to focus on policy and strategic matters rather than being overburdened with operational issues.

"...to facilitate better utilisation of bank boards' time, after a comprehensive review of all our extant instructions, we propose to revise and rationalise the matters requiring their attention," RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said.

"One had been hearing from the boards that a lot of operational matters were also coming to them, as a result of which they were not able to concentrate on real policy and strategic matters. So, that's the reason why we have brought this up," Malhotra said.

This move follows the recent episode at HDFC Bank, where former part-time chairman, Atanu Chakraborty, resigned abruptly, citing certain developments at the bank that were incongruent with his values and ethics. Sources had said there was a relationship issue between the bank's management and the former chairman, leading to his sudden exit.

That said, the RBI quelled fears, stating there are "no material concerns" on record regarding HDFC Bank's conduct or governance. The bank remains well-capitalised, with its financial position satisfactory and liquidity adequate. It also noted that the bank is a Domestic Systemically Important Bank (D-SIB), with sound financials, a professionally run board, and a competent management team.

THE RBI EMPHASISED THAT THE ULTIMATE RESPONSIBILITY FOR A BANK'S PERFORMANCE, CONDUCT, AND CONTROL RESTS WITH THE BOARD

A senior banker at a state-owned bank said this RBI move is not linked to the HDFC Bank episode, but has been in the works for some time based on feedback from banks that they keep adding more items for boards to oversee. Similarly, under the Companies Act and LODR (listing obligations and disclosure requirements) requirements, other regulators also continue to expand the list of matters requiring board attention. As a result, boards have become heavily compliance-driven, the senior banker said.

"One common concern raised with regulators is that, because so many matters are placed before the board, it is not able to focus adequately on strategy. Instead, boards are largely occupied with regulatory requirements — what needs to be presented, reviewed, or approved — most of which is compliance-driven," he further said.

The RBI has released draft guidelines on governance of commercial banks, proposing that boards can delegate certain responsibilities to the board or management committees while retaining oversight of material decisions. Boards may delegate the review of policies to committees, approving only material amendments, the contours of which must be clearly defined.

The draft norms lay down key principles to guide boards in determining which matters should come before them. The RBI emphasised that the ultimate responsibility for a bank's performance, conduct, and control rests with the board, even as it may delegate operational aspects to committees or senior management with appropriate reporting structures.

Boards will also be required to clearly define which matters need their approval and which can be handled at lower levels, taking into account statutory and regulatory responsibilities. At the same time, the central bank has stressed that boards must ensure adequate time is devoted to strategic issues and risk governance. The framework assigns the chairperson a central role in setting the agenda for board meets, while requiring boards to ensure they receive sufficient and relevant information from management to discharge their duties effectively.

MOVE TO REDUCE COMPLIANCE

New framework for NBFCs very soon

ANUPREKSHA JAIN
Mumbai, 8 April

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is set to introduce a new framework for categorisation of non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) into upper, middle, and lower level NBFCs, Governor Sanjay Malhotra said on Wednesday. "We are coming up with a new framework for the NBFCs very soon. New framework for categorisation of NBFCs into upper, middle, lower," he said.

Currently, NBFCs are classified under a scale-based regulation (SBR) framework, introduced in October 2021, which groups entities into four layers — base, middle, upper, and top — based on their size, systemic importance, and risk profile.

Under this framework, the RBI periodically identifies NBFCs that fall into the upper layer (NBFC-UL) based on asset size and scoring methodology. For 2024-25, the list includes large players such as Bajaj Finance, Shriram Finance, Tata Capital, Aditya Birla Finance and Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services, among others.

The list also features housing finance companies such as LIC Housing Finance and PNB Housing Finance, as well as core investment entities like Tata Sons Private Limited, reflecting the diversity within the upper layer.

NBFCs are categorised based on liability structure, deposit taking and non-deposit taking, and by activity, including investment and credit companies, housing finance companies, microfinance institutions and others.

The RBI (as of February 2026) also proposed exempting small NBFCs with no public funds, no customer interface, and assets under ₹1,000 crore from registration. Eligible NBFCs can apply for voluntary deregistration via PRAVAAH portal by September 30, 2026, to reduce regulatory compliance.

▸ FROM PAGE 1

RBI maintains status quo; pegs FY27 growth at 6.9% with downside risks

Malhotra acknowledged that the Rupee depreciated more in FY26 than the average decline in previous years. The Indian unit depreciated over 4 per cent in March following the West Asia conflict.

This prompted the central bank to unveil regulatory measures like capping net open position of banks in the ... tive volatility to ensure that self-fulfilling expectations do not exacerbate currency movements beyond what is warranted by fundamentals," Malhotra said.

"Out of the eight statements by the current governor, this statement is the most cautious/hawkish in our opinion, but that does not ... "The MPC seems convinced that higher inflation is, in fact, a supply shock outcome. We do not expect it to respond in any hurry via a rate hike, especially as the two-week ceasefire offers relief," they said in a note.

The governor noted that Indian banks remain resilient and system-level financial ...

RBI policy prudent, well-calibrated: Bankers welcome regulatory measures

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai, 8 April

Bankers termed the Reserve Bank's move to hold rates in its policy review on Wednesday as a prudent and well-calibrated measure.

Sector-specific moves like the removal of the Investment Fluctuation Reserve requirement and easing of CRAR (capital and risk-adjusted ratio) computation were also welcomed by bankers. "The RBI's deci- ... director and chief executive, Ajay Kumar Srivastava, said the status quo reflects a 'safety first' approach wherein the central bank is prioritising macroeconomic stability. "A cautious stance is warranted amid evolving global uncertainties, particularly geopolitical tensions in West Asia and volatility in crude oil prices," he said.

The removal of due diligence requirements for onboarding onto the TReds platform is a progressive step ... costs, following supply chain disruption relating to crude oil, gas and other commodities," he said.

Standard Chartered Bank's chief executive for the country and South Asia, P D Singh, said the potential risks from the West Asia crisis resulted in the status quo in rates.

"The measures to enhance capital metrics through review of the incremental provisions on non-performing assets and the investment fluctuation reserve, improving ease of trade busidoing business and encourage greater MSME participation on the platform. In monetary policy, guidelines for Treds were issued in 2014 and subsequently updated in 2018 to facilitate timely access to working capital for MSMEs. The scope of Treds was further expanded in 2023 with the inclusion of insurance companies as the fourth participant. "A comprehensive review of other extant instructions has also been undertaken, and draft directions will be issued shortly for public consultation," RBI said. BS REPORTER

offshore onshore deliverable and barred banks to offer non-deliverable contracts to their clients. Following these steps, the rupee changed trajectory and has appreciated 2.4 per cent.

"The RBI stands committed to this [exchange rates are market determined] policy, and would judiciously contain excessive or disrup-

mean a rate hike is imminent," said State Bank of India Group Chief Economic Adviser Soumya Kanti Ghosh. "We expect a prolonged pause as the natural outcome under current uncertain global environment," he said in a note.

Economists at Barclays concurred that there may not be a rate hike any time soon.

parameters related to capital adequacy, liquidity, asset quality and profitability of Scheduled Commercial Banks (SCBs) continue to remain healthy. He said bank credit maintained its upward trajectory and remained broad based.

The next meeting of the MPC is scheduled for June 3 to 5, 2026.

sion to maintain a status quo stance amid ongoing global uncertainties reflects a prudent and well-calibrated approach aligned with market expectations," C S Setty, who chairs the largest lender SBI and also industry grouping IBA, said in a statement.

Setty said the regulatory moves will help strengthen banks' capital positions and help support credit growth on a sustained basis.

Indian Overseas Bank's managing

that will significantly enhance liquidity access and working capital efficiency for small businesses, he said.

AU Small Finance's founder, managing director and chief executive Sanjay Agrawal said the decision to hold rates is a pragmatic one, which signals that the economy has resilience. "Market has digested the RBI's caution about upside risks to inflation and downside risk to growth over the baseline scenario due to rise in input

ness for MSMEs and development of the term money market continue the structural business-friendly measures announced by RBI," Singh said.

Among the non-banks, Muthoot Finance's managing director, George Alexander Muthoot, said the policy reinforces confidence in India's economic fundamentals, and added that he expects credit demand to remain resilient in the near term as growth momentum sustains.

Govt raises non-urea subsidy by 10-21 % as fertiliser prices increase

SANJEEB MUKHERJEE
New Delhi, 8 April

With fertiliser prices rising sharply due to the West Asia crisis, the Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved a 10-21 per cent increase in per-kilogram (kg) subsidy rates for non-urea fertilisers for kharif 2026 under the Nutrient-Based Subsidy (NBS) regime, compared with kharif 2025. The move will cost the exchequer around ₹41,534 crore — about 12 per cent more than the previous season.

"The Cabinet's approval of a ₹41,500 crore fertiliser subsidy is a prudent and timely measure to mitigate the cascading impact of supply disruptions and price volatility arising from the West Asia conflict. By ensuring the continued availability of key fertilisers at stable prices, the decision safeguards farmers' input affordability during the critical kharif season," Chirag Jain, partner — agri and allied sector at Grant Thornton Bharat, said in a statement.

The hike as per some experts could also mean that unless global prices of finished products such as Diammonium phosphate (DAP), and other complex fertilisers ease considerably, or the cost of raw materials such as sulphur, phosphate, potassium ammonia used in the domestic production of P&K (phosphorus and potassium) fertilisers declines, India's fertiliser subsidy could overshoot the 2026–27 (FY27) Budget Estimates. Imported Triple Super Phosphate (TSP) has also been brought under the subsidy regime. The Gulf region accounts for 20-30 per cent of India's urea requirement and 30 per cent of DAP imports, and also supplies nearly 50 per cent of the country's liquefied natural gas imports — a key feedstock for urea production.

Subsidy maths

Nutrient-based subsidy rates for kharif 2026-27 season (₹/kg)

Items	Kharif 2025-26	Rabi 2025-26	Kharif 2026-27	Chg from FY26 Kharif (in %)
Nitrogen(N)	43.02	43.02	47.32	10.00
Phosphorus(P)	43.6	47.96	52.76	21.01
Potassium (K)	2.38	2.38	2.38	0.00
Sulphur (S)	2.61	2.87	3.16	21.07

Note: Nutrient-based subsidies are fixed twice in a financial year. First, during kharif season that runs from April to September; second, for rabi season from October to March Source: Government of India and others

The higher subsidy also suggests that the Centre will continue to ensure that DAP, the second-largest fertiliser by use in India, is sold at ₹1,350 per 50 kg bag, with the government absorbing the additional cost.

In FY27, the Centre had budgeted ₹54,000 crore for non-urea fertilisers out of a total fertiliser subsidy allocation of ₹1.7 trillion. This was nearly 10 per cent lower than the revised 2025–26 estimate of around ₹60,000 crore. Following Wednesday's decision, the per kg subsidy on nitrogen has been increased by 10 per cent compared with the last kharif season, while that on phosphorus has risen by 21 per cent and that on sulphur by 21.07 per cent.

The subsidy on potash remains unchanged at ₹2.38 per kg. The decision, taken at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, fixes subsidy rates for the April 1 to September 30 period. Subsidies are extended across 28 grades of P&K fertilisers under the NBS scheme, in force since April 2010. Globally, since the outbreak of the West Asia conflict, urea prices have risen by about $200–250 per tonne from pre-conflict levels to nearly $700 per tonne. DAP prices have also increased from $650–670 per tonne to $850 per tonne during the crisis.

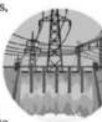
India imported about 5.65 million tonnes (mt) of urea, 4.57 mt of DAP, and 2.54 mt of ammonia in 2024–25 (FY25). Retail prices of non-urea fertilisers such as DAP, muriate of potash, and nitrogen (N), phosphorus (P) and potash (K) are decontrolled and determined by manufacturers, while the Centre provides fixed subsidies each year. According to a recent Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations paper, India — the world's second-largest fertiliser producer and consumer after China — consumed about 70.7 mt of fertiliser products in FY25.

Hydropower projects worth ₹40,000 cr in Arunachal get nod

SUDHEER PAL SINGH
New Delhi, 8 April

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday approved an investment of ₹40,000 crore to set up two hydro electric project (HEP) in Arunachal Pradesh.

This includes ₹14,105.83 crore for the construction of Kalai-II HEP on the Lohit river in Anjaw district and ₹26,069.50 crore for the construction of Kamala HEP in Kamle, Kra Daadi & Kurung Kumey districts. The estimated completion periods for the two projects are 78 months and 96 months, respectively.



The Kalai-II project will be set up with an installed capacity of 1,200 megawatt (Mw) and is expected to generate 4,852 million units (MUs) of power annually. As the first hydro project in the Lohit Basin, it will strengthen power supply in the state, support peak demand management, and contribute to balancing the national grid.

"The project will be implemented through a joint venture company between THDC India Ltd and the Government of Arunachal Pradesh. The Government of India shall extend ₹599.88 crore as budgetary support for the construction of roads, bridges and associated transmission lines under enabling infrastructure, besides central financial assistance of ₹750 crore towards the state's equity share," CCEA said in a statement.

The Kamala HEP will be set up with an installed capacity of 1,720 Mw and is expected to generate 6,870 MUs of energy. The power generated from the project apart from strengthening the supply position in the state, will also provide flood moderation benefit in the Brahmaputra valley.

"In addition to Kamala HEP, other hydropower projects — Subansiri Lower (2,000 Mw) and Dibang Multipurpose (2,880 Mw) are under construction, and Etalin (3,097 Mw) is planned for development by NHPC Ltd in Arunachal Pradesh," CCEA said.

The Kamala HEP will be implemented through a joint venture company between NHPC and the state government. The Centre will extend ₹4,743.98 crore as budgetary support towards the flood moderation component and ₹1,340 crore as budgetary support for enabling infrastructure, including the construction of roads, bridges and associated transmission systems.

CCEA okays ₹79,459 cr revised cost of Rajasthan oil refinery

SUDHEER PAL SINGH
New Delhi, 8 April

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Wednesday approved the increase in the cost of HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Ltd (HRRL) project to ₹79,459 crore from ₹43,129 crore, along with additional equity investment of ₹8,962 crore by Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL).

The total equity investment of HPCL after the increase will stand at ₹19,600 crore. HRRL is being set up as a highly complex refinery with more than 26 per cent petrochemical product slate, and production capacity of 1 million tonne per annum (mtpa) of petrol and 4 mtpa of diesel.

The refinery will also produce 1 mtpa of polypropylene, 0.5 mtpa of linear low density polyethylene (LLDPE), 0.5 MTPA of high density polyethylene (HDPE) and around 0.4 mtpa of benzene, toluene and butadiene.

"All these products are critical to our energy and industrial ecosystem in sectors like transportation, pharma, paints, packaging industries, etc. The project will lead to energy independence and reduce import dependence of the petrochemical sector. The scheduled commercial operation date is July 1," the CCEA said in a statement.

The HRRL refinery project is considered important in view of the growing energy needs and the petrochemical requirements of the country and speciality products production. It is expected to reduce the country's dependence on imports and save foreign exchange. "This project will contribute towards industrialisation of a backward area, usage of locally available Mangala crude and help in promoting India as a refining hub," CCEA said.

₹13,000 cr Jaipur Metro Phase-II expansion project cleared

The Union Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved Jaipur Metro Phase 2 on Wednesday. This 41-kilometre North–South corridor from Prahladpura to Todi Mod, comprises 36 stations at a total project cost of ₹13,037.66 crore.

The Rajasthan Metro Rail Corporation Limited (RMRCL), an equal joint venture between the Government of India and the state government of Rajasthan, will implement the project. The Phase 2 corridor will provide connectivity to key activity nodes including Sitapura Industrial Area, VKIA, Jaipur Airport, Tonk Road, SMS Hospital and Stadium, Ambabari, and Vidhyadhar Nagar. It includes underground stations at the airport area. BS REPORTER

OPINION

Together, let us empower our *Nari Shakti!*

NARENDRA MODI

In the coming days, India will be immersed in a festival season, with celebrations taking place across the length and breadth of the nation. The people of Assam will mark Rongali Bihu, while Odisha will celebrate Maha Bishuba Pana Sankranti. In West Bengal, Poila Boishakh will usher in the Bengali New Year, and in Kerala, Vishu will be observed with immense enthusiasm. In Tamil Nadu, Puthandu will be celebrated, while in Punjab and other parts of North India, it will be Baisakhi, which will usher in a spirit of hope and positivity. I convey my best wishes to all those across India and the world who are marking these festivals. May these auspicious occasions bring happiness and prosperity to everyone's lives.

Furthermore, on April 11, we celebrate Mahatma Phule's 200th birth anniversary, and on April 14, India will pay homage to Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar on Ambedkar Jayanti.

In addition to these special occasions, when the spirit of renewal fills our hearts and minds, our nation stands at the threshold of another historic occasion. It is an opportunity to deepen the foundations of our democracy and to reaffirm our collective commitment to equality and inclusion.

On April 16, Parliament will be convened to discuss and pass an important Bill that advances women's reservation. To describe this merely as a legislative exercise would be an understatement. It is a reflection of the aspirations of millions of women across India. It is an affirmation of a principle that has long guided our civilisational ethos, that society progresses when women progress.

Women constitute nearly half of India's population. Their contributions to our nation are vast and invaluable. Today, India is witnessing remarkable achievements by women across fields. From science & technology to entrepreneurship, from sports to the armed forces, and from music to the arts, women are at the forefront of India's progress. Over the years, sustained efforts have been made to create an enabling environment for women's empowerment. Greater access to education, improved health care, enhanced financial inclusion and better access to basic amenities have strengthened the foundations of women's participation in economic and social life.

Yet, their representation in the world of politics and legislative bodies has not always been commensurate with their role in society. This is particularly unfortunate because when women participate in administration and decision-making, they bring with them experiences and insights that enrich public discourse and improve the quality of governance.

I APPEAL TO ALL MEMBERS OF PARLIAMENT, ACROSS PARTY LINES, TO COME TOGETHER IN SUPPORT OF THIS IMPORTANT STEP FOR THE WOMEN OF INDIA. LET US SEIZE THIS OPPORTUNITY WITH A SENSE OF RESPONSIBILITY AND PURPOSE

It is imperative that the 2029 Lok Sabha elections and the Assembly elections in the various states in the times to come are conducted with women's reservation in place. Over the decades, there have been repeated efforts by previous governments to secure women's rightful place in democratic institutions. Committees have been made and Bill drafts have been introduced, but these have not seen the light of day. But the broad consensus has remained that women's representation in legislative bodies has to increase. In September 2023, Parliament passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam with the same spirit of consensus. I consider it to be among the most special occasions of my life.

This opportunity to ensure women's reservation also resonates deeply with the spirit of our Constitution. The makers of our Constitution envisioned a society where equality is both enshrined and realised in practice. Strengthening women's participation in legislative institutions is an important step towards fulfilling that vision. It reflects our commitment to building a society where every citizen has an equal stake in shaping the nation's destiny.

This is a moment that cannot be deferred any longer. Every delay in advancing women's representation is, in effect, a delay in strengthening the quality and inclusiveness of our democracy. For decades, the need for greater participation of women in legislative institutions has been acknowledged, discussed and reaffirmed. To postpone action now would mean extending an imbalance that we already recognise and have the capacity to correct. At a time when India is moving forward with confidence and purpose, it is essential that our institutions reflect the aspirations of all citizens, especially those who form half our population. Timely action will not only honour long-standing commitments but also ensure that the momentum of progress is sustained. This is a truly historic opportunity to make our democracy more representative, responsive and future-ready.

This moment calls for collective action. It is not about any one government, party or individual. It is about the nation as a whole recognising the importance of this step and coming together to realise it. It is what we owe our *Nari Shakti*. That is why the passage of a Bill for women's reservation should reflect the broadest possible consensus and be guided by the larger national interests. Such opportunities call upon us to act not for ourselves, but for future generations. They remind us that the true strength of a democracy lies in its ability to evolve and to become more inclusive over time.

As we approach this historic Parliament sitting, I appeal to all Members of Parliament, across party lines, to come together in support of this important step for the women of India. Let us seize this opportunity with a sense of responsibility and purpose. Let us act in a manner that reflects the highest traditions of our democracy.

India has always shown that when it comes to matters of national importance, it can rise above differences and act with unity. This is one such moment. Let us move forward together and strengthen constitutional values and empower our *Nari Shakti* for national progress.

The author is Prime Minister of India

FROM PAGE 1

Markets soar on shaky Iran-US ceasefire

FPI outflows were below their average of about ₹7,000 crore per session since the conflict began. DII inflows have averaged nearly ₹7,500 crore over the same period.

The India Vix, the volatility gauge, declined 20 per cent to 19.7. Broader markets also strengthened, with the Nifty Midcap 100 and Nifty Smallcap 100 rising more than 4 per cent each. All sectoral indices ended higher, led by auto and realty, which gained more than 6 per cent each.

gas and fertiliser prices are unlikely to revert quickly to pre-war levels. The key variable is not the ceasefire headline, but whether shipping flows, insurance costs and actual energy transit normalise. Confidence in safe passage remains uncertain," he added.

Market participants warned that the volatility could persist. "The volatility will continue for some time. Elevated oil prices are already having a cascading impact on inflation, interest rates and

point proposal. Nonetheless, he said the US was prepared to discuss with Iran much-desired sanctions relief.

The shift to diplomacy came as countries including Kuwait, Bahrain and the United Arab Emirates (UAE), as well as Israel, reported ongoing missile attacks into Wednesday, sewing confusion about when and how the ceasefire would be enforced. Saudi Arabia's oil pipeline to the Red Sea was hit by a drone strike, according to a person familiar with the matter.

Further uncertainty surrounded whether the ceasefire includes Israel's campaign in

struggled to understand if they can safely transit the vital waterway. Brent crude fell as much as 17 per cent to $92 a barrel, while European natural gas futures posted their biggest decline in more than two years, shedding as much as 20 per cent. Trump's ceasefire announcement represented a dramatic climb-down from a warning earlier on Tuesday that "a whole civilisation will die tonight, never to be brought back again" if Iran didn't give in. His threatened attacks on Iran's civilian infrastructure, including power plants, may have been considered war crimes if they were carried out.

information. US Vice President J D Vance said at an event in Budapest that Trump has achieved Washington's military objectives in Iran, having set out to "decimate" Iran's ability to wage conventional war, while describing the truce as "fragile." Both the US and Iran are portraying the ceasefire as a "victory," but significant differences remain between their demands to bring the war to a complete end, according to Mona Yacoubian, a senior adviser with the Middle East Program at the Center for Strategic and International Studies.

"Iran says it will allow free passage for the next two weeks

between US and Iranian officials in the coming days, *CNN* reported, citing US officials.

The complete terms of a possible pact weren't disclosed. Trump only said the US had received a 10-point proposal from Iran, describing it as "a workable basis on which to negotiate." Iran's demands include its continued control of the Strait of Hormuz, acceptance of its nuclear-enrichment activities, the lifting of all primary and secondary sanctions, and a withdrawal of US combat forces from the region, according to a statement by its Supreme National Security Council carried by state media.

might have to push a PLI kind of a scheme for that. We are in discussion with the finance ministry to see the kind of support that would give us investment in this particular area," Sarangi added.

Last month, the ministry introduced ALMM List-III to promote domestic manufacturing of ingots and wafers.

Under this provision, solar projects will be required to source these components locally starting June 2028, supporting the goal of a fully integrated solar supply chain. At present, ALMM List-I for solar modules is already in force, while ALMM List-II for solar PV cells is set to come into effect on June 1.

BS SUDOKU #4856

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lowed an 8 per cent correction since the start of the conflict.

Analysts said the durability of the rally would depend on developments in energy markets and supply chains. "If oil prices continue to fall and logistics normalise, markets can begin to unwind stagflation risks," said Stephen Dover of the Franklin Templeton Institute. He cautioned, however, that damage to Gulf energy infrastructure could delay a full recovery in supply.

"Supply normalisation will not be immediate. Oil, natural

growth expectations for FY27 may moderate from 14-15 per cent to 10-12 per cent. If oil averages around $100 this financial year, growth could slip to single digits," said Dhiraj Relli, managing director and chief executive of HDFC Securities. Market breadth remained strong, with 3,832 stocks advancing and 575 declining. All but three Sensex constituents ended higher. HDFC Bank, up 5.7 per cent, was the largest contributor to gains, followed by ICICI Bank, which rose 5.1 per cent.

US, Iran agree to talk in Islamabad, even as Strait stays blocked for now

Trump had made a series of dubious claims about the terms of the agreement in a social media post on Wednesday morning. He said the Islamic Republic has gone through a "regime change," even though there have been no signs this week that new leadership had taken hold.

He also indicated the US would use its own 15-point plan as the basis of negotiations with Tehran, after saying on Tuesday that the sides would begin discussions off of Iran's 10-

waging a parallel war against the Iran-aligned Hezbollah militia. Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, a key mediator, said the truce included Lebanon, but Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu disagreed. The Israeli military on Wednesday said it had carried out its largest operation against Hezbollah since the start of the Iran war, targeting more than 100 of the militia's command centers and military sites within 10 minutes. Oil and gas prices plummeted on news of the ceasefire, which paves the way for a potential resumption of energy supplies via the Strait of Hormuz — through which about fifth of oil and liquefied natural gas supplies flows.

Iran Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi pledged to reopen the critical chokepoint as part of the ceasefire agreement, albeit in coordination with Tehran's military. Hormuz appeared to remain largely blocked in the early hours of the agreement on Wednesday, as shipowners

died in the near six-week war.

In a posting on Truth Social, Trump said "there will be no enrichment of uranium" — a reference to longstanding efforts by Washington and Israel to curb Iran's nuclear program. He also announced plans to impose 50 per cent tariffs on US imports from any country that sold weapons to Iran. It's unclear how he would follow through on that threat, since the US Supreme Court curbed his authority to impose certain levies unilaterally.

Kuwait's army on Wednesday said it's still dealing with "intense" attacks. The US expected orders to stand down from strikes would take time to reach Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, Axios reported. Such lags are typical in conflicts, with hostilities often continuing before gradually tapering off.

Explosions occurred at Iran's Lavan Refinery after the start of the truce, the semi-official Mehr reported, without saying where it got the

but in coordination with Iran's armed forces. If the US agrees to that, that is a huge concession to Iran," she said. Although Trump claimed to have stopped Iran's nuclear program, there's been no mention of its missile or drone programs or support for proxy groups.

Pakistani PM Sharif invited all sides to Islamabad to continue negotiations. Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian confirmed the Islamic Republic would participate, according to a statement by the Pakistan prime minister's office. Vance, US Envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner are expected to attend potential in-person talks

be extended by mutual agreement, though Iran will enter talks with "complete distrust," its state media said. The focus will be on Hormuz and if ships can pass safely through the vital waterway. While some vessels have made it through the strait in recent weeks, they've not been from countries Iran views as hostile or having at least tacitly supported the US and Israeli strikes. Over 800 freighters are stuck inside the Gulf, mostly waiting to leave, and shipowners and insurer groups have warned that more details will be needed to determine if safe transit is possible.

BLOOMBERG

MNRE, FinMin in talks to launch PLI for polysilicon

Globally, the polysilicon industry is highly concentrated, with Chinese firms accounting for over 93 per cent of production. The sector acts as the primary feedstock sup-

plier not only for solar photovoltaic but also for the semiconductor industry. "We think ALMM may not work for polysilicon because the stakeholders are different. So, we

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SOLUTION TO #4855

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7	9	4	2	6	3	5	1	8
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Medium: ★★★
Solution tomorrow

HOW TO PLAY
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Dhaka seeks more oil, fertilisers from India

Bangladesh foreign minister in New Delhi, meets Jaishankar, Puri, Doval

ARCHIS MOHAN
New Delhi, 8 April

During his two-day visit to New Delhi, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman met External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Wednesday. He also met National Security Advisor Ajit Doval as the two countries set out to mend bilateral ties.

During the discussion, Jaishankar said that visas for Bangladeshi citizens, especially medical and business visas, would be eased in the coming weeks, according to the Bangladesh High Commission. Rahman thanked Petroleum Minister Puri for India's recent diesel supply to Bangladesh. He also requested an increase in the volume of diesel and fertiliser supplies to Bangladesh.

The two sides resolved to accept the reality of the challenges confronting them as immediate neighbours who share history, borders and water. It was agreed to set aside irritants, such as the extradition of Sheikh Hasina, former prime minister of Bangladesh, and to strengthen trade and investment ties. Dhaka is keen on having more investment in Bangladesh from India's public and private sector as well as the revival of projects that were stalled after Hasina's ouster.

Dhaka is also seeking the reversal of increased tariffs on

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar *(right)* with Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman during a meeting in New Delhi on Wednesday PHOTO: PTI

its shipments, especially textiles, levied in recent months at India's inland ports. The two sides are discussing the possibility of Bangladesh PM Tarique Rahman's visit to India soon. Given the sentiments in Bangladesh, if not for his maiden bilateral visit abroad, Bangladesh's PM could travel to India after paying a visit to Dhaka's other smaller allies or neighbours.

Khalilur Rahman landed in New Delhi on Tuesday. He was accompanied by Humayun Kabir, Adviser on Foreign Affairs to the Prime Minister of Bangladesh. The Bangladesh Foreign Minister met NSA Doval on Tuesday evening over dinner. On Wednesday, Bangladesh EAM Rahman and Kabir met Jaishankar and Puri and discussed trade relations as well as energy supplies. Bangladesh High Commissioner to India, Riaz Hamidullah, was also present during the meetings.

The visit was described by the Bangladeshi side as a "signal" and "desire" to mend ties, which plummeted during the 18-month tenure of the Muhammad Yunus-led interim government, which took over after Hasina's ouster in August 2024.

The Bangladeshi side reiterated its request to extradite former PM Sheikh Hasina and her home minister Asaduzzaman Khan Kamal to Bangladesh since they have been given the death penalty by the International Crimes Tribunal.

During his meeting with Khalilur Rahman and Kabir, Foreign Minister Jaishankar reiterated India's desire to engage constructively with the new government in Bangladesh and further strengthen bilateral ties.

The Tarique Rahman-led Bangladesh Nationalist Party took office on February 17, with Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla attending the oath-taking ceremony. The two sides agreed to explore proposals for deepening the partnership through the relevant bilateral mechanisms. Follow-on official meetings are expected to take place at an early date, the Ministry of External Affairs said.

The BNP government led by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman would pursue its foreign policy in accordance with the principle of 'Bangladesh First' and on the basis of mutual trust and respect and reciprocal benefit, the Bangladeshi Foreign Minister said.

He thanked the Indian government for apprehending the suspected killers of student leader Osman Hadi, and the two sides agreed that the arrested men would be sent back to Bangladesh in accordance with the procedures laid out in the bilateral extradition treaty.

DATANOMICS

April 9 polls: A look at candidate demographics

SNEHA SASIKUMAR

Assembly elections in Assam (126 seats), Kerala (140 seats), and Puducherry (30 seats) will be held in a single phase on April 9. But beyond the manifestos and campaign promises lies a question worth asking: Who exactly are the candidates seeking votes for the next five years?

PHOTO: PTI

Polling officials board a boat on the Brahmaputra river to reach polling stations, in Assam on Wednesday

Youth barely in poll fray

Young candidates account for less than 6 per cent of the total, with most contestants concentrated in the 41-60 age group.

Age-wise candidates (in %*)

Kerala, Assam, Puducherry to vote today

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, 8 April

Kerala is all set for a crucial Assembly election on Thursday, with 27.1 million voters poised to cast their votes in a decisive contest that will test the ruling Left Democratic Front's (LDF) bid for a third consecutive term, the Opposition United Democratic Front's (UDF) comeback prospects, and the National Democratic Alliance's (NDA'S) push to open its account in the state.

After nearly a month of intense campaigning, the southern state will go to the polls in a single phase, with voting to be held from 7 am to 6 pm across all 140 constituencies where 883 candidates are in the fray.

The electorate comprises 13.2 million men, 13.9 million women and 273 transgender persons, along with over 242,000 overseas voters, underlining the scale of the electoral exercise, according to Election Commission figures.

The contest, though triangular, is rooted in Kerala's traditionally bipolar political

*Total won't add to 100 as figures have been rounded off Sources: ADR, *BS* calculations

Educated candidates on the ground

Most candidates hold at least secondary qualifications. Assam leads in graduate representation, with a nearly 30 per cent share. Kerala, despite high literacy, has candidates who passed only Class 10.

Education level of candidates (in %)

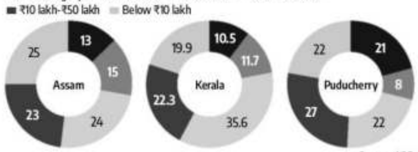
Education level	Assam	Kerala	Puducherry
Illiterate	0	0.12	1.37
Literate	0.42	0.81	0.69
10th Pass	15.24	25.38	19.24
Graduate	29.36	16.57	16.84
Graduate professional	6.79	13.89	14.09
Post Graduate	15.37	13.56	14.09
Doctorate	1.66	1.97	1.03
Diploma	1.66	5.1	8.59

Sources: ADR, BS calculations

Puducherry leads in affluence

Puducherry leads in wealthy candidates, Assam shows an even spread, and Kerala is dominated by candidates with assets below ₹2 crore.

Share of wealth among candidates (in %)



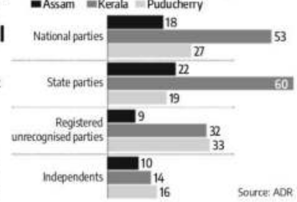
Source: ADR

Kerala tops list of contenders facing criminal charges

Kerala has the highest share of candidates with criminal cases, particularly among state parties.

*Total will not add to 100 in all cases as some figures have been excluded and rounded off

Candidates with criminal cases (in %*)



Source: ADR

landscape, where power has largely alternated between the LDF and the UDF.

The outcome of this election will indicate whether that pattern holds or if the state is headed towards a shift.

Led by Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, the Left Front has foregrounded its 10-year governance record, highlighting infrastructure development, welfare schemes and crisis management. The UDF has also attempted to sharpen its political messaging by alleging an understanding between the CPI(M) and the BJP, while accusing the Left of links with outfits like the SDPI, the political arm of the banned Islamist outfit Popular Front of India (PFI).

In Assam, more than 150,000 security personnel have been deployed as part of arrangements for Thursday's polling in Assam that will decide the fate of 722 candidates hoping to enter the 126-member state Assembly.

Officials said 31,940 polling stations have been set up in 35 districts for the single-phase polling. Micro-observers have been deputed in sensitive polling stations.

The results will be declared on May 4.

While most personnel set out for the polling stations on Wednesday morning, those deployed in remote areas such as Karbi Anglong and Dima Hasao districts left on Tuesday itself, Chief Electoral Officer Anurag Goel said.

As many as 25 million electorate, which comprises 12.5 million men, 12.5 million women and 318 from the transgender community, will decide the fate of the 722 candidates in the fray. Among the electorate, 63,423 are service voters, 642,314 voters are in the age group of 18-19 years, 250,006 are above 80 years of age, and 205,085 are persons with disabilities.In Puducherry, around 950,000 voters will decide the electoral fate of 294 candidates in the Assembly elections on April 9 and all arrangements have been made for smooth conduct of polls, CEO P Jawahar said on Wednesday.

The polling will begin at 7 am in Puducherry and its enclaves of Karaikal, Mahe and Yanam, which together have 30 Assembly seats. The union territory has 1,099 polling stations and of them 209 have been identified as vulnerable.

Smoke rises from an explosion in the Abbasiyeh neighbourhood following an Israeli strike, in Tyre, Lebanon, on Wednesday PHOTO: REUTERS

Day after, Trump turns dovish on Iran

> US PRESIDENT SWITCHES FROM 'STONE AGE' THREAT TO TALK OF 'GOLDEN AGE' FOR W ASIA

> UNCERTAINTY STILL LOOMS AS HORMUZ REMAINS BLOCKED, ISRAEL CONTINUES TO POUND LEBANON

REUTERS
8 April

The United States will work closely with Iran and the two countries are discussing tariff and sanctions relief, US President Donald Trump said on Wednesday, following the announcement of a two-week ceasefire.

Trump's upbeat talk towards Iran in three Wednesday social media posts marks a dramatic, 24-hour turn in tone. On Tuesday, he had threatened to end the country's whole "civilization" while on Wednesday he declared "A big day for World Peace!" Trump said on social media that many of the 15 points in the US plan proposed to Iran had been agreed to, but did not elaborate.

"We are, and will be, talking Tariff and Sanctions relief with Iran," Trump said.

On the other hand, Israel carried out its heaviest strikes on Lebanon centres and military sites were targeted in Beirut, the Bekaa Valley and southern Lebanon, it said.

The strikes killed 89 and wounded 700, according to Lebanon's health ministry. In Beirut, *Reuters* reporters saw people on motorcycles picking up wounded and transporting them to hospitals because there were not enough ambulances to get them in time. A group of firefighters worked to put out flames in a car park after one strike left more than a dozen cars scorched and mangled.

The head of Lebanon's syndicate of doctors, Elias Chlela, called in a written statement for "all physicians from all specialities" to head to any hospital they could to offer help.

One of Beirut's biggest hospitals said it was in need of donations of all blood types.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said overnight that the ceasefire suspending the six-week-

NNA had reported continued Israeli strikes across southern Lebanon earlier in the day, including artillery shelling and a dawn airstrike on a building near a hospital that killed four people. An Israeli strike on the southern city of Sidon killed eight people and wounded 22 others, Lebanon's health ministry said.

Hezbollah stopped attacking Israeli targets early on Wednesday, three Lebanese sources close to the group told *Reuters*. The group's last public statement on its military activity was posted at 1 a.m. (2200 GMT Tuesday), saying it had targeted Israeli troops inside Lebanon on Tuesday evening.

The group is likely to issue a statement outlining its formal position on the ceasefire and on Netanyahu's assertion that Lebanon is not included, the three Lebanese sources said.

French President Emmanuel Macron said the situation in Lebanon, a former French protectorate across Lebanon," senior Hezbollah lawmaker Ibrahim al-Moussawi told *Reuters*.

Most of Wednesday's strikes were in civilian-populated areas, Israel's military said. Hours before the strike, the military had issued warnings for some areas of southern Beirut and southern Lebanon. No such warning was given for central Beirut, which was alsohit.

Following the strikes, Israeli military spokesperson Avichay Adraee claimed on X that Hezbollah had moved out of its traditional Shi'ite stronghold in southern Beirut's Dahiyeh neighbourhood to religiously mixed areas of the city, including in the north.

Addressing Hezbollah, he said, Israel's military will "pursue you and act with great force against you wherever you are".

Trump: 50% tariffs on nations supplying Iran with weapons

US President Donald Trump said

Iran confirms it will attend talks with US in Islamabad, says Pak

Pakistan said Iran has confirmed its participation in peace talks with the US in Islamabad later this week as global efforts mount for a permanent agreement to end the war in the Middle East after a two-week ceasefire.

President Masoud Pezeshkian "reaffirmed Iran's participation in the upcoming negotiations with the US and expressed appreciation for Pakistan's efforts," according to a statement by Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's office after a conversation between the two leaders on Wednesday. US has not confirmed its participation.

Pakistan's Sharif earlier requested the two sides for a ceasefire and offered to host them in Islamabad on April 10. The nuclear-armed Pakistan has leveraged its close ties with both Iran — with which it shares a border — and the US to negotiate a ceasefire deal between the two countries.

WORLD REACTS TO CEASEFIRE

I EARNESTLY AND SINCERELY URGE ALL PARTIES TO EXERCISE RESTRAINT AND RESPECT THE CEASEFIRE FOR TWO WEEKS, SO THAT DIPLOMACY CAN TAKE A LEAD ROLE TOWARDS PEACEFUL SETTLEMENT OF THE CONFLICT

Shehbaz Sharif, Pakistan PM

TOGETHER WITH OUR PARTNERS WE MUST DO ALL WE CAN TO SUPPORT AND SUSTAIN THIS CEASEFIRE, TURN IT INTO A LASTING AGREEMENT AND REOPEN THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ

Keir Starmer, British PM

IT (THE CEASEFIRE) BRINGS MUCH NEEDED DE-ESCALATION. NOW IT IS CRUCIAL THAT NEGOTIATIONS FOR AN ENDURING SOLUTION TO THIS CONFLICT CONTINUE

Ursula Von Der Leyen,

since the conflict with Hezbollah broke out last month, even as the Iran-aligned group paused attacks on northern Israel and Israeli troops in Lebanon under a two-week US-Iran ceasefire.

Consecutive explosions shook Beirut, sending smoke billowing across the capital, as Israel's military said it had launched the largest coordinated strike of the war. More than 100 Hezbollah command

old US-Israeli war against Iran did not apply to Lebanon, and the Israeli military said operations against Hezbollah there would continue.

That position contradicted comments by Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, a key intermediary in the US-Iran ceasefire talks, who had said the truce would include Lebanon.

Lebanon's state news agency

remained critical and called for Lebanon to be included in the deal. Lebanese President Joseph Aoun, welcoming the US-Iran ceasefire, said Beirut would continue its efforts to ensure that Lebanon was included in any lasting regional peace agreement.

"Hezbollah was informed that it is part of the ceasefire "so we abided by it, but Israel as usual has violated it and committed massacres all

on Wednesday that imports from countries supplying Iran with military weapons will face immediate 50 per cent tariffs with no exemptions, announcing the threatened duty in a social media post just hours after agreeing to a two-week ceasefire with Tehran.

Trump's Truth Social post did not specify which legal authority he would invoke to impose such tariffs.

Pakistan Defence Minister Khawaja Asif on Wednesday said his country was now being recognised as a "credible and trusted" mediator both in the region and globally, hours after the US and Iran agreed on a ceasefire facilitated by Islamabad. "It (ceasefire) is the success of our entire leadership...Arab states, our neighbouring brother Iran showed confidence in Pakistan and the US is looking at us," he said, adding that Pakistan was the "centre of attention". PTI

CEASEFIRES ARE ALWAYS GOOD NEWS... THE GOVERNMENT OF SPAIN WILL NOT APPLAUD THOSE WHO SET THE WORLD ON FIRE JUST BECAUSE THEY SHOW UP WITH A BUCKET

Pedro Sanchez, Spanish Prime Minister

THE AIM NOW IS TO NEGOTIATE A LASTING END TO THE WAR. WE ARE IN CLOSE COORDINATION WITH OUR PARTNERS ON THIS MATTER

Friedrich Merz, German Chancellor

Oil, gas flows from Gulf may take months to recover

REBECCA F ELLIOTT & IVAN PENN
8 April

Reopening the Strait of Hormuz — a central aim for the United States when it agreed to a cease-fire with Iran — would be the first step toward getting more energy flowing through the Persian Gulf.

But only the first step. That is because dozens of refineries, storage facilities, and oil and gas fields in at least nine countries, from Iran to the United Arab Emirates and beyond, have been targeted in strikes. All told, 10 per cent or more of the world's oil supply has been turned off. Restarting those operations will require not only safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz, but also inspecting pumps, replacing bespoke processing equipment and recalling employees and ships that have scattered across the globe.

"It's not a case of you just flick a switch and everything's back up again," said Martin Houston, a longtime oil and gas executive who now serves as board member for several energy companies.

A view of a security post overlooking the Zubair oil field in Iraq, amid the recent disruption to shipping in the Strait of Hormuz FILE: REUTERS

The timeline for bringing the Gulf energy system back to some semblance of normal is highly uncertain.

For one thing, the war has been paused for only two weeks.

In the cease-fire deal, Iran agreed to allow ships to pass through the strait without being attacked.

Attacks on energy facilities continued in the days leading up to the cease-fire, including on an oil refinery in Kuwait and petrochemical complexes in Iran. How much damage has already been done to the region's infrastructure is difficult to know because many countries have shared little information.

Once companies regain confidence that their ships can transit the narrow waterway that runs between Iran and the Arabian Peninsula, the first order of business is likely to be shipping out the oil and other fuels that countries close to the strait stockpiled in storage tanks. Then, as long as hostilities do not resume, some wells are likely to flow again within days or weeks, industry analysts and Gulf oil executives say.

But a fuller recovery will be a monthslong process, they cautioned. And even then, some infrastructure that has sustained extensive damage is expected to take years to repair.

For consumers, this means that gasoline prices at the pump — which recently topped $4 a gallon, on average, in the United States — are unlikely to return to their prewar levels any time soon. Countries are using up stores of energy they had before the war, so the longer the war drags on, the stickier those high prices are likely to be.

The shuttering of oil wells has other consequences. Once idled, oil and gas wells can be difficult to restart, and the longer they remain closed, the more trouble companies may have turning them back on.

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IN BRIEF

Nepal court issues arrest warrants against former PM Deuba, wife

A Nepalese court has issued arrest warrants against former prime minister Sher Bahadur Deuba and his wife Arzu Rana Deuba, the former foreign minister, in money laundering cases, media reports said on Wednesday. The Kathmandu District Court issued warrants against the couple on Tuesday following a request by the Department of Money Laundering, which is investigating the couple's assets, according to The Kathmandu Post newspaper. The department started investigating the assets of the couple after burnt pieces of banknotes were recovered from their residence at Budhanilkantha on the outskirts of Kathmandu in September. PTI

Bangladesh Parliament endorses ban on ex-PM Hasina's Awami League

Bangladesh's Parliament on Wednesday passed a law endorsing the previous Muhammad Yunus-led interim government's order to disband deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina's Awami League party. "This bill (law) concerns the banning of a genocidal, terrorist organisation. This is an amendment to the previous Anti-Terrorism Act," Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed told the Parliament, without naming the Awami League. Ahmed said the new law would continue the suspension of the Awami League's registration with the election commission and ensure the party's trial for its alleged involvement in "genocide". PTI

Hong Kong Mortgage Corp weighs world's biggest digital bond sale

Hong Kong Mortgage Corp. is considering raising up to HK$12 billion (US$1.5 billion) through its first digital bond sale, according to people familiar with the matter, in what may turn out to be the biggest-ever such offering globally. The potential sale from the Hong Kong government-owned financial services provider comes as the city is looking to cement its role as a digital asset hub. Hong Kong Mortgage Corp, which has total assets of about HK$221.8 billion, is considering marketing the multi-tranche bonds denominated in Hong Kong dollars and offshore yuan as early as next month, said the people, who asked not to be identified. BLOOMBERG

Oscars set dates for 99th and 100th broadcast, before move to YouTube

The organisation that puts on the Oscars has set dates for its final two shows on ABC, including the 100th Academy Awards. The Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences and ABC said Tuesday that the 99th Oscars will be held on March 14, 2027, and the 100th on March 5, 2028. They will be the last ceremonies broadcast on its longtime network home before the show moves to YouTube in 2029, and the last two held at the Dolby Theatre in Hollywood. The film academy just recently announced that the show would also have a new physical location at the Peacock Theater in downtown Los Angeles as part of a 10-year agreement with AEG. AP/PTI

Greece to ban social media for kids under 15 from next year

Greece will ban access to social media for children under the age of 15 from January 1, 2027, Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis said on Wednesday, citing rising anxiety, sleep problems and the addictive design of online platforms. An opinion poll by ALCO published in February showed about 80 per cent of those surveyed approved of a ban. The Greek government has already outlawed mobile phones in schools and set up parental control platforms to limit teenagers' screen time. "Greece will be among the first countries to take such an initiative," Mitsotakis said in a video message, adding that he had spoken with parents before making the decision. REUTERS

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Wait and watch

Developments in West Asia will be critical for monetary policy

The six-member Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), in its first meeting this financial year, took a judicious call on Wednesday to keep the policy repo rate unchanged. Given the uncertainty stemming from the crisis in West Asia — though its intensity has declined considerably since the United States (US) and Iran have agreed to a ceasefire at a crucial juncture — it made sense for the MPC to wait for more clarity before adjusting the monetary policy. It is also worth noting that while there are concerns that higher commodity prices, particularly those of crude oil and gas, could push up the inflation rate over the coming months, the retail inflation rate before the war started was relatively low and provided considerable policy comfort. The consumer price index-based inflation rate for January and February was 2.7 per cent and 3.2 per cent, respectively.

It will now be worth watching whether the two-week ceasefire between the US and Israel, on the one hand, and Iran, on the other, holds and whether that will be enough to find a durable solution to the crisis. If the two sides fail to find a solution and the war resumes, the threshold for any further dialogue will rise substantially. To what extent movements in the Strait of Hormuz are restored, and on what conditions, need to be carefully monitored. It is believed that oil and gas facilities damaged during the war will take some time to start functioning again. Nevertheless, the ceasefire has helped bring down oil prices and pushed up those of stocks and bonds. It should also help provide much-needed stability in the currency market. The direction in financial markets will be determined by how diplomatic efforts progress over the coming days.

In terms of the assessment of the economy in this uncertain environment, the RBI projected a growth rate of 6.9 per cent in real gross domestic product for 2026-27. The second advanced estimates by the National Statistics Office had estimated real growth at 7.6 per cent for 2025-26. Thus, growth this financial year is expected to be comparatively slow, partly owing to external uncertainties. A private-sector forecaster has projected that the monsoon this year will be below normal, which could also affect outcomes on growth and inflation. On inflation, the RBI expects the rate to average 4.6 per cent in 2026-27, with the highest quarterly rate of 5.2 per cent during October-December. These forecasts can change significantly, depending on developments in West Asia. As the Monetary Policy Report showed, the RBI's baseline assumption for prices of crude oil is an average of $85 per barrel for the financial year. Resumption in hostilities can push it up.

Assuming these inflation-growth forecasts hold, it is reasonable to argue that the policy interest rate will remain at the current level throughout the year. Interestingly, the RBI has also started giving a projection for the core inflation rate, which is expected to average 4.4 per cent during the year. The inclusion of this additional information must be welcomed. It will help reduce information asymmetry. Besides, although the RBI's target is the headline inflation rate, using the core rate in communication could be useful in managing expectations, particularly during supply-driven shocks, which tend to make the headline rate more volatile. Along

Beyond the illusion of normalcy

India's limited fiscal buffer increases macroeconomic risks from the West Asia crisis

ILLUSTRATION: BINAY SINHA

The devastating consequences of the United States' misadventure in Iran are not yet fully apparent in the Indian economy. The adverse effects of rising energy prices and supply disruptions on economic growth, inflation, employment, exchange rate depreciation, and the balance of payments are still unfolding. The full impact has not entirely been felt, as the government has cushioned the effects due to elections in Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and the Union Territory of Puducherry.

However, the absorptive capacity of the government is limited, and its resilience is fast running out, despite running down its foreign exchange reserves by $10.3 billion in one week through March 27, thereby bringing the reserves down to $688 billion. In fact, the rupee's depreciation by 9.9 per cent in FY26 is the worst performance among Asian currencies.

Continued hostility in West Asia will unveil the façade of normalcy, and with limited fiscal headroom available, sus-

points, from 3.3 per cent to 2.7 per cent. The growth rate of the Indian economy is estimated to decline by 0.8 to 1 percentage points, while inflation will rise by 0.8 to 1 percentage points.

While this may approximate the impact of prices, issues relating to availability remain, and the consequences may be even more severe. After energy prices are reset and input cost escalation is taken into account, inflationary conditions are likely to reappear in the economy. The human suffering cannot be captured merely by these growth and inflation numbers.

The West Asia conflict has led to India's manufacturing PMI dropping to a near four-year low of 53.9, from 57.9 in the previous month. The reduction in the excise duty on petrol and diesel is likely to add to the fiscal woes of the government, which is already stressed. Even when prices ease, the scarcity of oil and gas will continue to haunt households and businesses.

The lack of fiscal buffer in the country increases the macroeconomic instability risks. Due to the base revision of gross domestic product (GDP), the revised estimate of fiscal deficit for 2025-26 is pegged higher at 4.8 per cent of GDP, against the 4.4 per cent. The budgeted deficit for 2026-27 is estimated at 4.8 per cent after the base revision, compared to 4.3 per cent.

The target of reducing the debt-to-GDP ratio to 50 (±1 per cent) of GDP by 2030 is also in danger of being breached. What is of concern is that, despite the passage of fiscal responsibility legislation at the Union and state levels, in none of the years except 2007-08 was the target of containing the fiscal deficit at 6 per cent of GDP achieved.

Furthermore, except in the Covid year, when household sector financial savings touched 11.1 per cent, in none of the years did it come close to the 10 per cent of GDP assumed by the 12th Finance Commission while setting the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management targets. While claims are made about fiscal consolidation since the Covid year, the aggregate fiscal deficit in 2023-24 was 8.8 per cent of GDP, even as the household sector's net financial savings were just about 5.2 per cent of GDP.

This has escalated the cost of borrowing for industry. In fact, since 2021-22, the aggregate fiscal deficit has been much higher than the household sector's financial saving, creating a stagnant investment climate due to elevated cost of borrowing. Almost 90 per cent of the financial institutions are owned by the government and this helps in government borrowing. The periodic infusion of liquidity only helps to keep the cost of government borrowing low. Who cares if the Reserve Bank of India has a conflict of interest in managing multiple, often conflicting, roles?

In an environment of constrained fiscal space, a sharp increase in energy prices can trigger a crisis. It was when Saddam Hussein invaded Kuwait in 1990 that oil prices doubled, and the accumulated fiscal imbalances escalated into a crisis of unprecedented magnitude. Thanks to market-based reforms since that crisis, the economy has gained resilience, and we are in a much better position to face such a shock than in 1991.

But the problems cannot be wished away. The elevated levels of deficits and excessive government borrowing, aided by financial repression will constrain with the MPC's decision, the RBI also announced measures to improve the ease of doing business, and one of them is worth highlighting here. It recently consolidated over 9,000 regulatory instructions into 238 master directions. A similar exercise is being carried out for supervisory instructions. Taken together, these should help improve clarity among regulated entities and reduce friction.

Administrative control

FCRA imposes excessive restrictions

Proposed amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), introduced during the recently concluded Budget session of Parliament, risk underlining India's reputation for administrative overreach. Among the key changes proposed in the Bill, the passage of which was deferred following an uproar by the Opposition, is the creation of a "designated authority" to take over, manage, or dispose of assets created from foreign funds if a non-government organisation's (NGO's) FCRA licence is suspended or cancelled, or not renewed.

This Bill marks another step in the progressively strict regime that the Centre has imposed on the functioning of civil society since 2010, when the FCRA Act was enacted to regulate foreign contributions received by individuals, associations, and NGOs. The impact can be seen in the government's dashboard, which shows that 14,958 FCRA associations are active, 21,979 had their licences cancelled, and another 15,187 licences are deemed to have expired. Amendments in 2016, 2018, and 2020 successively tightened the terms on which NGOs were permitted to function. These included opening an account with the State Bank of India's Parliament Street branch, stipulating the amount of funds earmarked for administrative costs, restricting subgrants to smaller NGOs, and meeting minimum expenditure thresholds.

According to the Bill's "Statement of Objects and Reasons", the amendment has been introduced to ensure that such foreign funds are not used for causes that "adversely affect national interest". Since the amplitude of "national interest" can be wide, this phrase considerably expands the scope for a government to cancel the FCRA permit for NGOs involved in activities it deems inconvenient. The "Statement" also explains that the amendment was introduced to address operational gaps. Indeed, the amendment in 2020 had the provision for vesting with an authority the assets of NGOs whose FCRA permit has been cancelled. The latest amendment lays down the procedure under which this can be done. Remarkably, the proceeds from the assets sold or transferred are to be directed to the Consolidated Fund of India. Additional elements of arbitrariness include permitting an authority designated by the government to act as a custodian of the assets, even undertaking the activities of the NGO or individual concerned "if considered necessary or expedient to do so". If the activity of the institution concerned is considered necessary, why deny to it the foreign funds needed to keep it operational? The Bill also provides for the assets to be restored if an FCRA certificate is renewed or restored, or a fresh one granted, but subject to certain conditions.

It is nobody's case that all recipients of foreign contributions are above board and do not require monitoring. But in seeking to stall the transgressors, the Centre has complicated the functioning of legitimate foreign-funded NGOs that have contributed to poverty alleviation, nutrition, education, health, or gender rights. In a country as vast as India, the government has struggled to deliver these basic necessities uniformly. In fact, tacit recognition of the need for civil-society support can be seen in the introduction of the mandate for corporate social responsibility. Further, the sprawling domestic NGO sector is not subject to a similar regime, though there is no evidence to suggest they are any different in nature. Such asymmetric treatment does not enhance India's standing as an impartial jurisdiction.

POLICY PILLARS

M GOVINDA RAO

taining such operations will be difficult. Hopefully, the two-week ceasefire will bring the curtains down. On the other hand, if the hostilities prolong, the price of crude oil will keep rising, and, combined with supply disruptions, India may face a severe energy shortfall, adversely impacting every sector of the economy. With options running out, the government may increase energy prices to reflect market realities once the elections are over. It may not take much time for the "Goldilocks" economy to be caught in a "stagflationary" spiral.

While a ceasefire has been declared, it is not clear if hostilities will end or the extent of the damage they will cause to the Indian economy. One estimate suggests that an increase of $20 per barrel will reduce global economic growth by 0.2 to 0.4 percentage

The impact goes beyond the transportation sector. Many small and medium industries are faced with the spectre of closure. The effects will also be felt in agriculture due to the non-availability and higher prices of fertilisers, which may require the government to increase subsidies. Energy-intensive small and medium enterprises are likely to bear the brunt, particularly in sectors such as transportation, metallurgy, chemicals, and cement. As it is not possible to transition to renewables in the short run, hardships and black marketing in scarce items may intensify. The longer the hostilities drag on, the more pronounced the adverse effects will be on growth, employment, exchange rate depreciation, the current account deficit, and overall human suffering.

corporate investments by enhancing their cost of borrowing. The situation is far from normal than it looks at present and, the longer we delay the fiscal adjustment, the more intense the problem will become. In the immediate context, it is important to raise the prices of petroleum products to reflect the market reality.

The government will have to think carefully about whether it needs to continue with Rozgar Melas or schemes such as providing free foodgrains to 813 million people under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana, especially when multidimensional poverty has declined to 11.28 per cent of the population. One hopes the government will not miss the opportunity offered by this crisis to undertake much-needed reforms.

The author is former director, NIPFP.
The views are personal

Windows of opportunity

The Indian government's record on managing crises has been erratic. On the one hand, years of experience with certain emergencies have taught the administrative apparatus the art of deploying proactive management tools. As a result, India no longer suffers as acutely when a drought strikes (as it threatens to do this year). Pre-emptive precautions ensure that large numbers of Indians do not die when cyclones hit the coasts, and energetic realignment of coal transport to thermal power plants has helped us muddle through the demand spikes for the past three scorching summers.

True, responses to these crises are not perfect but each year bureaucracies build on their learnings. The pity is that the political apparatus is rarely able to reorient crisis responses in meaningful and lasting ways. While governments have demonstrated agility in dealing with an immediate crisis, they rarely spot opportunities for lasting reform. The last time that happened, the country was set on the path of economic liberalisation.

SWOT

KANIKA DATTA

Covid was the first test case since then. Admittedly no country in the world was prepared for the pandemic, and each initially struggled for a coherent response. In India, there has been justifiable satisfaction at the speed with which the vaccine was rolled out, and the government's proactive fiscal responses that somewhat cauterised the impact for the poor. Fading in public memory is the virulent Delta phase of the virus when death rates soared, as citizens simply died for lack of access to a hospital bed, oxygen, ventilators and basic nursing. The virus fully exposed India's sub-Saharan standards of health care and successive governments' abdication of responsibility towards this critical component of human development over the years. In that nightmare period, officialdom vanished from public view — except when it came to fiercely contesting high death statistics against all the evidence (the fact that Donald Trump's America and Jair Bolsonaro's Brazil did worse on this score must offer little comfort).

The obvious long-term lesson from this is that the Centre and states urgently need to reverse the decades-old ennui over health care spending so that the country is better prepared for the next health crisis. Yet the needle on this has scarcely moved. In March 2022, a parliamentary reply said India had 0.6 beds per 1,000 population in 2021. That figure has improved to 1.3 beds per 1,000 population. That's still below the National Health policy's 2017 guideline of two beds and the global average of 2.7 beds.

Worryingly, much of the growth has come from a healthy expansion of private hospital beds with a growing number of petty entrepreneurs spotting a profitable opportunity in a chronic shortage. This trend is troubling mainly because private hospitals tend to be urban-oriented, whereas rural India is catastrophically short of even primary health care. They are exclusionary in their patient intake. The poor or destitute are routinely turned away from their luxurious granite exteriors. Despite a substantial 10 per cent jump in health care allocations over the last year, health care is scarcely an expenditure priority. It accounts for less than 2 per cent of government expenditure and less than 1 per cent of GDP.

The West Asian war offers another opportunity to shift the dynamics of policymaking and economic spending priorities. When the Straits closed, Kartavya Bhavan moved swiftly to shield the consumer from cooking gas shortages by restricting industrial and commercial usage, rationing supplies and reducing taxes to hold the line on pump prices. Those are astute moves ahead of Assembly elections but they ignore the longer term impact of joblessness as eateries and small businesses shut shop for lack of fuel. In short, Indians are now facing the consequences of failing to build strategic natural gas storage facilities even as the government sought to expand demand through Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana subsidies and the expansion of piped natural gas, both of which are mostly imported. The creation of strategic crude oil reserves is the other spending priority that this crisis demands. Some moves are being made to build buffers; whether they are sufficient is the open question.

As the Kharif season approaches, Indian farmers are staring at a fertiliser shortage owing to supply disruptions in the Straits of Hormuz. With domestic production falling and the cost of imported urea, the most heavily subsidised nutrient, rising, the government expects its already outsized fertiliser subsidy bill to burgeon. This would provide a good opportunity to reorient the subsidy from manufacturers to farmers. A long-standing prescription from the more thoughtful agricultural economists, a direct benefit transfer (DBT) to farmers for fertiliser costs has the potential to save the exchequer ₹75,000 crore annually, plug the leakages that inevitably accompany subsidy schemes, and save India's rapidly deteriorating soil health from excessive urea application.

As with expanding health care delivery, building strategic fossil fuel reserves, realigning an increasingly burdensome fertiliser subsidy or even fast-tracking electric vehicle (EV) usage, the government has a unique opportunity before it — and a popular mandate — to leverage this crisis for durable benefits. It should not close this window of opportunity.

The limits of weaponising global finance

BOOK REVIEW

SHYAM SARAN

Edward Fishman's voluminous 538-page book entitled *Chokepoints* has coincidentally reached our bookshops just as Iran is effectively leveraging its domination of one such chokepoint, the Strait of Hormuz, in its unequal military contestation with the United States and Israel. The Hormuz Strait conforms to the definition of a chokepoint as "a vital crossroads, a place where civilizations trade and jostle for power, where empires rise and fall." In ancient history, the Bosphorus, the narrow sea passage connecting the Black Sea littoral with the Aegean Sea, was policed by the powerful Athenian naval fleet. It allowed Athens to obtain grain and other commodities from Ukraine and the Balkans. Its rival, Sparta, won the Peloponnesian War in the 5th century BC by defeating the Athenian fleet and closing the Bosphorus to its ships, thereby starving it into submission.

Mr Fishman, a former senior sanctions officer in the US administration, tells the story of the economic and technological chokepoints of the post-Cold War era of rapid globalisation. Mastery over these has enabled the exercise of power without recourse to the messy use of violent and kinetic instruments. But Iran is currently a compelling exception. Geography matters and old-style clash of arms may still be necessary to force an adversary into submission.

Economic warfare is the "economic means by which damage is imposed on other countries or the threat of damage used to bring pressure on them." Bombing a bank is an act of conventional war but sanctioning an adversary's bank by preventing its access to the international financial market is an act of economic war. Mr Fishman draws attention to the meteoric rise of foreign exchange markets. In 1950, foreign exchange trading was minimal but today the volume is $7 trillion a day and is 80 times the value of daily global trade flows. Ninety per cent of these foreign exchange transactions involve the US dollar. This gives the US control over a financial chokepoint of unparalleled strategic value.

The weaponisation of global finance was systematised, and a specialised bureaucracy was put in place to implement it. This became more elaborate after the 9/11 terrorist attack against the Twin Towers in New York in 2001, which uncovered a complex financial trail enabling the operation. This also led to secondary sanctions to prevent any deflection or bypassing of sanctions by foreign banks and financial institutions. The SWIFT inter-bank messaging system, based in Brussels, was also corralled into the sanctions regime. It would have to deny any participant bank access to its system at the command of the US Treasury. The dominance of the dollar enables American extra-territorial jurisdiction. Ours is an era of finance weaponised through a mere ledger entry rather than through the threatened lethality of a loaded gun. This progression is covered in detail in the book.

While economic warfare is a potent instrument for influencing the behaviour of other countries, friend and foe alike, it has its limits. Neither Iran nor Russia has been deterred from pursuing policies considered inimical by the US. The US itself has a threshold beyond which it cannot escalate further, as doing so would hurt its own interests in an interdependent global economy. US interest in keeping oil prices low limits the severity of sanctions it is ready to impose on key oil producers like Russia.

Interdependence, particularly China's full integration into the global economy, imposed limits that led to the next phase of economic warfare: Its technological dimension. The author says the intent is not merely to change behaviour but to "downsize China's role in the world economy, inflicting economic damage on China as an end in itself." Technology denial is powerful because technology has become the chief driver of economic growth. The focus of this contestation has been high-end semiconductors and artificial intelligence. But the US does not dominate this domain to the same extent that it dominates currency and financial markets.

Chokepoints: American Power in the Age of Economic Warfare
by Edward Fishman
Published by Penguin
538 pages ₹2,469

The book refers to India in the context of US pressures to persuade countries to reduce and eventually stop buying Iranian oil and later Russian oil in the aftermath of the Ukraine War. The author claims that India did trim its oil purchases in deference to the US but that "it would never publicly admit that it was complying with US sanctions". It would portray its decisions as dictated by its energy security choices alone. It is Donald Trump's insistence that India make a public display of its acquiescence to US demands that poses a challenge.

The author points to the fragmentation of the global economy in response to the acute vulnerabilities exposed by the weaponisation of interdependence. There is a trade-off between economic interdependence and economic security in an age of heightened geopolitical competition. Economic warfare and its technological dimension have also not diminished the possibilities of bloody and destructive kinetic warfare as we are witnessing in the ongoing Iran war.

Chokepoints is a valuable insider view of the evolution of economic warfare, though it is debatable whether this renders recourse to kinetic war less likely, as the author implies.

The reviewer is a former foreign secretary

Business Standard MUMBAI | THURSDAY, 9 APRIL 2026

The Smart Investor

STREETVIEW

"WE NOW HAVE TWO WEEKS OF RESPITE. IT REMAINS TO BE SEEN WHETHER THE CRISIS IS REALLY OVER, BUT ITS IMPACT ON OIL PRICES WILL REMAIN. WHATEVER HAPPENS WE'RE HEADING TOWARDS SLOWER GLOBAL GROWTH AND HIGHER INFLATION THIS YEAR

Vincent Juvyns, Chief Investment Strategist, ING

Brent above $100 could slice corporate margins by half

BS 1000 companies brace for potential earnings collapse if crude keeps climbing

KRISHNA KANT
Mumbai, 8 April

A sharp rise in crude oil prices due to the US-Iran conflict is likely to halve corporate margins and reduce overall profits in the coming quarters. Historically, corporate operating profit margins have shown a strong negative correlation with international crude prices

ILLUSTRATION: BINAY SINHA

Crude oil, India Inc Margins & Markets

Markets believe worst phase of West Asia war is over: Samir Arora

Q&A Markets reacted to the developments in West Asia and the outcome of the monetary policy meeting of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday. **Samir Arora,** founder and chief investment officer of Helios Capital, tells **Puneet Wadhwa** in a telephonic conversation that there may be some impact of the West Asia war on select sectors and companies. However, it's not as bad as was feared earlier. Edited excerpts:

How are markets interpreting the ceasefire in West Asia — is this a stop-start phase, or is the worst over?

■ I don't think it is a stop-start situation. We and markets believe that the worst phase of West Asia war is over. By February-end, the tional crude prices.

This relationship has been particularly pronounced in recent years. Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation, and amortisation (Ebitda) margins — also called operating margins — of *BS 1000* companies have steadily risen over the past four years, coinciding with a decline in crude oil prices.

The *BS 1000* is an annual ranking of India's largest listed companies, excluding banking, financial, and insurance, based on revenue.

For instance, operating margins of BS1000 companies improved from 15.1 per cent of revenues in 2022-23 (FY23) to a record 19 per cent during April–December 2025 (nine months of 2025-26/9MFY26). Over the same period, Brent crude prices were up 32 per cent, averaging $95.3 per barrel in FY23 and $64.8 in 9MFY26. In contrast, when crude prices more than doubled between 2020-21 (FY21) and FY23, corporate margins fell roughly 390 basis points (bps), from 19.01 per cent in FY21 to 15.13 per cent in FY23.

Both crude prices and corporate margins contracted in 2019-20 as the Covid-19 pandemic sharply curtailed global economic activity, hitting corporate earnings and energy demand.

Outside these exceptions, Indian corporate margins typically react negatively to rising crude prices — and vice versa. BS1000 companies, for example, saw margin pressure between 2009-10 (FY10) and 2012-13 (FY13) when crude averaged $114.8 in 2011-12 (FY12), up from $70.6 in FY10. Margins then recovered from FY13 to 2016-17 as crude prices fell to $47.8 in 2015-16 from their FY12 peak.

Brent crude has risen 43 per cent since the end of February 2026 and 34 per cent over the 12 months ending March 2026 (FY26). In contrast, crude averaged $64.8 in 9MFY26, down 17 per cent from $78 in 9M of 2024-25 (FY25). Lower energy prices in 9MFY26 supported corporate margins, with non-financial companies' Ebitda margins rising nearly 100 bps to 19 per cent from around 18 per cent in FY25. One bp equals one-hundredth of a per cent.

"A 40 per cent rise in crude to an average of $100 per barrel could push raw material costs up by roughly 20 per cent, outpacing potential sales growth of 12 per cent and compressing operating margins by up to 36 per cent. For non-financial corporates, core operating margins (excluding other income) could fall from around 15 per cent to 8 per cent, risking outright earnings contraction," says Dhananjay Sinha, co-head of research and institutional equities, Systematix Group.

If this scenario unfolds, overall profits in the non-financial sector could be halved. For comparison, listed companies (excluding banking, financial, and insurance) reported core operating margins of 16 per cent during 9MFY26 and 15.6 per cent in the third quarter (October–December/Q3) of FY26. Over the past 20 quarters, these margins have ranged from 12.4 per cent to 17.6 per cent, averaging 15.6 per cent.

According to Sinha, the 2026 US/Israel-Iran conflict has triggered one of the most severe oil supply disruptions in six decades. Even a sustained 5–10 per cent shortfall in energy supply could create a debilitating economic shock.

Others see a limited downside if hostilities in West Asia end soon and oil supply stabilises. "We see limited earnings downgrades for 2026-27E and 2027-28E if the US/Israel-Iran conflict ends within the next two to three weeks and oil and gas supply conditions improve over the coming months," write analysts Sanjeev Prasad, Anindya Bhowmik, and Sunita Baldawa of Kotak Institutional Equities.

Historically, changes in crude prices have positively correlated with the Nifty 50 index, which has usually risen alongside oil. Higher oil prices often signalled stronger global economic activity and benign financial conditions. This time, however, Nifty 50 has fallen despite a crude rally: the index was down 5.1 per cent in FY26, even as Brent crude gained 34 per cent, indicating that the current situation differs from past oil price shocks.

Note: Crude oil price is average for the financial year; *Average for Apr-Dec 2025; PBIDT: Profit before interest, depreciation, and taxes
Sources: Bloomberg, Capitaline, BS 1000; Compiled by BS Research Bureau

West Asia war broke out. By February end, the markets were in a 'good mood' and held up despite sharp corrections like in the information technology (IT) sector. So, the March correction was clearly due to the war and with prospects of that coming to a conclusion, there is a natural rally.

Even the recent quarterly business updates by companies suggest consumer sentiment is strong.

For the most recent quarter (which includes March), we have seen strong business updates from consumer companies, good numbers from auto companies and decent recovery in credit demand for banks.

There would have been some damage to macro in terms of higher oil and commodity prices, lower travel/tourism and may be lower remittances but hopefully this is largely contained. Markets had discounted the bad news with select pockets seeing a dip of over 15 per cent, which have recovered partially now.

Yes, there may be some impact of the West Asia war, but it's not as bad as was feared earlier. Some sectors may continue to face pressure, but overall, markets are not behaving as if the worst is still ahead.

What returns should investors expect from here on?

■ As of now, we are not getting carried away in our expectations only because the fall has been sharp in March and year-to-date. Let us think of around 15 per cent returns over the next 12 months after the 7-8 per cent gains already made this April.

That's a more realistic approach and target right now. Additionally, some macro factors like currency stability have also improved, which supports this moderate optimism.

But will the real impact show up with a lag in companies' financial performance, especially the rise seen in crude oil prices? Are markets factoring this in?

■ Yes, if there is any slowdown, inflation, or damage, it may show up after one-two months — but not across all sectors. Also, if the impact is for a short period, markets tend to justify and absorb the impact. Economy, oil prices and inflation, among others, will not exactly go back to February-end levels in a short period. But markets have a habit of looking into the future and small adverse changes may have been already reflected in the prices due to steep fall in March.

"MARKETS HAVE A HABIT OF LOOKING INTO THE FUTURE AND SMALL ADVERSE CHANGES MAY HAVE BEEN ALREADY REFLECTED IN THE PRICES DUE TO STEEP FALL IN MARCH"

Will tariffs and trade deals drive markets from here on?

■ Yes, tariffs matter, but in a positive way. First, tariffs matter if a country is isolated and suffers because of specific targeting, which makes it uncompetitive versus others. If all countries face the same tariff (10 per cent currently), it is more a cost issue for US customers rather than a negative for us. As far as India is concerned, the tariffs have fallen from 50 per cent to 10 per cent. It is not even clear how US will extend these tariffs beyond the 150-day limit.

Also, even if US President Donald Trump increases the tariff for different countries using different trade laws, our effective weighted tariff is expected to be at 18 per cent (according to the trade deal). So, it will still be much better than the 50 per cent tariff we were paying till recently.

How US will reinstate tariffs for different countries to the pre-Supreme Court decision remains to be seen but there is no reason to believe that India will again be targeted separately on this.

After the rout, a breather for mkts

The latest rebound offers a measure of relief after a turbulent spell for global financial markets since the onset of the conflict.

In the weeks following the escalation, Indian equities entered a sharp risk-off phase, with benchmark indices correcting as much as 11 per cent amid a 45 per cent surge in crude oil prices, rupee weakness, and persistent foreign investor outflows.

The spike in oil prices — driven by fears of disruption in the Strait of Hormuz — emerged as the key overhang, stoking concerns around imported inflation, tighter financial conditions, and a potential hit to corporate earnings.

The rupee weakened from around ₹91 before the conflict to breach ₹95 intraday at its weakest. The India VIX more than doubled during this period, reflecting heightened investor anxiety.

Other asset classes offered limited refuge. Rising bond yields eroded fixed-income appeal, while declines in gold and silver prices reduced traditional safe-haven support.

Foreign portfolio investors remained consistent sellers, offloading nearly ₹1.6 trillion in what was among their most brutal month-long sell-offs. Domestic institutional investors, however, provided a crucial counterbalance, absorbing much of the selling and preventing a sharper market decline.

Sectorally, the pain was broad-based, with rate-sensitive segments such as financials, autos, and real estate bearing the brunt. Broader markets also saw meaningful declines, underscoring risk aversion among retail and high-beta investors.

Against this backdrop, Wednesday's sharp rally marks a sentiment-driven turnaround, aided by easing oil prices and hopes of de-escalation. However, with geopolitical risks still lingering and energy markets yet to fully stabilise, market participants remain cautious about the durability of the recovery.

SUNDAR SETHURAMAN

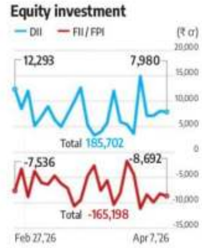
40 days of West Asia war

World indices

US*	40-day chg %
Dow Jones	-2.45
S&P 500	-1.54
Europe#	
Euro Stoxx 50	-4.7
FTSE 100	-2.6
Asia	
Nikkei 225	-5.8
Kospi	-8.4
Hang Seng	-2.9
Shanghai SE Composite	-3.6
Stock Exch of Thailand	-5.6

*As at 22:00 IST; #As at 16:33 IST on April 8

Equity investment



NSE sectoral indices

	Feb 27,'26	Apr 8,'26	Chg %
Nifty IT	30,603.9	31,565.8	3.1
Nifty Metal	12,240.7	12,079.0	-1.3
Nifty Energy	37,045.2	36,469.2	-1.6
Nifty Financial Services	31,390.7	30,127.9	-4.0
Nifty India Tourism	7,795.0	7,265.6	-6.8
Nifty Auto	28,158.9	26,003.0	-7.7
Nifty Bank	60,529.0	55,703.9	-8.0
Nifty PSU Bank	9,820.5	8,716.1	-11.2

Nifty 50

Gainers	Share price (₹)		
Tech Mahindra	1,357.8	1,451.4	6.9
HCLTech	1,389.1	1,461.0	5.2
Coal India	430.7	449.3	4.3
Losers			
HDFC Life Insurance Co	715.3	598.3	-16.4
Max Healthcare Institute	1,092.0	941.2	-13.8
Tata Motors PV	382.7	334.8	-12.5

Major Asian currencies against US$	(Chg %)*
Philippines peso	-2.97
Thai baht	-2.87
South Korean won	-2.63
Malaysian ringgit	-2.07
Indian rupee	-1.73
Japanese yen	-1.51
Taiwan dollar	-1.41
Indonesian rupiah	-1.32
Vietnam dong	-1.04
Singapore dollar	-0.75
Bangladesh taka	-0.62
Hong Kong dollar	-0.12
China renminbi	0.48

Source: Bloomberg, Exchanges; Compiled by BS Research Bureau

*40-day change

Sebi tweaks lock-in rules for pledged shares

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) on Wednesday introduced a mechanism to strengthen compliance with lock-in requirements for pledged shares. Under the revised framework, securities that cannot be locked in through existing systems will be marked as "non-transferable" by depositories for the duration of the stipulated lock-in period. Experts said the move will plug a key regulatory gap by ensuring that promoters and pre-IPO shareholders cannot circumvent lock-in norms through pledging arrangements.

BS REPORTER

Bonus proposal sends LIC stock soaring

Shares of Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) surged nearly 7 per cent on Wednesday, a day after the state-owned insurance major said it will consider a bonus issue. The company's board is scheduled to meet on April 13 to deliberate on the proposal. The stock ended at ₹794, up 6.8 per cent, taking LIC's market capitalisation to ₹5.02 trillion. While a bonus issue does not alter the company's fundamentals, it improves affordability for retail investors and typically enhances liquidity in the counter.

BS REPORTER

IFSCA cancels broker-dealer licence in first such action

In a first such enforcement action, the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) has cancelled the registration of broker-dealer String AI IFSC (formerly King Blockchain) for alleged regulatory violations. In an order dated April 6, the GIFT City regulator cited multiple lapses, including inadequate infrastructure, engagement in activities beyond permitted securities and commodity derivatives business, and failure to furnish required documents and clarifications despite repeated follow-ups. The violations were detected during surprise inspections carried out in 2024. Following earlier warnings, IFSCA issued a showcause notice to the entity in December 2025.

BS REPORTER

THE COMPASS

Gains for Coal India hinge on higher e-auction volumes, demand

DEVANGSHU DATTA

In its update for the fourth quarter of financial year 2025-26 (Q4FY26), Coal India Ltd (CIL) reported low FY26 volumes, with production at 768 million tonnes (mt), down 1.6 per cent year-on-year (Y-o-Y). Offtake was at 744 mt, down 2 per cent Y-o-Y, despite month-on-month (M-o-M) pickup in March. The Q4 contributed 31.1 per cent to annual output, less than the average of 32.3 per cent, and full-year production was 7.2 per cent below target.

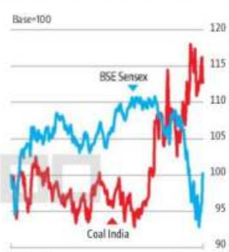
CIL's production is seasonal but thermal power demand was low through FY26 due to extended monsoons, rising share of renewable energy (RE) contributions, and also increased contributions from captive miners. The company reported production of 84.5 mt in March, up 13.1 per cent M-o-M but down 1.5 per cent Y-o-Y. Subsidiaries Mahanadi Coalfields Ltd (MCL) and Western Coalfields Ltd (WCL) both disappointed, leading to production declines. Offtake was 69.5 mt for March, up 12.1 per cent M-o-M and up 0.7 per cent Y-o-Y, and it was 744 mt for FY26, down 2 per cent Y-o-Y versus 759 mt in FY25. CIL has a 1 billion mt (bmt) volume target, and it will be looking to boost production from FY26 levels to 815 mt in FY27, and maintain 5 per cent production growth in future, assuming power demand grows at 6-7 per cent.

India's power demand was flat (up 0.5 per cent Y-o-Y) during April 2025-February 2026. Captive production rose 12 per cent Y-o-Y during the same period, with the share of captive coal in total volumes up 222 basis points (bps) to 20.9 per cent in the 11 months of FY26. RE contributed 26 per cent to total generation against 21 per cent for the same period in FY25.

For Q4FY26, CIL's adjusted operating profit may fall by 8-9 per cent Y-o-Y to ₹10,200 crore due to lower e-auction realisations and high coal inventories at plants. For FY26, adjusted operating profit growth may be in low single digits.

The market share trend is down from over 82 per cent in FY20 to around 73 per cent in the first 11 months of FY26 as captive and merchant miners raised their production to 194 mt (up 9 per cent Y-o-Y). Given captive production is still ramping up, more loss of share is likely.

Coal inventories at power plants are high. CIL's own inventory is at a record high of 143 mt. On the e-auction front, despite geopolitical tensions and Indonesia's production caps, upside was limited. While inventories are at current levels, e-auction gains could remain limited. This could change if the Iran war leads to sustained increase in global coal prices. The impending wage revision in FY27 could also put some pressure on earnings. A slowdown in renewables capacity additions, or a substitution of gas in certain industrial processes could push demand for coal. Of course, higher growth in power demand would also lead to growth in coal demand, since thermal remains the key base-load component of the energy mix.



The Central Electricity Authority projects peak demand at 363 gigawatts (Gw) by FY30, backed by over 40 Gw of additional thermal capacity. This implies a long-term trend of higher CIL offtake in absolute terms, even if market share erodes. Also, industrial metals and cement, which are energy-intensive sectors, are ramping up capacity, and this may drive demand. By 2030, domestic demand should be about 1.3 billion tonnes (bt), which leaves ample headroom for 1 billion production output from CIL.

The company is looking to boost e-auction volumes. In FY25, e-auction sales stood at 79 mt, about 10 per cent of dispatches and at a 68 per cent premium over FSA (fuel supply agreement). Management looks to increase e-auction offtake to 15-20 per cent of production by measures such as directly allowing buyers from Bangladesh, Bhutan, and Nepal. Subsidiaries have been asked to offer up to 40 per cent of production for e-auctions. CIL is also trying to increase coal-washer capacity to improve its share in domestic coking and non-coking coal. It is expanding its mining operations and may consider raising debt to undertake diversification into RE and coal gasification.

The FY26 underperformance may have been an outlier due to the weather. A mid-single digit rise in volumes may be the trend through the medium term. Higher realisations through e-auctions, and better cost controls are both imperatives. CIL's shares fell on Wednesday on hopes of easing geopolitical tensions. But the stock has risen over 15 per cent in the past three months on expectations of summer demand and support from high prices.

Gold rally puts wind in jewellers' sails

Same-store sales strength and higher spends lift Q4 showing

YOUR MONEY

ANNUITY PLANS

alli, head – product management & strategy, Bajaj Life Insurance.

A do-it-yourself alternative

Younger individuals with a high risk appetite may build a retirement portfolio independently using a mix of equity, debt, and gold funds. "As they approach retirement, they can shift the

should consider a joint life plan so that the payouts continue for the spouse's lifetime as well.

Decide whether your priority is to maximise monthly income for yourself or to pass on some wealth to your heirs. "Investors who seek to do legacy planning may prefer the RoPP option," says Burugupalli. Payouts are lower under this

RAM PRASAD SAHU
Mumbai, 8 April

Robust same-store sales growth (SSSG) helped listed jewellery majors record better than expected topline growth in the fourth quarter (January-March/Q4) of 2025-26 (FY26). Along with higher average ticket sizes, an improvement in buyer growth is signalling a demand recovery. While Kalyan Jewellers India rose 7.5 per cent to ₹445, market leader Titan Company gained about 6.2 per cent to ₹4,492 at close on Wednesday.

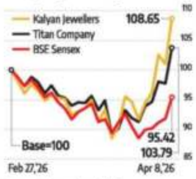
Growth for Titan was led by the jewellery segment, which reported domestic revenue growth of 46 per cent, excluding bullion sales. The outperformance was driven by Tanishq, Mia, Zoya, and beYon from House of Titan. Most brokerages had expected the company to deliver growth in the 40-42 per cent range. Secondary (retail) sales were up 52 per cent year-on-year (Y-o-Y), led by Tanishq and Mia.

The growth in jewellery sales was driven by a 48 per cent jump in like-for-like (LFL) sales, as gold prices surged 80 per cent over the year-ago period. In addition to higher average ticket sizes, growth was also supported by high single-digit buyer growth. Buyer growth in Q4FY26 follows a flat performance in the preceding three quarters of FY26.

Within sub-segments, studded jewellery grew in the early thirties, while plain gold saw growth in the mid-thirties. The company reported a near-trebling of coin sales Y-o-Y.

Among other segments, watch saw growth of 7 per cent Y-o-Y, driven by a 16 per cent increase in analogue watches. However, this was partly offset by a 53 per cent decline in the smartwatch category. Premiumisation trends, according to the company, contributed to healthy increases in ticket sizes during the quarter.

Staying strong



Sources: Bloomberg, BSE

Commenting on Titan's performance, Goldman Sachs Research said domestic jewellery consumer growth was strong at 52 per cent Y-o-Y, driven by sharp LFL acceleration. The improvement in buyer growth to high single digits indicates a recovery in demand, it added. The brokerage has maintained a "buy" rating with a target price of ₹5,000.

Higher gold prices may weigh on the company's gross margins in Q4. Analysts at Antique Stock Broking, led by Abhijeet Kundu, however, said healthy growth in studded jewellery in the early thirties, supported by robust buyer expansion, could partially offset the impact on margins. Incremental improvement in watch profitability could ease some of the margin pain, they added.

Antique estimates an operating profit margin expansion of 90 basis points (bps) for domestic jewellery over the next three years, reaching 10.6 per cent by 2027-28, driven by an improving product mix and operational efficiencies.

The brokerage has a "buy" rating with a target price of ₹5,143 per share. It expects Titan's medium- to long-term performance to be driven by market-share gains in the jewellery business, supported by brand strength, execution, and expansion of the store network.

Kalyan Jewellers also reported robust revenue growth of 64 per cent Y-o-Y on a consolidated basis, comfortably beating brokerage estimates. The domestic business reported growth of 65 per cent Y-o-Y, led by strong SSSG growth (45 per cent) across key markets. Despite volatile gold prices, both wedding and discretionary demand remained strong during the quarter. Given the strong performance in India, Motilal Oswal Research has maintained its "buy" rating with a target price of ₹550.

JM Financial Research, which also maintains a "buy" rating, expects profit before tax growth of 86 per cent on a standalone basis in Q4, compared to its earlier estimate of 52 per cent. The brokerage expects margins at the profit-before-tax level to expand by 60 bps Y-o-Y to 5.2 per cent.

Compare payouts from various options, understand trade-offs

HIMALI PATEL

Tata AIA Life Insurance has launched Shubh Flexi Pension Plan, an annuity plan, in association with Policybazaar. One part of the payout offers guaranteed income for life, protecting customers against longevity and reinvestment risks. The other part is linked to the Nifty 50, and will grow in line with India's equity markets. Customers can choose the balance between these two income streams.

Tackling inflation risk

Most annuity plans make a fixed payout for life, whose value erodes over time due to inflation. In this plan, a portion of the income gets locked in at the prevailing annuity rate for life. "This protects customers from falling rates and reinvestment risk. The variable payout component helps customers beat inflation," says Sameep Singh, head of investments, Policybazaar.

The variable component, however, is not guaranteed. "Equity market downturns can lead to lower payouts," says Abhishek Kumar, Sebi-registered investment adviser and founder, SahajMoney.com.

"Customers who expect to retire within the next five to 10 years can opt for this type of annuity plan because it provides income stability and inflation protection," says Gibin John, senior investment strategist, Geojit Investments.

Do not select a lower guaranteed income than you need to cover essential costs. "Plan conservatively. Avoid relying on optimistic return assumptions for the market-linked component," says Madhu Burugup-

required amount into risk-free annuity products or other stable return options," says John.

Singh points out that a generic (non-labelled) portfolio runs the risk of funds being diverted to meet other financial needs.

Multiple payout options available

Annuity plans offer a variety of payout options: Single life, joint life, with and without return of purchase price (RoPP), increasing annuity, and immediate and deferred annuity.

Those who want payouts to begin after a few years should choose a deferred annuity plan, while those who want payouts to start immediately should opt for an immediate annuity plan. People with dependent spouses

option than under the "without RoPP" option.

Burugupalli adds that individuals concerned about inflation may consider increasing annuities. These plans offer a fixed, pre-declared rate of increase, which is not market-linked. Prioritise your needs, then compare the payouts from various options to understand the trade-offs.

Lock in today's annuity rates

The biggest advantage of deferred annuities is the certainty they bring to retirement planning. "They allow a person to lock in an annuity rate today for a payout that begins later," says Kumar. They also offer payouts for life.

But liquidity is a concern. "Funds are usually locked in during the accumulation period, limiting access in case of unforeseen needs," says Burugupalli.

"The returns from a deferred annuity plan may be lower than the returns from a diversified investment portfolio," says Kumar.

Before investing in a plan, compare annuity rates, which can vary significantly across insurers. Finally, avoid committing your entire retirement corpus to annuities, as that could cause you liquidity problems.

The writer is a Mumbai-based independent journalist

Check returns across insurers before buying

Insurer	Plan name	Pension per month (₹)*	Pension per month (₹)**
Bajaj Life	Guaranteed Pension Goal - II	10,747	5,102
Tata AIA	Fortune Guarantee Pension	10,190	4,760
ABSLI	Guaranteed Annuity Plan	10,023	5,327
Ipru	Guaranteed Pension Plan	9,798	5,025

*Pension is for a 50-year-old male, who makes a single payment of ₹10 lakh, and starts receiving payouts after 10 years.
**Pension is for a 60-year-old male, who makes a single payment of ₹10 lakh, and starts receiving payouts immediately.
Both are single-life, return-of-premium plans. Source: Policybazaar

Filing returns for overseas pension accounts: What taxpayers must know

New income-tax return (ITR) documents for assessment year 2026-27 have discontinued earlier forms for reporting foreign pension assets, changing paperwork for Indians holding such investments.

For taxpayers with accounts such as US 401(k), UK SIPP or Canadian RRSP, filing ITR-1 (Sahaj) or ITR-4 (Sugam) is no longer permitted. Professionals who filed ITR-1 after returning to India could be caught off guard. "This year, that return will be treated as defective before it is even processed," said Parag Jain, a chartered accountant and tax head at 1 Finance.

Taxpayers must now disclose foreign retirement accounts in:

- Schedule FA (Foreign Assets): Account details, country, peak balance
- Schedule FSI (Foreign Source Income): Income such as interest, dividends, or pension

Errors that could lead to scrutiny or penalties:

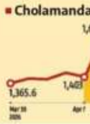
- Filing ITR-1 or ITR-4 despite holding foreign assets will result in the return being rejected
- Not reporting dormant or non-income-generating accounts
- Filing Form 10-EE does not remove the need to disclose foreign assets. Both obligations exist simultaneously
- Foreign assets must be reported on a calendar year basis, not the Indian financial year

Read full report here: mybs.in/2g5Lj08

COMPILED BY AMIT KUMAR

IN THE NEWS

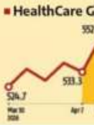
Cholamandalam Financial Holdings



Top gainer among BSE 500 Companies

₹1,403.0 PREVIOUS CLOSE
₹1,635.3 CLOSE
▲ 16.6% UP

HealthCare Global Enterprises



Trading volume surged 22 times over 2-week average

₹533.3 PREVIOUS CLOSE
₹552.9 CLOSE
▲ 3.7% UP

National Aluminium Co

Snaps 8-day winning streak

₹411.7 PREVIOUS CLOSE
₹400.1 CLOSE
▼ 2.8% DOWN

*OVER PREVIOUS CLOSE

STOCK OF THE DAY

Godawari Power and Ispat

Hits new all time high at ₹296; Up 50 per cent in a year

NIFTY 50

Company	Close (₹) 8 Apr '26	% Chg	Wt (%)	PE Con	PE Std	Company	Close (₹) 8 Apr '26	% Chg	Wt (%)	PE Con	PE Std
Adani Enter	2043.8	8.6	0.6	79.6	113.1	JSW Steel	1194.3	3.7	1.4	37.2	40.5
Adani Ports	1453.3	5.2	0.9	26.5	168.2	Kotak Mah Bank	380.2	4.7	2.4	20.1	27.9
Apollo Hosp	7401.5	1.0	0.7	58.6	73.3	L&T	4005.5	7.6	4.8	32.0	40.7
Asian Paints	2282.4	4.4	0.9	51.6	54.5	Mah & Mah	3210.1	6.8	2.9	25.0	26.0
Axis Bank	1333.0	6.6	3.3	15.8	16.9	Maruti Suzuki	13602.0	6.3	1.6	28.6	29.5
Bajaj Auto	9366.8	3.5	1.0	29.3	28.5	Max Health	941.2	0.9	0.6	62.8	130.2
Bajaj Fin	915.1	7.8	2.3	31.3	35.4	Nestle India	1213.7	-0.7	0.8	74.9	73.6
Bajaj Finsrv	1784.6	5.9	1.0	28.7	200.7	NTPC	374.2	1.4	1.5	15.0	18.0
Bharat Elctn	433.1	1.2	1.4	53.1	53.2	ONGC	285.5	-0.4	1.3	9.5	11.0
Bharti Airtel	1861.6	1.7	4.9	37.8	51.9	Power Grid	294.9	-0.2	1.2	17.7	17.5
Cipla	1215.9	1.1	0.6	20.7	21.4	Reliance Ind	1347.8	3.3	8.1	24.1	45.9
Coal India	449.3	-3.0	0.9	9.3	16.8	SBI	1061.5	3.8	3.8	12.1	13.8
Dr Reddys	1191.4	-0.4	0.6	17.9	21.4	SBI Life Ins	1987.6	3.6	0.7	-	77.2
Eicher Motor	7131.8	8.8	0.9	36.2	39.3	Shriram Finance	1021.2	9.9	1.3	21.0	21.1
Eternal	243.6	5.8	2.1	-	92.0	Sun Pharma	1714.6	-0.2	1.8	33.9	94.3
Grasim Ind	2756.2	5.2	0.9	39.7	486.1	Tata Consumer P	1064.5	0.6	0.6	72.8	69.5
HCL Techno	1461.8	1.3	1.4	21.1	32.3	Tata Motors PV	334.8	8.4	0.6	20.9	22.1
HDFC Bank	826.1	5.2	11.0	16.5	17.2	Tata Steel	204.2	3.1	1.5	26.0	16.2
HDFC Std Life	598.3	2.9	0.6	68.3	68.3	TCS	2559.2	0.8	2.5	18.1	19.0
Hindalco	951.8	-0.3	1.2	12.3	24.6	Tech Mahindra	1451.4	-1.5	0.8	29.6	33.8
HUL	2145.6	1.7	1.7	46.2	47.1	Titan Company	4492.5	6.2	1.6	81.7	89.0
ICICI Bank	1309.2	5.1	8.2	17.7	19.1	Trent	3985.6	2.2	0.8	83.8	73.7
Infosys	1346.2	0.5	4.1	18.9	19.6	UltraTech	11603.0	6.1	1.2	44.0	45.3
InterGlobe Avia	4615.5	8.1	0.9	38.9	39.4	Wipro	203.4	-0.6	0.5	16.1	17.8
ITC	302.5	1.3	3.3	18.4	18.8	Nifty 50	23997.4	+3.8	100.0	21.8	27.6
Jio Financial	240.9	4.9	0.7	99.1	224.4						

BSE SENSEX

Company	Close (₹)	% Chg	Wt (%)	PE Con	PE Std	Company	Close (₹)	% Chg	Wt (%)	PE Con	PE Std
Adani Ports	1453.8	5.3	1.2	26.5	168.3	L&T	4007.4	7.6	5.8	32.0	40.7
Asian Paints	2285.1	4.5	1.1	53.7	54.6	Mah & Mah	3210.7	6.8	3.4	25.0	26.0
Axis Bank	1332.8	6.6	4.0	15.8	16.9	Maruti Suzuki	13602.6	6.3	1.9	28.6	29.5
Bajaj Fin	915.5	7.8	2.7	31.3	35.4	NTPC	374.3	1.4	1.9	15.0	18.0
Bajaj Finsrv	1784.1	5.8	1.2	28.7	200.7	Power Grid	294.9	-0.2	1.4	17.7	17.5
Bharat Elctn	433.0	1.2	1.6	53.1	53.2	Reliance Ind	1347.8	3.3	9.7	24.0	45.9
Bharti Airtel	1861.6	1.6	5.9	37.0	51.9	SBI	1061.1	3.8	4.6	12.1	13.0
Eternal	243.6	5.8	2.5	-	93.0	Sun Pharma	1713.6	-0.3	2.0	33.9	94.2
HCL Techno	1457.2	1.1	1.6	23.0	32.2	Tata Steel	204.3	3.1	1.8	26.0	16.2
HDFC Bank	816.1	5.7	13.1	16.9	17.2	TCS	2559.8	0.8	2.7	18.1	19.0
HUL	2145.7	1.7	2.0	46.2	47.1	Tech Mahindra	1450.9	-1.5	1.0	29.6	33.8
ICICI Bank	1309.3	5.1	9.0	17.7	19.1	Titan Company	4492.1	6.2	2.0	81.7	89.0
Infosys	1346.3	0.5	4.9	18.9	19.0	Trent	3995.7	2.2	0.9	83.8	73.7
InterGlobe Avia	4616.6	8.2	1.1	38.9	39.4	UltraTech	11599.5	6.1	1.5	44.0	45.3
ITC	302.4	1.3	4.0	18.4	18.8	BSE SENSEX	77562.9	+3.9	100.0	21.8	27.
Kotak Mah Bank	380.0	4.8	2.9	20.1	27.9						

C = Consolidated; S = Standalone

WORLD INDICES

Indices	Close	%Chg*	Indices	Close	%Chg*
Americas (Apr 07,26)			Asia/Pacific (Apr 08,26)		
S&P/ TSX Composite	33237.5	0.2	Kospi	5872.3	6.9
Nasdaq Composite	22017.9	0.1	Taiwan Taiex	34761.4	4.6
Dow Jones	46584.5	-0.2	Jakarta Composite	7279.2	4.4
Europe/Africa (Apr 07,26)			Shanghai Se Comp	3995.0	2.7
DAX	23884.9	4.2	Stock Exchange of Thai (Apr 07)	1405.0	1.4
CAC 40	8209.8	3.8	Kuala Lumpur Comp	1696.3	1.2
IBEX 35	17961.4	3.0	Straits Times	4996.1	0.8
FTSE 100	10598.1	2.3	Volatility (Apr 07,26)		
Asia/Pacific (Apr 08,26)			CBOE Dow Jones	23.1	4.1
Nikkei 225	56308.4	5.4	CBOE S&P 500	20.5	-20.5
Hang Seng	25893.0	3.1			

*Change over previous close

MAJOR INDICES

	Previous Close	Open	High	Low	Close	Change	% chg
BSE Sensex	74,616.6	77,290.6	77,635.5	77,042.2	77,562.9	2946.3	3.9
BSE Sensex 50	24,175.4	24,899.5	25,111.3	24,916.6	25,085.1	909.9	3.8
BSE-100	24,268.9	25,128.6	25,224.5	25,022.1	25,197.6	928.6	3.8
BSE-200	10,527.8	10,902.3	10,950.0	10,855.7	10,919.0	411.2	3.9
BSE-500	33,395.1	34,583.6	34,723.0	34,422.9	34,690.6	1295.5	3.9
BSE IPO	14,240.2	14,702.2	14,805.5	14,609.8	14,768.7	528.5	3.7
Dollex-30	6,593.7	-	-	-	6,875.8	282.1	4.3
Nifty 50	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	3.9
Nifty Next50	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Nifty 500	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
India VIX	24.7	24.7	24.7	19.3	19.7	-5.0	-20.2
Nifty CPSE	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	-0.6	[illegible]

ADVANCES/DECLINES

[illegible]

MARKET OVERVIEW

[illegible]

TRADING ACTIVITY

[illegible]

FIIs IN DERIVATIVES

[illegible]

BSE SECTORAL INDICES

Auto	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Bankex	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Cons. Durables	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Cap. Goods	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
FMCG	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Healthcare	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Infra	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
IT	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Metal	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Oil & Gas	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Power	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
PSU	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Realty	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]

F&O SNAPSHOT

[illegible]

PUT-CALL RATIO

[illegible]

ACTIVE CALLS

[illegible]

ACTIVE PUTS

[illegible]

SPURT IN VOLUMES

[illegible]

52-WEEK NEW HIGHS/LOWS

[illegible]

* Indicates that the market price of these companies reached two-year high/lows.

DAY'S TOP GAINERS

Company	Day's high	Close	% chg*	2-wk high	52 wk high
[illegible]					
HPCL	367.7	364.3	9.0	475.3	508.5
Tata Motors CV	445.7	433.8	9.5	589.0	589.0
PG Elect	487.3	482.3	9.5	634.4	1000.0
Au Small Fin	972.2	967.4	9.0	1038.0	1038.0
Navama	1289.5	1288.8	8.9	1501.8	1702.0
Samvardhana Mot	119.5	118.1	8.9	136.1	136.1
Adani Energy So	1085.1	1073.3	8.8	1085.1	1085.1
HDFC AMC	2560.0	2549.3	8.8	2981.0	2965.0
Angel One	268.7	267.5	8.7	288.7	328.3

DAY'S TOP LOSERS

Company	Day's low	Close	% chg*	2-wk low	52 wk low
[illegible]					
Nestle India	1209.2	1213.2	-0.8	1160.0	1085.0
Marico	746.1	747.5	-0.7	708.7	644.3
Wipro	202.9	203.3	-0.7	186.5	186.5
Torrent Phar	4000.0	4027.6	-0.5	3724.1	3101.0
Dr Reddys	1185.5	1191.5	-0.4	1149.0	1062.2
ONGC	274.8	285.5	-0.4	231.7	239.2
Sun Pharma	1685.5	1713.0	-0.3	1583.6	1547.3
Hindalco	947.2	951.9	-0.3	835.8	552.5
Persistent S	5323.4	5373.6	-0.2	4450.0	4370.0

* Ranked on the basis of percentage gain/loss on previous close

MOST TRADED

	Value BSE+NSE (₹ crore)	Volume BSE+NSE (Mn shrs)
HDFC Bank	5954.3	73.3
ICICI Bank	3402.0	26.0
BSE	3287.2	18.4
SBI	3291.9	30.0
Reliance Ind	3190.9	23.8
L&T	3080.3	7.7
InterGlobe Avia	2681.1	5.8
Gallantt Ispat	2397.5	34.8
Infosys	2348.8	17.5
Bharti Airtel	2217.9	11.9
Shriram Finance	1903.3	18.7
Axis Bank	1888.1	14.0
Ashok Leyland	1828.0	108.1
Titan Company	1822.9	4.1
Adani Green En	1728.4	17.0
Tata Motors CV	1675.0	38.6
Eternal	1637.8	67.1
Maruti Suzuki	1457.4	1.1
Mah & Mah	1438.0	4.5
Bajaj Fin	1331.0	14.6
TCS	1290.3	5.0
Adani Power	1268.1	74.8
Vedanta	1254.1	17.3
ONGC	1252.2	43.8
Kotak Mah Bank	1239.8	32.7

TOP M-CAP

Rank	Company	Mcap (₹ cr)
1	Reliance Ind	1821838.0
2	HDFC Bank	1256255.4
3	Bharti Airtel	1134261.3
4	SBI	979459.0
5↑	ICICI Bank	937534.3
6↓	TCS	926161.2
7↑	Bajaj Fin	569638.0
8↑	L&T	551271.1
9↓	Infosys	545987.8
10	HUL	504141.9
11	LIC India	501888.0
12↑	Maruti Suzuki	427664.2
13↑	Axis Bank	414254.2
14↓	Sun Pharma	411144.0
15↑	Mah & Mah	399257.0
16	Titan Company	398826.4
17↓	HCL Techno	395433.1
18↓	ITC	378829.4
19	Kotak Mah Bank	377967.0
20↑	NTPC	362897.9
21↓	ONGC	359167.0
22	UltraTech	341834.1
23	Adani Ports	334936.7
24	Adani Power	326297.1
25	Bharat Elctn	316514.3
26↑	JSW Steel	292084.9
27↑	Bajaj Finsrv	285545.2
28↓	Avenue Supermar	284831.5
29	Vedanta	281998.5
30↓	Coal India	276829.8

TRENDS

Company	% change	Company	% change
BS200		Elitecon	-36.5
UP 3 DAYS		IEC Edu	-21.1
Adani Green En	20.4	Ranjit Sec.	-13.2
Ashok Leyland	16.0	IE Infotech	-13.2
Titagarh	15.3	True Green Bio	-12.0
Shriram Finance	14.8	UP 3 DAYS	
Prestige Est	14.7	Ahd Steelcft	61.1
Chola Inv	14.5	Krypton Ind	55.8
Godrej Prpty	12.8	Quest Flow	48.6
DOWN		SKM	47.6
Dr Reddys	-2.1	Lux Inds	44.0
Others		KPT Inds	44.0
UP 7 DAYS		Al Champdany	41.8
Glittek Gra	40.7	DOWN 3 DAYS	
Magnus Retail	40.7	Raj Tele	-40.8
Yashinto Inds	40.7	AmirChand Jagdu	-27.1
Madern Mall.	40.4	Gyan Develop	-20.5
Maitri Enterpri	40.4	Yash Trading	-14.2
Talsyan Nec	36.0	Highness Micro	-14.0
Seton Auto	36.0	Informed Tec	-13.8
DOWN 7 DAYS		Ambasgri	-13.1
Citurgia Bio	-30.1		
Nilachal Ref	-30.1		

BOARD MEETINGS

Group Company Purpose

APRIL 09

Anand Rathi Wea: Audited Results & Final Dividend.

CHD Chemicals: To consider and approve the draft notice convening the Extra Ordinary General Meeting.

Galaxy Agric: To consider and approve 1. Appointment of Directors. 2. Resignation of Directors. 3. Change in Registered Office Address of the [illegible]

Indrayani Bio: To consider and approve a proposal of de-merger of a unit of the Company.

Premier Auto: To consider and approve Audited Financial Results (Standalone) for the Quarter and year ended 31st March 2026.

Rajputana Stainl: To inter alia consider and approve the Unaudited standalone financial Results of the company for third quarter and nine months [illegible] ance of equity shares and / or other securities and Conduct of an Extraordinary General Meeting.

Sbl: To consider and approve 1. Draft letter of the Company including matters Connected there to and related documentation 2. Any other Business with Permission of Chair

TCS: To consider and approve audited standalone financial results of the Com[illegible]

APRIL 10

Agri-Tech I: To consider and approve audited financial results as on 31st March 2026

Eco Hotels: For Audited (Standalone & Consolidated) Financial Results for FY 2025-26

Energy Infra Tr: Meeting of board of directors of the company

Faalcon: Meeting of the Board of Directors of the Company

Davis Sec: Right Issue of Equity Shares [illegible] any 3 & 4. Noting minutes of previous Board Meeting/Committee meeting(s)

USG Tech Solu: Meeting of the Board of Directors of the Company

Vishu Bhagnani: To consider and approve the proposal for the listing of the Company's equity shares on the National Stock Exchange of India Limited (NSE)

Virgoglob: To consider and approve the proposal for Reduction of [illegible] and approve discuss business matters.

APRIL 11

B2B Soft Tec: To consider and approve Audited Financial [illegible]

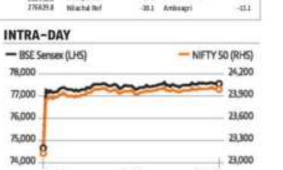
Gravera: To consider and approve the proposal for setting Feed Mill Project unit of Company; To consider and approve the [illegible] Aquaculture unit of the Company.

Swadhulture: To consider and approve Audited financial results for the quarter and [illegible] To consider and approve audited financial results of the Company for the quarter and year ending March 31 2026.

Ad Bid Finm: [illegible] approve appointments & resignation

Swaraj Engin: Consider and approve the Audited Financial Results of the Company [illegible]

INTRA-DAY



BS 200

WHAT THIS STOCK PAGE CONTAINS AND WHY

BS 200 stocks account for over 85 per cent of the volume of shares, value and trades on the Bombay Stock Exchange and National Stock Exchange. For BS 200 stocks, the company name is followed by its BSE group in brackets and the symbol indicating the paid-up value. Four categories of information are provided: First, the basic information on the day's trading. Information is also given on the number of shares traded, and also the price trend with 52-week highs and lows. The third sub-set of information is the stock's market capitalisation. The market capitalisation is shown in ₹crore and is arrived at by multiplying the closing prices of shares with equity capital. It changes either because more shares have been issued (or extinguished) or the price has moved. The table also contains the company's price-earnings (P/E) multiple. The P/E multiple is arrived at by dividing the day's closing price by its reported earnings per share (EPS) for trailing 12 months. EPS is calculated on the basis of consolidated earnings wherever available. In the futures and options (F&O) section a wide set of data has been provided. Open interest: OI is the number of contracts open at end of day in the futures and options segment. OI thus indicates traders' expectations. High OI is typical when traders see a continuing trend. **Strike Price:** The price at which an option may be exercised. An option is "in-the-money" if the market price exceeds the SP (in case of a call option) and the market price is below SP (in case of a put). Otherwise it is "out-of-money". Expiry date: The date on which a derivative expires. An unexercised option becomes valueless while futures contracts are compulsorily settled on expiry. On NSE, it is the last Thursday of every month. Put/call ratio: The ratio of open interest in put options & call options. ABBREVIATIONS: When a significant change occurs in the day's closing value compared with the previous close, the close price is underlined. A significant change means a 3 per cent rise or fall in scrips whose market values are over 10 times paid-up value or 5 per cent for the rest of the shares. The letters H or L appended to prices indicate a new high or low in the scrip; the letters XD after the traded quotes indicate that the scrip has gone ex-dividend after that date; XB denotes ex-bonus, XR ex-rights; XD ex-indicator for other corporate actions like AGM/EGM/preference shares/mergers and others. M denotes volume of shares in million, L in lakhs & K in '000'.

[illegible]

52 Wk H/L	432/141	432/141	131/77	131/77	1348/1085	1348/1085	92/69	92/72	87/60	87/60	395/316	395/316
Mcap	73475	73493	23938	23967	233941	234038	77015	77045	72919	72893	362898	362901
	Pidilite Ind★		**PNB★**		**PNB Hou Fin**		**Policy Bazar★**		**Polycab India**		**Power Fin**	
PClose	(1295.8)	(1295.1)	(104.6)	(104.6)	(816.8)	(817.0)	(1459.7)	(1459.7)	(7230.0)	(7227.0)	(407.1)	(407.4)
Open	1374.0	1400.0	109.2	109.0	837.9	834.9	1488.8	1487.3	7485.9	7450.0	422.1	423.0
High	1394.0	1400.4	111.5	111.4	885.0	885.5	1516.0	1516.6	7644.0	7648.5	425.7	425.8
Low	1350.0	1350.0	108.5	108.6	837.9	834.9	1488.1	1485.0	7447.0	7442.0	414.0	413.8
Close	1355.4	1355.0	111.2	111.1	873.6	873.1	1498.5	1498.5	7601.2	7600.5	417.2	417.7
Shares	1066K	1856K	3793K	28565K	13260	1056K	83863	1202K	44502	714K	314K	14646K
PE	59.6	59.6	7.2	7.2	10.4	10.4	119.7	119.7	43.6	43.6	5.5	5.5
52 Wk H/L	1575/1299	1575/1298	135/89	135/89	1142/738	1142/738	1978/1334	1978/1364	8724/4893	8722/4898	444/330	444/330
Mcap	137953	137912	127744	127733	22760	22754	69333	69336	114435	114426	137664	137829
	Shree Cement		**Shriram Finance★**		**Siemens★**		**Solar Ind★**		**Sona BLW Precis**		**SRF**	
PClose	(23346.3)	(23350.0)	(930.5)	(930.7)	(3074.1)	(3075.5)	(13401.5)	(13406.0)	(515.1)	(525.2)	(2396.1)	(2396.0)
Open	24750.0	24200.0	974.9	975.0	3220.2	3180.0	14000.0	14000.0	546.0	530.0	2515.9	2500.0
High	24750.0	24700.0	1035.7	1035.5	3244.9	3245.6	14000.0	14000.0	546.0	543.5	2515.9	2506.0
Low	23945.0	23895.0	973.0	975.0	3150.0	3147.0	13490.0	13495.0	525.9	525.7	2421.0	2420.2
Close	24330.8	24360.0	1023.6	1023.2	3227.6	3226.1	13660.9	13662.0	533.9	533.7	2436.3	2435.1
Shares	1163	31556	461K	18257K	13217	398K	15761	186K	1991K	2802K	23347	895K
PE	49.0	49.8	21.1	21.0	70.3	70.3	85.1	85.1	50.9	50.9	39.0	39.0
52 Wk H/L	[illegible]	[illegible]	1108/566	1108/567	3461/2660	3460/2660	[illegible]	[illegible]	559/403	560/402	3319/2314	3325/2305
Mcap	87786	87891	192586	192520	114935	114882	123631	123641	33197	33188	72217	72181
	Titan Company★		**Torrent Pharm★**		**Torrent Pwr**		**Trent★**		**Tube Inv of India★**		**TVS Motor★**	
PClose	(4238.7)	(4230.6)	(4049.2)	(4051.3)	(1400.0)	(1399.5)	(3823.4)	(3823.0)	(2588.3)	(2588.2)	(3469.1)	(3470.6)
Open	4389.0	4351.3	4076.0	4098.9	1428.2	1430.0	3960.0	3960.0	2673.2	2694.9	3649.0	3640.0
High	4514.0	4505.0	4090.9	4098.9	1475.0	1475.0	3998.0	3999.0	2755.0	2757.9	3735.5	3736.0
Low	4311.0	4309.1	4000.0	3997.7	1425.0	1424.9	3895.8	3891.8	2646.1	2650.6	3578.4	3573.9
Close	4492.3	4492.5	4027.6	4029.2	1448.2	1448.4	3905.7	3905.0	2730.9	2727.1	3697.9	3701.4
Shares	262K	3835K	94075	435K	24342	376K	94784	1426K	29129	354K	94536	1533K
PE	81.7	81.7	59.1	59.1	23.1	23.1	83.8	83.8	83.4	83.3	60.2	60.3
52 Wk H/L	4514/3090	4505/3091	4480/3101	4481/3102	1640/1188	1640/1188	6259/3276	6261/3274	3419/2165	3428/2165	3978/2424	3979/2427
Mcap	398826	398844	136318	136364	72975	72985	138846	138823	52870	52797	175685	175854

52 Wk H/L	286/172	286/172	2866/1198	2865/1191	524/336	524/336	293/228	293/229	9948/6232	9958/6235	671/455	678/454
Mcap	72725	72745	59476	59478	74645	74653	359167	359167	62484	62495	51173	50983
	Power Grid		**Premier Energie★**		**Prestige Est**		**Rail Vikas Nigm**		**RBL Bank**		**REC**	
PClose	(295.5)	(295.4)	(942.3)	(943.3)	(1222.6)	(1222.1)	(261.1)	(261.3)	(312.6)	(312.6)	(329.5)	(329.4)
Open	300.4	301.0	973.9	962.5	1300.1	1300.0	278.0	275.0	323.2	324.0	339.5	344.9
High	301.0	301.8	973.9	974.0	1347.1	1347.0	278.0	276.5	326.8	326.8	343.2	344.9
Low	293.6	293.6	939.8	939.1	1287.3	1288.3	271.2	271.2	318.7	318.6	337.7	337.6
Close	294.8	294.9	960.2	959.7	1321.9	1320.8	275.1	274.9	322.6	322.9	342.7	342.7
Shares	382K	10888K	75399	1663K	99652	2514K	441K	7153K	384K	6089K	758K	6841K
PE	17.7	17.7	32.7	32.7	58.7	58.6	50.0	50.0	27.6	27.7	5.2	5.2
52 Wk H/L	322/250	322/250	1164/661	1164/660	1812/1064	1814/1062	448/248	448/248	340/165	340/165	447/304	448/304
Mcap	274220	274228	43495	43472	56938	56891	57359	57326	19945	19963	90240	90227
	Sun Pharma★		**Supreme Ind★**		**Suzlon Energy★**		**Swiggy★**		**Tata Consumer P★**		**Tata Elxsi**	
PClose	(1718.5)	(1718.0)	(3772.9)	(3772.4)	(41.5)	(41.5)	(269.0)	(269.3)	(1061.8)	(1062.8)	(4357.3)	(4357.6)
Open	1749.9	1738.0	3949.0	3941.4	43.3	43.4	285.0	281.0	1084.9	1076.0	4499.8	4490.0
High	1749.9	1749.2	3949.0	3941.4	44.4	44.4	285.7	285.6	1091.2	1091.9	4499.8	4490.0
Low	1685.5	1685.5	3748.5	3745.6	42.7	42.6	275.7	275.6	1066.0	1066.0	4387.3	4388.0
Close	1713.6	1714.6	3793.4	3787.9	44.3	44.2	277.4	277.7	1068.3	1068.5	4427.1	4434.4
Shares	229K	4860K	16369	264K	5911K	98804K	391K	15185K	33018	1950K	16420	203K
PE	33.9	33.9	59.2	59.1	18.6	18.6	-	-	72.9	72.9	43.7	43.8
52 Wk H/L	1851/1547	1851/1548	4740/3106	4739/3105	74/38	74/38	473/256	474/257	1221/1007	1221/1007	6734/3970	6735/3966
Mcap	411144	411184	48195	48125	60200	60172	76671	76640	105714	105739	27581	27626
	UltraTech		**Union Bank**		**United Spirit★**		**Uno Minda★**		**UPL★**		**Varun Bever★**	
PClose	(10929.8)	(10936.0)	(171.8)	(171.9)	(1237.3)	(1238.1)	(1020.9)	(1021.4)	(607.5)	(607.5)	(400.6)	(400.9)
Open	11574.9	11400.0	181.7	180.0	1280.0	1269.0	1058.1	1060.0	633.8	625.0	415.4	412.9
High	11777.3	11776.0	186.8	186.9	1280.0	1270.5	1100.0	1100.5	643.4	643.5	424.0	424.0
Low	11384.9	11349.0	178.9	179.0	1246.2	1246.3	1051.3	1050.0	623.0	622.7	411.6	411.1
Close	11599.5	11603.0	185.7	185.7	1248.8	1248.8	1091.0	1090.2	639.9	640.3	421.9	421.9
Shares	15044	613K	704K	20660K	64156	713K	44780	1392K	44797	3242K	222K	6926K
PE	44.0	44.0	7.5	7.5	51.6	51.6	54.3	54.3	27.9	27.9	48.7	48.7
52 Wk H/L	[illegible]	[illegible]	205/113	205/115	1645/1210	1645/1211	1382/808	1382/807	812/565	812/565	569/381	569/381
Mcap	341814	341917	141756	141726	90828	90871	62991	62948	53987	54033	142674	142691

52 Wk H/L	1382/789	1382/789	6987/4378	6695/4341	327/235	327/235	1008/437	1008/437	1965/1403	1993/1403	4329/2780	4330/2780
Mcap	71235	71229	84773	84779	40545	40562	13760	13761	61226	61269	43655	43644
	Reliance Ind		**SAIL**		**Samvardhana Moth★**		**SBI★**		**SBI Card & Pay**		**SBI Life Ins**	
PClose	(1304.7)	(1304.6)	(160.9)	(160.6)	(108.4)	(108.4)	(1030.3)	(1030.4)	(639.5)	(639.2)	(1841.4)	(1841.4)
Open	1350.0	1349.0	164.6	165.0	115.5	114.9	1076.6	1074.0	663.0	660.0	1896.8	1880.0
High	1350.5	1350.6	168.9	169.0	119.5	122.3	1078.5	1077.8	677.9	678.2	1922.4	1923.0
Low	1326.5	1326.2	162.5	162.4	113.9	114.0	1059.4	1059.5	652.5	652.0	1875.0	1870.0
Close	1347.8	1347.8	164.4	164.4	118.1	118.1	1061.1	1061.5	671.2	671.3	1907.5	1907.6
Shares	1943K	21818K	2938K	34941K	1429K	42283K	1429K	28534K	62209	1734K	16591	1104K
PE	24.0	24.1	22.4	22.4	35.2	35.3	12.1	12.1	30.5	30.5	77.2	77.2
52 Wk H/L	1611/1169	1612/1168	169/101	169/101	136/75	136/75	1235/741	1235/741	1023/615	1027/616	2133/1476	2132/1475
Mcap	1823839	1823906	67885	67910	124595	124658	979459	979782	63871	63876	191321	191336
	Tata Motors PV★		**Tata Power★**		**Tata Steel★**		**Tata Technol★**		**TCS★**		**Tech Mahindra★**	
PClose	(308.6)	(308.7)	(387.6)	(387.7)	(198.1)	(198.1)	(551.0)	(548.5)	(2539.9)	(2539.8)	(1473.3)	(1473.4)
Open	332.5	321.0	398.6	395.0	202.4	202.0	566.0	566.0	2584.0	2572.0	1490.0	1484.0
High	336.8	337.0	398.6	397.5	206.5	206.4	566.1	566.0	2584.0	2580.3	1490.6	1493.0
Low	318.9	319.0	392.2	392.1	202.1	202.4	554.8	554.9	2540.2	2540.1	1446.5	1445.8
Close	335.1	334.8	394.9	395.0	204.3	204.2	561.6	561.4	2559.8	2559.2	1450.9	1451.4
Shares	1115K	20930K	298K	7324K	1471K	37018K	101K	741K	277K	4769K	120K	2737K
PE	20.9	20.9	33.4	33.4	26.0	26.0	34.7	34.7	18.1	18.1	29.6	29.6
52 Wk H/L	744/294	744/294	418/342	418/342	217/125	216/125	797/508	797/507	3630/2346	3631/2346	1858/1265	1856/1264
Mcap	123379	123268	126182	126198	254975	254888	22801	22791	926161	925944	142168	142214
	Vedanta★		**Vodafone Idea**		**Voltas★**		**Waaree Energies**		**Wipro★**		**YES Bank★**	
PClose	(713.6)	(713.3)	(8.6)	(8.6)	(1220.5)	(1220.2)	(3081.3)	(3083.8)	(204.7)	(204.7)	(18.1)	(18.1)
Open	735.0	734.0	9.0	9.0	1246.2	1250.0	3155.1	3150.0	208.8	207.7	18.7	18.9
High	735.0	735.0	9.3	9.3	1277.4	1278.0	3155.2	3150.0	208.8	209.0	19.1	19.1
Low	717.3	717.3	8.9	8.9	1246.2	1246.4	3090.0	3088.2	202.9	202.8	18.7	18.7
Close	721.2	721.4	9.2	9.2	1263.9	1264.8	3125.0	3125.0	203.1	203.4	19.0	19.0
Shares	928K	16394K	49566K	640895K	92427	1549K	67322	1759K	827K	22084K	11422K	117741K
PE	29.3	29.3	-	-	80.7	80.7	25.8	25.8	16.1	16.1	18.9	18.9
52 Wk H/L	770/369	770/369	13/6	13/6	1582/1186	1583/1187	3864/2074	3865/2072	273/187	273/187	24/17	24/17
Mcap	281999	282096	99784	99676	41821	41852	89889	89891	213229	213355	59747	59747

A debate unscrolled

The question of whether or not to ban or regulate social media for children and teenagers has no easy answers

AASHISH ARYAN & AVIK DAS
New Delhi/Bengaluru, 8 April

Nearly six years after British scientist Tim Berners Lee launched the World Wide Web in 1991, American businessman Andrew Weinreich tapped into Greek philosopher Aristotle's statement, "Man is a social animal", to present a virtual universe that would allow that social instinct to exhibit itself in a way humankind probably never fathomed possible. He launched the world's first social media platform: SixDegrees.com.

It did what social media platforms today were originally meant to do, which is to let users add friends, family, and acquaintances through a common portal, and exchange interests with them. Its scale, of course, wasn't a match to the reach and impact of today's platforms, even though at its peak it had more than 3.5 million users worldwide, representing 3 per cent of all internet users active then.

Thirty years since SixDegrees.com opened an unexplored world rife with potential, social media has raced past all other internet activity to become the most widely used digital service. Today, nearly 97 per cent of all internet users log on to a social media service every day, spending an average of 2.5 hours on the activity, according to the Digital 2026 Global Overview report by We Are Social UK, a London-headquartered agency specialising in social media marketing, strategy, and research.

Among these users are teenagers and young adults, to whom the digital world comes as second nature — to the extent that it often blurs the line between what is real and what is virtual. Hence, the rising concern about its impact on the mental health, self-image, and overall behaviour of this cohort. As a result, several governments have increased their scrutiny of these platforms, their algorithms, and their impact.

On December 10, 2025, Australia became the first country to take decisive action and ban the use of social media for those aged under 16. Others, such as Indonesia, South Korea, Austria, France, the United Kingdom, and the Philippines, have followed suit and are either considering banning social media for children under a certain age or regulating its usage.

India, which is one of the largest markets and user bases for social media intermediaries of all kinds, has also started considering measures such as banning these platforms or heavily regulating their use by children.

The use of social media by children in India is already regulated under the provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, which requires all social media users below the age of 18 to obtain verifiable parental consent while logging on to such platforms.

Besides this, governments at both the central and state levels are stepping up efforts to further regulate social media usage, especially by children. The debate is about imposing a complete ban or adopting a regulatory stance, which would mean certain restrictions.

Soon after Australia banned social media for those under 16, Andhra Pradesh's Minister for Information Technology, Electronics and Communications Nara Lokesh also hinted at bringing in a similar regulation.

Karnataka became the first state to propose strict restrictions on social media for children. However, the state's IT minister, Priyank Kharge, later said the idea was to regulate what children are exposed to on the internet rather than impose a complete ban.

"I think 'ban' would be a very harsh word. And it's very difficult to ban these things because, first, if we ban them on regulated platforms, people go to unregulated sites, which is even more dangerous," Kharge told *Business Standard* in March.

Not long after Karnataka's proposal, made public in the state's annual Budget, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu announced that the state would introduce a law by June to regulate the use of social media by teenagers and young adults, and ban it completely for those under 13.

Screenscrape

62%
of Indian teenagers use a mobile device for internet access

42%
say they operate others' social media accounts

56%
say they can log in to someone else's account

- Over 50% children from affluent families get a mobile device between the age of 11 and 13, compared to 38% teens from urban low-income families, and 42% from rural low-income families

88%
of urban affluent teens aged 16 and above have access to laptops, compared to 33% of urban low-income, and 19% of rural low-income teens

- About 93% of affluent children have a personal email ID, compared to 36% in urban low-income, and 28% in rural low-income groups

Restrictions and risks

The general view among those who work with this cohort is that an outright social media ban is unlikely to protect children from harm.

Uma Subramanian, founder and co-director of RATI Foundation, a Mumbai-based organisation focused on child protection, technology, and rights, is of the view that a blanket ban would be detrimental to children from marginalised segments of society since they mostly use shared devices, unlike those from well-off backgrounds who have access to personal devices.

"One should instead set accountability standards for these platforms," she said. "When we put a blanket ban, the risk-taking behaviour shifts to unregulated platforms."

When contacted, Tara Hopkins, the global director of public policy at Instagram, said: "We do share the same views as the vast majority of policymakers that teenagers, especially younger teenagers in the 13-15 age group, have the safest, most protected experience when they come to use social media platforms run by Meta."

Protecting children in their digital lives and ensuring they have a safe experience, however, is a "societal challenge", which cannot be solved solely by barring them from accessing certain platforms or services, Hopkins added.

Outright bans, as in the case of Australia, are blunt instruments that leave open "an awful lot of concerns and questions" for the government, the social media intermediary, as well as the parents, she said.

Although all social media intermediaries have complied with the law of the land, industry estimates indicate that Australian children are increasingly using virtual private networks (VPNs) to access their social media accounts.

A 2024-25 STUDY BY THE RATI FOUNDATION FOUND THAT DIGITAL SAFETY OF TEENAGERS IN INDIA WAS LARGELY "FRAGMENTED"

Australian children have also resorted to using "logged out" versions of these platforms, while also logging on to other lesser-known social media services that may not have as strict safety features, a senior executive at a social media intermediary said, asking not to be named.

To prevent similar problems, India will need to put in place safeguards, along with adopting a more controlled, regulated approach to exposing children to online platforms, Namita Viswanath, a partner at law firm CMS Induslaw, said.

Placing the onus entirely on social media intermediaries may not work in the long run, she said, since children will find ways to circumvent the restrictions placed on them, and the platforms might find it difficult to stop such logins completely.

"It is important to strike a balance, to incentivise platforms to also play a responsible role in this. Platforms cannot devote all their resources to trying to build technology to curb such usage," Viswanath said.

The India case

Studies have shown that teenagers and young adults in India use the internet and social media platforms very differently compared to similar-age users globally.

A 2024-25 study by the RATI Foundation found that the digital safety of teenagers in India is largely "fragmented".

"Many teens adopt practices in a piecemeal way, such as setting strong passwords yet missing foundational protections, such as avoiding password sharing or enabling recovery options. Platform safety features remain underused, leaving accounts especially vulnerable in shared-device contexts," the study covering 1,277 teenagers in the 13-17 age group across economic strata revealed. Though Meta's Instagram will soon introduce stricter age-gating and content norms for children in India, lawmakers will also need to identify children's online behaviour and their behaviour on their devices before enacting laws that regulate social media usage, Hopkins said.

Most teenagers, including those in India, use their devices by switching between apps and services such as Instagram, artificial intelligence tools and chatbots such as ChatGPT and Claude, as well as educational and sports applications of their respective schools, she said.

The challenge in enacting a law prohibiting children's use is, therefore, not limited to device and digital usage patterns. For example, even though the DPDP Act prohibits behavioural monitoring and targeted advertising, stakeholders believe it could lead to children losing out on the benefits of a personalised internet.

"Without personalisation, children could experience irrelevant content, reducing their ability to engage meaningfully online and also limiting innovative services to them," policy advocacy body CUTS International said in a report.

Such prohibition under the DPDP Act can expose children to inappropriate content, such as material promoting self-harm, violence, or misinformation. It could result in them facing an overwhelming flow of irrelevant or harmful material, posing risks to their online safety and diminishing their digital experience, the report said.

A similar approach, if used to implement the social media ban, could have an adverse, unintended impact on children, Viswanath said, adding that the states and the central government will have to work in tandem to ensure the restrictions are applied meaningfully.

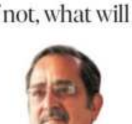
"The ability to enforce this will depend heavily on the central government's cooperation," she said. I think it will come down to what the threshold of expectation and obligations on social media intermediaries is, and what the impact of non-compliance is."

When it comes to impressionable minds and something as intense and all-pervasive as social media, there is clearly no one answer.

OPINION

Welfare politics and some procedural issues

Are the new or revised schemes costed properly? If not, what will it do to the Budget figures?



ASHOK KUMAR LAHIRI

In the olden days, the word of the supreme ruler was law, and they could order disbursal of funds to whoever, for whatever, and whenever they liked. This is not so any longer for chief ministers, and even prime ministers, in rule-bound democracies. Now, their powers are circumscribed by

The incumbent governments in all the four states of Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Jharkhand and Bihar won the elections with a larger number of seats than before: In Madhya Pradesh, it increased its tally from 109 to 163 seats out of 230; in Maharashtra, from 161 to 236 seats out of 288; in Jharkhand, the JMM-Congress-RJD alliance improved its count from 47 to 56 seats; and in Bihar, the NDA increased its tally from 125 seats in 2020 to 202 out of 243.

Assam is going to polls soon, and we will know the outcome in a couple of months. Some wonder whether the ability to announce such schemes has turned 'anti-incumbency' into 'pro-incumbency' in elections.

had passed, when the chief minister announced that the scheme would start from April 1 instead of August 15. Reportedly, there are eight million applicants, and the annual outgo on this scheme will be ₹14,400 crore, and not ₹5,000 crore.

Furthermore, there was the long-pending issue of dearness allowance (DA) of state government employees and pensioners. The government had repeatedly argued against this payment on grounds of financial crisis. The Supreme Court did not accept the argument, and, on February 5, ordered the state government to release the first instalment of arrears by March 31. The Interim Budget for West Bengal had no mention of this DA case.

On March 15, at 4 pm, the Election Commission announced legislative elections in West Bengal in two phases — on April 23 in 152 constituencies and then on April 29 in 142 constituencies. At 2:40

the Constitution. Discretionary powers are limited to the contingency fund established in the nature of an imprest to meet unforeseen expenditure. The legislature has to authorise even such expenditure post-facto under Articles 205 or 206. Some states, for example West Bengal, use the contingency fund sparingly — the last transfer to this fund was in 2021-22 to the tune of ₹180 crore.

Except for money 'charged' on the consolidated fund, for example governors' salaries and interest payments, all other expenditure, according to the Constitution, can be incurred by state governments only after authorisation by the legislature. In the understandable rush to get 'popular' schemes implemented before elections, have these rules been given short-shrift by some, for example, in West Bengal?

Welfare schemes, particularly women-specific ones, have become very popular with parties in power in poll-bound states. One example is Assam, which introduced Orunodoi in 2020 offering ₹830-1,100 monthly to women heads of households. Then there is Ladli Behna in Madhya Pradesh launched in March 2023, paying ₹1,000-1250 per month; Majhi Ladki Bahin scheme in Maharashtra in August 2024, offering ₹1,500 monthly to women aged 21-65; Maiya Samman in Jharkhand in August 2024, offering ₹1,100 monthly, later increased to ₹2,500 right before elections; and Mahila Rozgar Yojana in Bihar launched months before the 2025 election, offering Rs 10,000 in immediate assistance and a provision for up to ₹2 lakh in financial support.

With such empirical regularity, it is to be expected that parties in power in other states will also find it difficult to resist the temptation of introducing such schemes or enhancing their benefits. Particularly West Bengal, where the Trinamool Congress (TMC) government had introduced Lakshmir Bhandar — or Goddess Lakshmi's treasury — in February 2021, providing financial assistance to women from economically weaker sections. It provided women in the age group of 25-60 years and enrolled in 'Swasthya Sathi' ₹1,200 every month in SC/ST households and ₹1,000 per month to others. Launched a month before legislative elections at end-March 2021, it coincided with the TMC increasing its tally from 211 in 2016 to 215 out of 292 and romping home to power.

With the state going to polls in late April 2026, the TMC government in its Interim Budget presented on February 6 announced an increase in beneficiaries from 22.1 million to 24.2 million, and an additional amount of ₹500 per month per beneficiary retrospectively from February 2026. The government proposed an additional annual allocation of ₹15,000 crore for 2026-27. Strangely, there is no mention of the additional allocation needed in 2025-26, which could be upward of ₹2,000 crore.

There was also the announcement in the West Bengal Budget of a new scheme, 'Banglar Yuba Sathi', or Friend of Youth, from August 15, 2026 entitling youth aged 21-40 years a monthly assistance of ₹1,500 till they get employment or up to five years, whichever is earlier. There was an allocation of ₹5,000 crore in the Budget for this scheme. Not even a week pm, the chief minister increased the allowances for Muezzin and priests by ₹500 per month, and after 25 minutes, at 3:05 pm, she announced that the state government would start paying the pending DA arrears to the state government employees and pensioners from March this year. Where will the money come from? What does it do to the 2026-27 and even the 2025-26 Budget?

The social, economic and moral justification of welfare schemes vis-à-vis long-term development is a controversial issue. But the procedural part is straight and simple. Are the new or revised schemes costed properly? If not, what will it do to the Budget figures? How does a state government announce a scheme and start implementing it with finances from the consolidated fund of the state without the prior approval of the legislature? What happens to legislative oversight? What happens to the integrity of the Budget?

When the new outlays are large, it may not even be possible to manage the problem with reappropriation. With the nonchalant way we have started treating the public accounts committees, will the Comptroller and Auditor General's objections make any difference to the way governments function? We need to pay greater attention to these procedural issues if we want to avoid the current financial indiscipline ballooning into a fiscal crisis in some states.

The writer is a member of the West Bengal legislative Assembly and former chief economic adviser to the Government of India

More loans for women, less room for new borrowers

These borrowers accounted for 26% of total credit in 2025: NITI report

AUHONA MUKHERJEE
& HIMANSHI BHARDWAJ
New Delhi, 8 April

The share of first-time women borrowers in India's credit system has declined in recent years, even as overall lending to women continues to expand, according to a joint report by TransUnion Cibil, NITI Aayog's Women Entrepreneurship Platform, and MicroSave Consulting, released on Wednesday.

The share of new-to-credit (NTC) women borrowers — defined as women taking their first microfinance loan via joint liability groups — has fallen from 28 per cent in 2022 and 2023 to 27 per cent in 2024, and further to 24 per cent in 2025, the report said. Over the same period, the share of existing-to-credit borrowers rose from 72 per cent to 76 per cent, indicating a higher proportion of loans extended to repeat borrowers.

"The share of NTC women borrowers in total originations has been declining since 2023, partly due to tighter guardrails and increased lender focus on existing borrowers. While lending to repeat borrowers helps maintain portfolio quality, it does not expand the reach of microfinance," the report said.

The microfinance segment, which serves as a key entry point for low-income women into formal credit, has faced a challenging 18-month period marked by a contraction in credit supply, attributed to borrower overleveraging and rising non-performing assets. "The share of credit-active borrowers has shifted from southern states such as Tamil Nadu to northern states such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar in 2025," the report added.

In retail credit, however, women's share among first-time borrowers has increased. The report shows that women accounted for 38 per cent of NTC originations in 2025, up from 28 per cent in 2022, indicating a rising share of women among new entrants in retail lending. Much of this growth has been driven by consumption and gold loan products, which continue to serve as the primary entry point into formal credit for women.

Overall, the report highlights that 160 million women were credit-active in 2025, with credit penetration among women rising to 36 per cent, up from 19 per cent in 2017. Women borrowers accounted for 26 per cent of total system credit, with outstanding portfolios reaching ₹76 trillion, a 4.8-fold increase since 2017.

Despite this growth, the report notes that the potential borrower base remains significantly larger, with around 450 million credit-eligible women in the country.

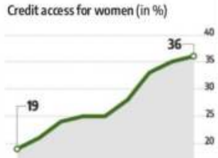
In terms of credit composition, retail loans continue to dominate, while the share of business-purpose lending has increased from 16 per cent in 2017 to 25 per cent in 2025. Microfinance has grown at a slower pace of 2.9x since 2017, compared with faster growth in other lending segments.

The report also observes that women's entry into formal credit is largely through consumption-led products such as gold loans, personal loans, and consumer durables financing, which account for a sizeable share of NTC originations.

It highlights that 19 per cent of active microfinance borrowers have moved to other credit products, including business loans, personal loans, and gold loans, indicating progression within the credit system.

Separately, a high-level meeting chaired by NITI Aayog Vice-Chairperson Suman Bery reviewed India's research and innovation ecosystem, with participation from senior government officials, industry representatives, and academic institutions. Discussions highlighted a persistent gap between industry and academia, with stakeholders noting that domestic industry continues to rely on imported technologies, limiting the translation of research into commercial outcomes.

The meeting flagged gaps in India's research-to-market pipeline, including limited access to shared testing and prototyping facilities, weak technology transfer linkages, and fragmented collaboration between institutions and industry. It also reviewed the need to streamline funding support, with the proposed Research Development and Innovation Fund identified as a mechanism to support late-stage research, product validation, and scaleup.



Note: Credit penetration is the percentage of credit active population to the total adult women (18 to 64) population

% share in origination volumes (YTD)

Year	NTC	ETC
2022	28	72
2023	28	72
2024	27	73
2025*	24	76

*Data as of November
Note: NTC is new-to-credit borrowers, ETC is existing-to-credit borrowers
Source: NITI Aayog report

National Quantum Mission achieves 1,000-km secure communication milestone

As part of the National Quantum Mission, a 1,000-km quantum communication network has been successfully demonstrated within less than two years of its launch, said Department of Science and Technology (DST) officials on Wednesday.

The network enables the transmission of information using quantum principles instead of classical binary signals in the form of 0s and 1s.

The development marks a rapid progress against the mission's target of achieving a 2,000-km quantum communication network over an eight-year period. In a statement, Abhay Karandikar, secretary at DST, said, "This is a landmark advancement in secure quantum communication." The milestone was achieved using indigenous technology developed by QNu Labs — a startup supported under the mission and focused on quantum-safe cybersecurity solutions.

The network is one of the longest quantum key distribution (QKD) deployments globally since the mission's launch in October 2024. PTI

WEST ASIA WAR IMPACT

Indian airlines' global business under stress

SURAJEET DAS GUPTA
New Delhi, 8 April

Even as Iran and the US have agreed to a ceasefire for the next two weeks, the West Asia conflict's huge impact on India's air carriers collectively can be gauged from the fact that as much as one-fifth of the total international flights flown by them between March 1 and March 31 got cancelled primarily because of dislocation of airports during the war.

According to the latest operating data by aviation analytics platform Cirium, Indian carriers cancelled 3,025 flights out of a total 15,984 international flights in March. The cancellations they were forced to make in the month was a staggering 13 times more than the previous month that witnessed only 228 flight routine cancellations.

Air India Express took the largest hit owing to its business being concentrated in West Asia. The Tata Group airline saw 1,215 flight cancellation in March — half of its total scheduled international flights. SpiceJet was also impacted as over 55 per cent of the carrier's international flights were cancelled. IndiGo's exposure to West Asia forced it to cancel nearly 10 per cent of 7,432 international flights scheduled in March. Air India also saw cancellations for 13 per cent of its total international flights in March compared with only 2 per cent cancellations in February.

Based on their schedule, India's top two air carriers, IndiGo and Air India Group, collectively, reduced their seat capacity by a substantial 313,000 seats in March over February between India and West Asia, according to Cirium data.

Broken wings

Carrier	Feb: Total scheduled flights	Feb: Flights cancelled	Mar: Total scheduled flights	Mar: Flights cancelled
IndiGo	8,207	44	7,431	724
Air India	4,697	86	4,910	659
Akasa	560	5	556	73
Air India Express	3,256	69	2,495	1,215
SpiceJet	643	24	622	354

Source: Cirium

Govt announces 25% cut in airport charges

Move will save airlines about ₹400 crore as jet fuel prices soar

DEEPAK PATEL
New Delhi, 8 April

The Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA) on Wednesday announced a 25 per cent cut in aircraft landing and parking charges for domestic flights for three months, a step expected to help airlines save about ₹400 crore during this period amid charges are revised at the end of each control period.

THE AIRPORTS ECONOMIC REGULATORY AUTHORITY OF INDIA WILL ADJUST ANY

Therefore, the MoCA's statement on Wednesday means that any under-recovery now will be recovered in the next control period instead of being passed on immediately.

The MoCA's decision about these charges has come as part of a broader increases and supporting both airlines and passengers. "This is a significant intervention to provide relief to airlines grappling with increasing operational costs," he said, noting that the government is in touch with airlines, airport operators and the regulator.

The order applies to all major airports regulated by AERA and to non-major airports operated by the state-run Airports Authority of India (AAI), with both catrising fuel costs.

The MoCA said the reduced charges will be implemented immediately, and the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA) will adjust any revenue shortfall faced by airports in future tariff cycles.

REVENUE SHORTFALL FACED BY AIRPORTS IN FUTURE TARIFF CYCLES

Typically, AERA sets airport tariffs — which includes aircraft landing and parking charges — for a five-year period, known as a control period.Once set, the airport operator can collect these fixed tariffs from all aircraft operators. These relief package for airlines grappling with multiple cost pressures, including higher Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) prices, depreciation of the rupee which raises dollar-denominated expenses such as leasing and maintenance, and the closure of sizeable parts of Gulf airspace due to the West Asia conflict, which has led to longer routes and higher operating costs.

Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu said the reduction in airport charges is aimed at containing airfare egories directed to implement a 25 per cent reduction for domestic flights for three months.

The MoCA's decision on Wednesday followed a series of developments since mid-March, when airlines began introducing fuel surcharges as ATF prices surged after the start of the West Asia conflict from February 28.

IndiGo on March 14 rolled out fuel charges across domestic and international routes, followed by Air India around the same time with surcharges on both segments.

Poonawalla-owned iconic Ravi Varma painting to be exhibited this weekend

Record-shattering artwork will be up for public viewing at AstaGuru's two-day exhibition in Mumbai

VEENU SANDHU
New Delhi, 8 April

Ten days after it set a record as the most expensive work of modern Indian art ever sold at auction, and the highest-bid South Asian artwork, Raja Ravi Varma's painting, *Yashoda and Krishna*, will be displayed for public viewing.

The painting's new owner, Serum Institute of India's founder Cyrus S Poonawalla, has offered the historic artwork to be exhibited at AstaGuru's two-day exhibition, ShowKeen, on April 11 and 12 at the Nehru Centre in Mumbai. The exhibition is being positioned as a rare opportunity for the public to view the artwork outside the private collection.

Cyrus S Poonawalla
Chairman & MD
Serum Institute of India

Yashoda and Krishna by Raja Ravi Varma
PHOTO COURTESY: ASTAGURU AUCTION HOUSE

The painting was recently acquired by Cyrus Poonawala and his son, the vaccine manufacturer's CEO Adar Poonawalla, for ₹167.2 crore, setting a new benchmark for modern Indian art. According to Cyrus Poonawalla, the painting is a national treasure and owning it is both an honour and a responsibility. According to a note by AstaGuru, Cyrus Poonawalla believes that given its historic importance, the painting deserves to be made available for public viewing, allowing a wider audience to experience its beauty and heritage.

Adar Poonawalla, incidentally, owns about a 20 per cent stake in AstaGuru.

The 1890s' work, executed at the peak of Raja Ravi Varma's career, is regarded as a defining example of his practice of merging classical Indian themes with the techniques of European academic painting. While his imagery is widely recognised through prints and reproductions, original canvases from his most productive years remain scarce and are seldom seen in public.

The artwork also holds significance as Varma is among India's nine designated "national treasure" (Navratna) artists, a classification that prohibits his works from being exported.

"Presenting this work at the ShowKeen exhibition offers audiences a rare opportunity to engage directly with one of the defining masterpieces of Indian art, and to experience the enduring impact of Ravi Varma's vision," said Manoj Mansukhani, director-Marketing of Mumbai-based auction house AstaGuru.

The display, AstaGuru said, offers viewers a chance to examine the nuances of the artist's brushwork, colour and composition at close quarters.

Entry to the exhibition is free and open to the public.